

UNA SANGRE



PROLOGUE

Present day. A city in Europe. Night.

THE RESTAURANT

(A restaurant on a cobblestone street. The kind of place people go to wash the day off. Cream-colored tablecloths. Ashtrays. Conversations that aren't ours.)

(At a back table, a young man. Dark suit, red tie, a glass of wine that's been sitting there longer than a sommelier would forgive. His hands are clasped over his mouth. He stares at something in the distance with the expression of someone watching the bottom of an aquarium.)

(What he's watching is a young couple at another table: the man is nervous in a very specific way. He checks his inside jacket pocket every few minutes. She hasn't noticed yet.)

NARRATION: You had to have a certain amount of practice to notice those things. People in love had that instinct atrophied.

(The phone of the man at the back table vibrates. He glances at it. Answers without taking his eyes off the couple.)

COLTRANE: Yes. I'm in the middle of something.

THE ALLEY

(The same night. Another continent. An alleyway somewhere in the Middle East. Stone walls, the smell of garbage baked by the heat of the day.)

(GLENN stands with the phone to his ear. He's wearing a photographer's vest and a camera slung around his neck that hasn't taken a single picture in its life. JUNO is beside him, with the calm of someone who has done this many times before.)

GLENN: Juno and I are going on a hunt. You in?

COLTRANE: *(on the phone)* I'd love to. But I'm tied up with something else, and I get the feeling you two aren't exactly next door.

GLENN: You'll be here before dawn.

COLTRANE: I'm more interested in seeing if this man is about to propose to Lauren. He's a doctor. He'd be a good catch.

GLENN: Lauren?

COLTRANE: One of my great-great-granddaughters. Fifth or sixth generation. I've lost count.

GLENN: Ah. Right. You sure I can't tempt you? I'd appreciate having someone with your linguistic talents on the hunt.

COLTRANE: What about your "boyfriend"?

GLENN: *(pause)* He's... a little rusty.

COLTRANE: *(covering his eyes with one hand)* That man. Really. Have fun and let me know how it

ends.

(Coltrane hangs up.)

BACK AT THE RESTAURANT

(Coltrane leaves the phone on the table. Looks at the couple again. The man is pulling something out of his jacket pocket.)

(Coltrane tilts his head slightly.)

COLTRANE: *(to himself, almost under his breath)* Here we go.

THE NEST

(A warehouse on the outskirts. The night is darker here. No restaurants, no cobblestones. Just brick walls and a dim light from an uncertain source.)

(Juno kills the first one without making a sound. She snaps his neck with the efficiency of someone closing a door.)

JUNO: We're close to the nest.

(Glenn examines the weapon the man was carrying. An old AK-47, well-maintained.)

GLENN: *(with something that isn't exactly nostalgia)* Ah, the memories.

JUNO: *(raising a hand like a claw)* No cheating. We do this the old-fashioned way. That's the fun part.

(Glenn drops the gun on the ground.)

GLENN: I know.

NARRATION: There were two of them. The rest were a crowd, at first. Then they were few. Then, none.

NARRATION: There were screams. Rifle bursts emptying in the wrong directions, because what was moving did so at a speed human arms found difficult to process. There were objects made of wood that shattered, and there were other things that gave way with a wet sound.

NARRATION: Then, a silence that didn't come all at once, but from exhaustion of the materials. When the last sound died, the warehouse air kept vibrating for a few more seconds, as if the building's architecture was struggling to digest what it had just contained.

NARRATION: Two were left standing.

THE AFTERMATH

(Glenn and Juno sitting against the wall. Covered in blood that isn't theirs, with holes in their flesh that are already closing on their own. Juno has the expression of someone who just finished a good book.)

JUNO: Ah. Much better. It's a shame we can't do this more often.

(Glenn nods. But his gaze is fixed on somewhere other than the alley.)

(Juno notices. Doesn't say anything. Not yet.)

(Glenn gets up. He starts pouring gasoline over the floor and the bodies. Juno stops him with a gesture.)

JUNO: Wait. There's one left. I can hear him.

(Glenn complies. He focuses his senses. Among the bodies, a man breathes in a way too controlled to be dead.)

JUNO: There.

(The man panics. He starts screaming in a language neither of them ever bothered to learn well enough.)

(Juno is about to act when the man pulls something from inside his jacket. A crumpled Polaroid photo. Two little girls.)

(Glenn sees it. He freezes. He takes it and looks at it.)

NARRATION: For a moment, the terrified man didn't exist. Juno didn't exist, watching him from three feet away with the slightly impatient curiosity of someone who knows what's going to happen but not in what order. There were only two girls in a photo that someone carried with them for a reason.

DECISION 1

A) Glenn keeps the photo. He folds it carefully. Puts it in his inside jacket pocket. He doesn't say a word.

B) Glenn drops it. He looks at it for a moment longer. Releases it with resignation. The photo falls to the ground. He doesn't pick it up.

(Before Glenn can react to what he just decided, Juno finishes off the man. She turns to him).

JUNO: What's wrong with you? Do you think none of the others had families? That the hundreds we've killed before didn't either? *(She kicks the body, without conviction).* What a waste. We did his family a favor.

(Glenn doesn't answer. Juno continues.)

JUNO: I can't stand what "Goldilocks" is turning you into. He's made you soft.

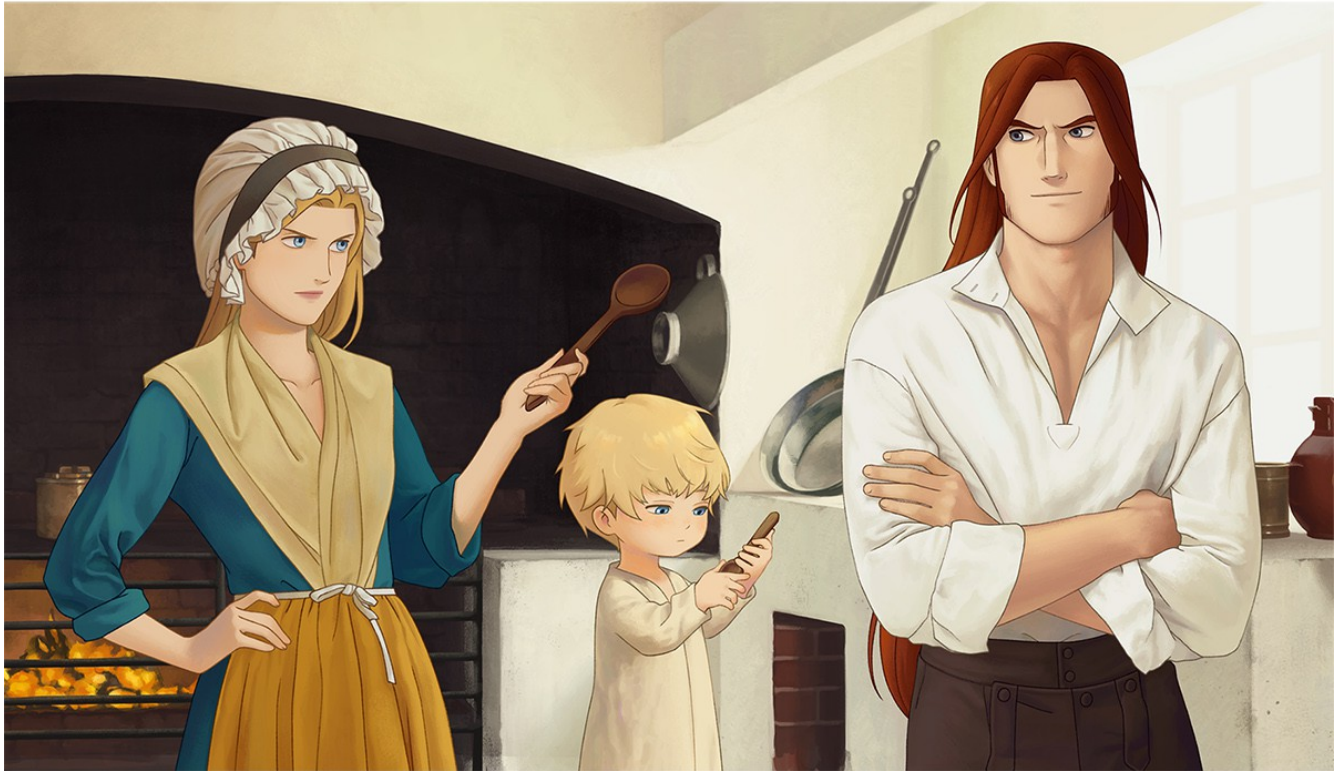
(She puts the gasoline canister into Glenn's hands.)

JUNO: Finish the job. We're done here.

(Glenn does as she asks.)

(They walk away while the nest burns behind them.)

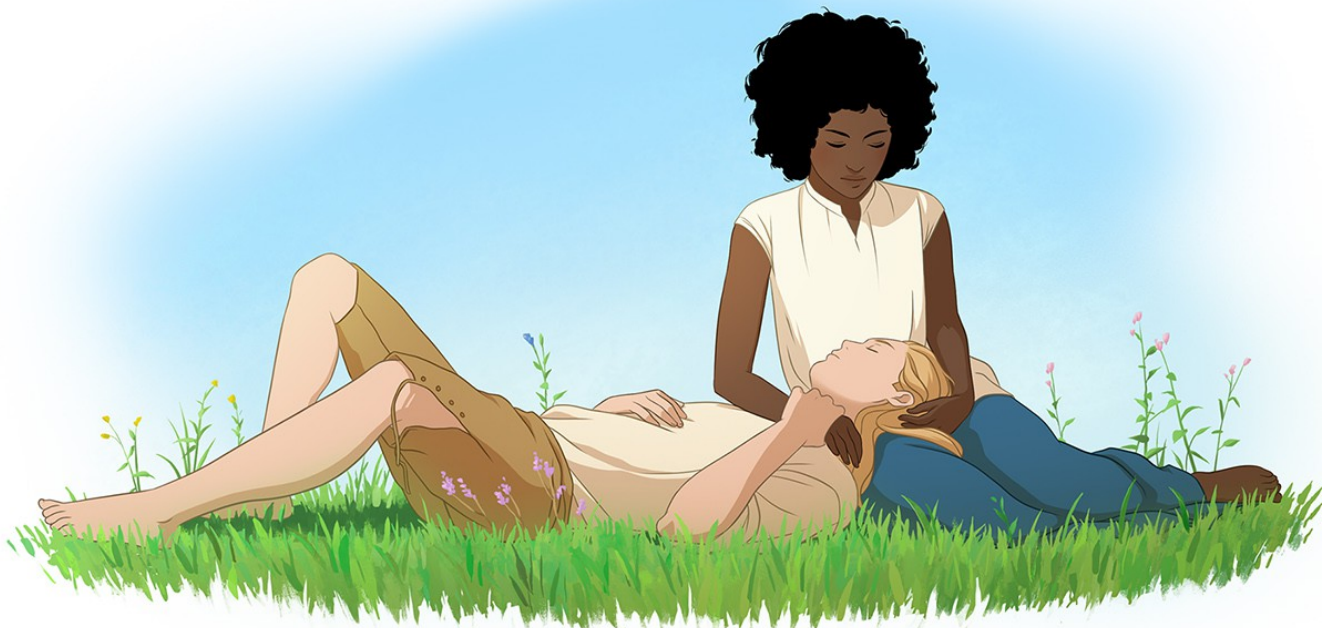
JUNO: *(almost casually)* Oh. And for what it's worth: I win.



DIANA

JOHANNES

HUMAN GLENN

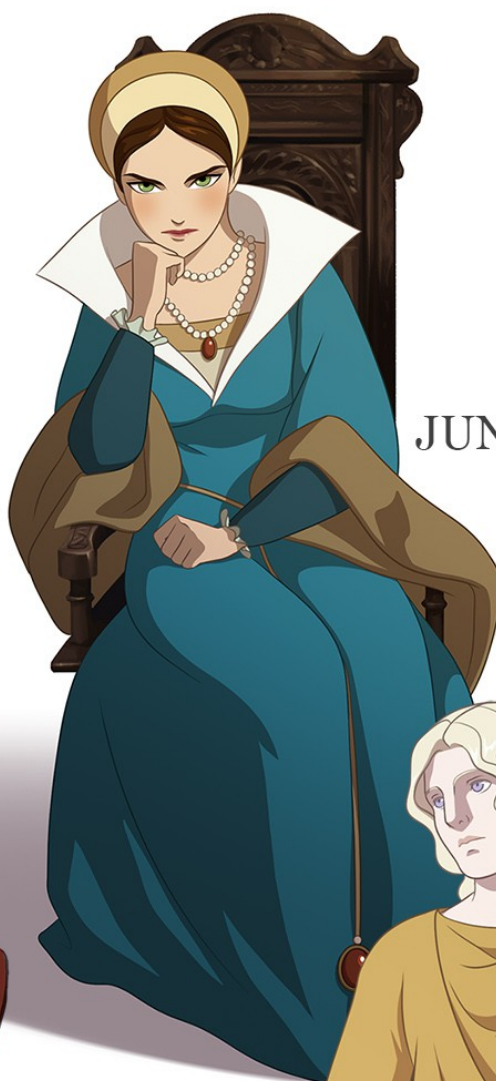


COLTRANE

ANNIE



PAUL



JUNO



IMMORTAL
GLENN



AISON

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The man he was. Virginia. 1764. Irish District, Richmond.

QUICK CUT — THE TAVERN

(The tavern smells of wet sawdust, old sweat, and cheap whiskey. GLENN is at a table in the back, one hand resting on the dice and the other around a tankard that's been empty for a while. He laughs before the joke is finished. Throws the dice. Loses. Laughs again.)

NARRATION: Thirty-five years old. A wife. A son. Not a shilling to his name. He had the gift of the gab and the curse of the wager. Any man in his position would be home.

(Glenn looks at the empty tankard for a moment. Signals the barkeep with two fingers, in no hurry.)

NARRATION: A man entirely at ease with his own disaster, surrounded by people who admired and envied him in equal measure. People in the district said he carried himself like a nobleman, and that his charm was his only title. But underneath all that, he was nothing but an Irish farmer with a talent for avoiding good sense.

(The barkeep brings another tankard before Glenn has paid for the last one. Glenn raises it toward him in thanks. The barkeep makes a face that isn't quite a reprimand.)

THOM, a parishioner in his fifties, poorly shaved, already well into his cups, leans in with a conspiratorial nudge.

THOM: Sheridan, I saw you coming out of Baxter's studio yesterday.

GLENN: *(without looking up, arranging the dice)* Then your eyes are failing you, Thom. I was home yesterday.

THOM: *(laughing)* Sure you were. And I was made Archbishop.

GLENN: *(raising the fresh tankard)* Bless me, Your Grace.

Thom lets out a deep laugh. Glenn smiles, but the smile doesn't reach his eyes. Throws the dice. Loses again.

THOM: And what, pray tell, does Baxter have you making? Another Madonna?

GLENN: Baxter doesn't commission me anything. I go to make sure he doesn't ruin his own canvases. Call it Christian charity.

THOM: Dropping by with your brushes, of course.

GLENN: Dropping by with whatever's needed.

Thom laughs again. Glenn doesn't clarify. Glenn never clarifies.

NARRATION: He painted the models Baxter sent his way when it wasn't the master's turn. Painted them without charge, which irritated Baxter, who always charged. Glenn said it was practice. Said it was a favor. Said anything except what it actually was — which, to be fair, he hadn't entirely figured out himself.

A younger regular, NED, who's been listening from the next table for a while, turns to Glenn with the smile of someone who hasn't grown tired of him yet.

NED: Sheridan, tell Thom about the Dutch captain.

GLENN: *(without enthusiasm, like a man who's told the story twenty times)* Again?

NED: Thom hasn't heard it.

THOM: I didn't hear it.

(Glenn sets down the dice. He leans back in his chair. The shift in posture is minimal, but the other two men go quiet. Glenn knows exactly how to buy the silence of a room.)

GLENN: Right. There was a Dutch captain. Fat. Drunk the way only a Calvinist can be when he's far from his congregation. He swears to me, on his mother's soul (and in Dutch, to top it all off) that he had a shipment of Chinese silk held at customs and that he needed someone trustworthy to watch over it for one night.

THOM: And you were someone trustworthy?

GLENN: That night, yes. *(Pause.)* Here's what matters. I say: Captain, I'll watch your silk. But my religion forbids me from guarding anything I haven't touched.

(Anticipatory laughter. Glenn lets it run.)

GLENN: He takes me to the dock. Shows me a crate. I say: Captain, this is linen.

THOM: Was it linen?

GLENN: It was hemp! The worst quality. But the captain wasn't offended. The poor bastard had spent the whole day trying to swindle someone, and when he discovered that I was the only wretched soul who could tell hemp from silk at two in the morning, he was so moved he invited me to drink.

THOM: And you did?

GLENN: Until dawn. Until the captain, weeping, confessed that the crate belonged to his wife, that he had no shipment, and that he only wanted company.

(Glenn raises his tankard.)

GLENN: And that, gentlemen, is why I still have the financial standing of a stray dog. But I made myself a Dutch friend.

(Thom slaps the table with his palm. Ned laughs as though hearing it for the first time, though he was the one who asked for it. Glenn drinks, watching over the rim of his tankard, utterly expressionless.)

NARRATION: The anecdote was absurd. Half of it was false and the other half had never happened at all. But just as he did with other stories, he had polished it until it became a functional truth. His companions at the table knew he was lying, but they had silently agreed that the lie was better than their own lives, so they bankrolled it with beer.

NARRATION: That was his gift: lying so transparently that people chose to forgive him. It was the only gift Glenn had cultivated with any discipline. It had saved his life more times than he could remember. And it had cost him more than he was willing to count.

(A BARMAID passes quickly. Glenn doesn't look at her, but he trails his fingers along the hem of her apron as she goes by. An imperceptible graze. She turns to look at him a second too long. He is already looking at Thom.)

THOM: *(lowering his voice, searching for the wound)* Say, Sheridan. Your wife.

GLENN: *(the smile freezes for a fraction of a second)* What about her.

THOM: When do you plan on going back home.

(Brief pause. Glenn runs his thumb over the dice. Doesn't throw them. Something in his face rearranges without quite moving.)

GLENN: Diana knows perfectly well where I am, Thom.

THOM: Does that mean you're going back?

GLENN: It means she knows where I am.

(Thom laughs, but it's an uneasy laugh. Glenn holds his gaze until the other man looks away. He throws the dice.)

NARRATION: Diana knew where he was. Diana always knew where he was. That was one of the things Glenn had learned not to examine too closely: that his wife, having that information, chose not to come looking for him. The edge of the obvious was something he preferred to sidestep at this hour of the night.

NED: And the boy? Is he walking yet? How old is he?

GLENN: *(without looking at Ned)* Two years old. Walks and stares at you, like he's reading your mind.

THOM: Children don't do that.

GLENN: Mine does. He looks at you and you feel like you owe him money.

(Pause.)

GLENN: Must be a phase.

(Glenn finally throws the dice. They skid off the board. He loses. The defeat no longer draws a laugh from him, only half a smile.)

NARRATION: Glenn was joking, but the discomfort was real. Johannes looked at him with a gravity that had no business belonging to a two-year-old. He looked at him the way a man reads a document that doesn't quite add up. Glenn had learned to barely meet his eyes.

(Visual: The background, the characters, shift color for a moment. Everything turns a few shades cooler and more desaturated. The murmur of the tavern dims by a fraction. Then everything returns to normal.)

NARRATION: All at once, Glenn feels a chill, for no reason. A savage drop in temperature at the base of his skull. He blamed it on the smoke, the fatigue, the cold seeping in through some crack. He glanced at the door. The door was closed. He went back to the dice.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The feeling stayed a moment longer than it should have. Like when you think you've heard your name called in a room where no one knows you.

(Glenn sets the dice down on the table. He stares at his tankard. Doesn't lift it. The noise of the tavern continues, but he seems to have come unplugged.)

NARRATION: There is a stretch of the night, in every tavern, when the man doing the entertaining stops entertaining. It doesn't last long. It lasts as long as it takes any given patron to turn his head. If someone had seen him in that second, they would have seen a man alone. But at that hour, in that place, no one sees anything out of the ordinary.

NED: *(from somewhere distant, muffled)* Sheridan? Are you throwing or not?

(The second closes. Glenn blinks. Smiles. The smile works.)

GLENN: *(picking up the dice)* You throw, Ned. Tonight luck belongs to fools, so you've got the advantage.

(Everyone laughs again. Thom raises his tankard.)

THOM: To the Dutch captain.

GLENN: To the Dutch captain.

NARRATION: The table toasted. Glenn toasted with them. His hand was as steady as ever.

(SLOW FADE.)

NARRATION: That night, as every night, Glenn left the tavern through the back door without saying goodbye to anyone. He knew his absence would not stop the party.

NARRATION: That night, however, someone took note of his absence. Someone who was not inside the tavern.

(SLOW FADE.)

QUICK CUT — THE MONEYLENDER

(A narrow shop, walls with wallpaper that has seen better days. Behind a counter, a heavysset man with spectacles. His eyes have no color: they have the absence of color that develops in men who have heard every excuse in Richmond.)

(Glenn on the other side of the counter. Hat in hand. Glenn's smile.)

GLENN: Morgan! Dear friend!

MORGAN: *(without looking up)* No.

GLENN: I haven't said anything yet.

MORGAN: No need.

(Glenn leans his elbows on the counter, invading exactly the right amount of space. Morgan keeps writing.)

GLENN: Two pounds. Until Friday.

MORGAN: No.

GLENN: Friday. I swear it on my mother's soul.

MORGAN: Your mother died twelve years ago, Sheridan.

GLENN: *(pause)* Precisely. That makes it a serious oath.

(Morgan looks up. He stares at him for a long moment. He sighs in a way that says he has lost this argument many times before and has already made his peace with the personal arithmetic of giving in again.)

(He opens a drawer. Counts the coins.)

MORGAN: Friday.

GLENN: Your Highness.

MORGAN: Out.

(Glenn takes the coins. Puts on his hat and leaves whistling.)

NARRATION: Morgan never saw the money again. No moneylender in the Irish district ever did. But they gave it to him anyway. He had been financing him for years and no one had ever managed to explain why: Glenn included. For some reason that exceeded common sense, they felt that saying no to that man would mean losing something more important than two pounds.

QUICK CUT — THE STUDIO

(The makeshift studio smells of linseed oil and turpentine. The afternoon light comes through a small window. GLENN stands before a small canvas, his shirt stained and his hair pulled back any which way.)

(The model, a middle-aged woman who was weary of being alive, sits posing in a chair.)

(He doesn't look at her. He looks at the canvas. He has transformed her into something ethereal, almost divine.)

NARRATION: As a husband he was an absence; as a father, a rumor. But with a brush in his hand, Glenn Sheridan was an exceptional liar. He could see beauty in the rot. He deceived himself into believing that documenting beauty absolved him of his inability to live it.

(The model yawns. Glenn smiles without taking his eyes from the canvas.)

GLENN: *(without looking at her)* You can move. I'm done with your face.

MODEL: And the rest?

GLENN: The rest I make up.

(The model laughs: a short, dry, tired laugh. She stands. Stretches. Looks at the canvas out of curiosity, the way they all do.)

(She keeps looking.)

MODEL: *(quietly)* Mr. Sheridan.

GLENN: Mm?

MODEL: This isn't me.

GLENN: *(cleaning the brush)* It's a version of you.

MODEL: A version I don't recognize.

GLENN: Well. Now you do.

(She looks at him a moment longer. Says nothing. Gets dressed and leaves.)

NARRATION: He never charged for these paintings. It was his only honest transaction. He made them for no reason. Every model left a little different from how she had arrived, though she couldn't have explained exactly in what sense. Glenn couldn't have explained it either. He wasn't entirely sure himself what he was trying to accomplish. He only knew it was the one thing he did without calculating what he might get in return.

QUICK CUT — THE KITCHEN

(The kitchen. Early morning. DIANA stands with her back turned, stirring something over the fire.

JOHANNES: two years old, fair-haired, with a gravity unbecoming his age, already having decided the

world doesn't deserve too much of his attention, sits on the floor with a wooden spoon he is examining as though it were an archaeological artifact.)

(Glenn appears. He is wearing the same clothes as yesterday. Diana doesn't turn around.)

DIANA: Did you bring anything to eat? Or did you gamble our future to the bottom of a bottle again?

GLENN: Good morning to you too.

DIANA: Did you win anything?

(Glenn thinks about it. Then smiles.)

GLENN: I won time. That counts.

(Diana finally turns around. She looks him up and down with that expression of hers that is not exactly anger, nor resignation. Something in between that Glenn has spent years unable to decipher.)

DIANA: Eat. Get changed. And this afternoon you fix the stable door.

GLENN: *(sitting down)* And if I fix two doors? Will you give me something in return?

DIANA: No. But you'll have the satisfaction of having done it.

(Glenn laughs. Diana turns back to the fire, but at the corner of her mouth there is something that doesn't quite become a smile and doesn't want to be anything else.)

NARRATION: That was how they were. He pushed and she didn't give. And in that tension the two of them lived rather well.

(Johannes looks up from the floor and watches his father with blue eyes that seem to be judging his soul. As though he knows his father is a fraud. As though he knows he doesn't deserve the air he breathes.)

(Glenn looks at him for a moment, lowering his voice, speaking only to him:)

GLENN: What are you looking at?

(Johannes doesn't answer. Goes back to the spoon.)

NARRATION: The boy never talked much. Glenn said he had inherited Diana's temperament. Diana said he had inherited Glenn's. They were probably both right.

(Glenn eats. Diana doesn't sit down: it's a habit she has. She eats standing, or afterward, or not at all. Glenn has noticed. He has never asked.)

QUICK CUT — THE STABLE DOOR

(Afternoon. Glenn is attempting to fix the stable door. He does it badly, but invests just enough effort to make it look, from a distance, like he is trying.)

(Diana watches from behind, arms crossed.)

DIANA: It's coming out crooked.

GLENN: It's fine.

DIANA: Glenn.

GLENN: *(without turning)* It's fine as it is. It's rustic. Gives it character.

DIANA: Character.

(Brief pause.)

GLENN: Soul.

(Diana sighs. She steps forward. Takes the hammer from his hands with the efficiency of someone who has done this before. Glenn steps aside. Watches her work. She straightens the hinge in half the time it took him to bend it.)

NARRATION: That was when he remembered why he loved her.

DIANA: Done.

GLENN: Came out perfect.

DIANA: Do me a favor and leave.

GLENN: *(with a disarming smile)* I'm leaving.

(Glenn walks away. Before rounding the corner, he turns and looks at her. She doesn't see him: she is putting the tools away.)

NARRATION: There were moments like this, brief ones, when Glenn wondered what his life would have been without her. He didn't like the answer that was beginning to form. He buried it quickly, turned around, and went to the tavern.

QUICK CUT — THE DIRT ROAD

(Night. Glenn walks alone down the path leading away from the district. He is in no hurry. He stops in front of a puddle of mud and stagnant water. He looks at his reflection for a moment: red hair, broad shoulders, the expression of someone who doesn't know exactly what he's looking for but is reasonably sure he'll recognize it when he sees it.)

NARRATION: He was not unhappy. That was the most honest thing that could be said of him. But sometimes, on nights like that one, the hangover left him with the feeling that his life was a vast canvas missing its subject at the center.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: And the universe, as Glenn was about to discover, abhors a vacuum.

(He reaches the bend in the path, where the trees swallow the moonlight. And there, in the darkness, stands a woman who was not there before.)

(SLOW FADE.)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The encounter with Juno. *Virginia. 1764. Irish District, Richmond. Night.*

QUICK CUT — THE DIRT ROAD

NARRATION: Another wasted night. He had lost what little he'd had in his pockets. He left the tavern through the back door, looking for the dirt path that cut through the woods toward home.

(Background: A dark dirt road. Trees on either side. Scant light, only moonlight filtering through the

branches.)

(Glenn walks alone. The cold is dry. His boots creak over dead leaves, making too much noise for the vastness of the silence surrounding him.)

NARRATION: He had drunk less than usual. That he knew. What he didn't know was why the forest seemed to have changed its dimensions tonight.

(He stops. Looks ahead.)

(At a bend in the road, beneath an old oak that marked the boundary of a property, there was a figure. A woman. Still, as though she had been standing there long enough for the wood itself to consider claiming her.)

(Cut to: Juno's figure in the darkness. White skin, dark dress. The texture of the background shifts subtly: the night seems to thicken, the moonlight turns clinical, stagnant.)

(Glenn blinks.)

(She is still there.)

NARRATION: The first thing he thought was that she was a prostitute. The second, that she was not. Both thoughts arrived simultaneously and the second won without the first knowing why.

(The woman doesn't move. But Glenn feels, with a certainty that has no rational explanation, that she is looking directly at him. That she has been looking at him from before.)

(Glenn takes a step. Then another.)

NARRATION: Each step cost him more than it should have, as though the ground were transfiguring beneath him. Like those dreams where you run and never arrive anywhere.

(When he finally has her a few feet away, he sees her face.)

NARRATION: Black hair. Skin of a whiteness that hurt to look at. Eyes that did not have the right color to be real.

(Glenn is not a man whose hands tremble. Tonight they tremble a little.)

JUNO: You've been walking in circles for a while now.

(The voice is not entirely a voice. Or it is, but it arrives through a different channel. Glenn feels the words more at his temple than in his ears.)

GLENN: *(by reflex, his voice rough)* Forgive me: I haven't any money. I was just heading home.

JUNO: That's not where you want to go.

(Silence. Only the wind in the branches, which suddenly sounds too loud. Glenn is not certain what it is he feels.)

GLENN: Do I know you?

JUNO: No.

GLENN: Should I?

(Juno looks at him for a moment. Something in her expression suggests that the question strikes her as, if not interesting, at least marginally less tedious than those of the preceding centuries.)

JUNO: That depends on you.

(Long pause. The background remains the same. Or it no longer matters whether it changed.)

NARRATION: Afterward, Glenn could not say with any certainty how long he stood there. He remembered her voice. He remembered the cold that came from her without her touching him at all: a cold that belonged to no body that was alive. He remembered thinking: this is a dream. But that didn't matter.

(A whisper at his ear, almost imperceptible. As though she had always been that close.)

JUNO: I am the queen of your dreams.

(Glenn doesn't move.)

(Neither does she.)

NARRATION: Nothing happened that first night. She held his gaze a moment longer, turned, and left. She walked until she disappeared. Glenn stayed where he was.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: When he finally persuaded his legs to obey him and reached his house, he realized he had no memory of the journey. Only of the tree.

QUICK CUT — THE FOUR NIGHTS

NARRATION: The first night Glenn told himself it had been the drink. An elaborate hallucination. He'd had them before. He went to bed certain he wouldn't remember it by morning.

NARRATION: By morning he remembered.

(Image: The bedroom in darkness. Glenn in bed, eyes wide open, staring at the ceiling beams. Diana sleeps beside him, her back to him. Johannes breathes between them.)

NARRATION: He was lying in his own bed, with his own family, but he already inhabited the space with the lightness of someone who doesn't belong there.

NARRATION: The second night he returned to the edge of the forest. He told himself he was going to confirm there was no one there, that beneath the tree there were only roots, that what had happened the night before had been the delirium of a tired man. It would be quick. Just to make sure.

(Image: The dirt road. Glenn standing before the old oak. No one there. Only the wind moving the dead branches, and the cold.)

NARRATION: He stayed longer than reason dictated. Half an hour. Perhaps an hour. The road remained empty, and he did not leave.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: He went home at dawn. Having done nothing. Having seen nothing. And yet he returned feeling infinitely worse than if he had found her.

(Image: Glenn entering the kitchen in the first light of dawn. Diana is awake, standing by the stove. She says nothing. Glenn passes her without looking. Goes upstairs to bed.)

NARRATION: The third night he tried to resist. He stayed at the tavern with the firm intention of drinking himself past the use of his legs. He managed it. By two in the morning the whiskey had clouded his vision, but he could still walk.

NARRATION: And toward the forest he walked.

(Image: The oak, empty. Again.)

NARRATION: This time he let himself sink to the ground, his back against the bark. He waited, without knowing exactly what for.

NARRATION: It was there that he began to understand what he had been refusing to understand. She was not the problem. If she had been there, it would have been bearable. Words might have passed between them, or not. Something might have happened, or not. But there would have been a closing. What was destroying him was this: the empty tree. The possibility that she had never existed. The possibility, worse still, that she had.

(Image: The makeshift studio. Glenn before the half-finished canvas of the middle-aged woman. The brush, completely dry on the palette. He stares at the canvas, inert. An hour like that. Two. The canvas unchanged.)

NARRATION: He stopped painting without deciding to. Stopped eating without noticing. Stopped speaking to Diana at some point he couldn't locate afterward. He began to move through the house like a man passing through his own life.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The worst part was the uncertainty. Had he known she was real, he would have felt dread. Had he known she was not, he would have felt shame. What was eroding him from the inside was his inability to assign the experience either word.

NARRATION: The fourth night he went to the path without telling himself any story. He did not tell himself he was going to confirm anything. He did not drink beforehand. He did not forbid himself from going. He left his house the way a man leaves for work.

NARRATION: He would return to that tree every night for the rest of his life if it came to that. He had accepted it that same afternoon, without drama, the way a man accepts the diagnosis of a chronic illness.

(Image: The dirt road. Glenn leans against the oak. He lets himself slide down until he is sitting on the damp earth. No particular expectation. His gaze adrift ahead of him.)

(Pause.)

NARRATION: He did not know how long he stayed like that. But when he finally looked up, she was there.

(FADE.)

QUICK CUT — THE KITCHEN

(Midday. Glenn is sitting at the table. In front of him is a plate with a piece of pork he has barely touched. Diana watches him from the other side of the room. She has that expression of hers: the one a physician wears when he already knows the diagnosis but waits for the patient to speak first.)

DIANA: It's been four days since you've painted any of your usual indecencies.

GLENN: I'm thinking.

DIANA: About what?

(It is not a question. Glenn knows it.)

GLENN: Nothing important.

(Diana doesn't answer. She picks up the plate. Says, with her back to him, in that voice of hers that never rises but always reaches the bone:)

DIANA: Glenn. You don't know how to lie.

(Glenn doesn't defend himself. He looks out the window. Outside, Johannes sits on the ground of the yard examining a stone with the same concentration another child would give a treasure.)

NARRATION: Diana did not press him. Not because she didn't want to know, but because at this stage of their marriage she already knew enough. What remained for her to know was precisely the kind of detail she would rather not have confirmed. She had learned the hard way that, with a man like Glenn, asking certain questions only served to have the answer pull the floor out from under you.

(Glenn watches her back for a moment. Opens his mouth. Closes it.)

(He stands from the table, dragging the chair. Leaves the kitchen by the back door.)

NARRATION: That was going to be the last time Glenn Sheridan shared a meal in that house. Neither of them knew it yet, but when he crossed the threshold, Diana stood motionless for a moment too long, looking at the plate. As though there were something there to be understood.

QUICK CUT — THAT NIGHT

(Background: The dirt road beneath the old oak. Pitch darkness, only the silhouettes of the trees.)

(Glenn rounds the bend in the road without pretending he is going anywhere else.)

(She is there.)

JUNO: *(without moving, her voice arriving like an echo from somewhere behind his eyes)* I knew you'd come back.

(Glenn stops two paces away. This time there is no ambiguity in the cold she radiates, nor in the way she looks at him: as though she had already decided something about him and the rest were mere procedure.)

GLENN: What are you?

JUNO: Whatever you need me to be.

GLENN: That isn't an answer.

JUNO: No. But it is the only one I'm going to give you tonight.

(Juno takes a step toward him. Glenn doesn't move back.)

NARRATION: He had a strange, very brief moment of lucidity. He thought of Diana. He thought of Johannes with his stone. He thought that he ought to go home. The three thoughts arrived at once, and he dismissed all three with the same ease with which he had dismissed thousands of good things over the course of his life.

(The surroundings dissolve into absolute blackness, erasing the forest.)

NARRATION: There was a flash. A pain that was not physical, but a reconfiguration of consciousness. He thought he saw something in the gloom. Sharp teeth, the gleam of something that did not belong to this world.

NARRATION: After that, he thought of nothing else.

(FADE TO BLACK.)

QUICK CUT — THE AWAKENING

NARRATION: When he woke, it was different. He was different. The world too.

(Close-up: Glenn's eyes opening all at once.)

NARRATION: The light of dawn struck him as offensive in a way he could not remember having known. The world sounded too loud, too bright, too alive. He did not understand the nature of the agony that gripped his viscera. He only knew that the hunger devouring him from within was a new thing: an entity in its own right, bearing the name of a woman.

(END OF SCENE.)

CAPÍTULO 1 — GLENN

Intermezzo. *Virginia. 1764—1780.*

NARRATION: The first thing was the noise.

(The sound begins muffled, with a low-pass filter, as though submerged in water. All at once, the filter cuts off. The sound rushes in: sharp, manifold, invasive.)

NARRATION: Glenn had not known the world sounded like this. That his own blood, pushed through his veins, had the volume of a conversation half a meter away. That the wood of houses creaked at night as if splitting apart. That insects did not hum: they screamed, all at once, in an unintelligible tongue.

NARRATION: It was an avalanche. The first nights he covered his ears. It served no purpose. The noise was not in the room: it was in his head.

(Juno watches him from a corner of the chamber. She does not laugh. The mockery will come months later. At the beginning, she only waits, with patience.)

JUNO: It passes.

GLENN: When?

JUNO: When it has to.

NARRATION: She did not explain about the hunger. Perhaps she assumed it was obvious. Perhaps she forgot, the same way one forgets to explain to someone how to breathe. It took Glenn three days to understand what that knot in his stomach was, the one that bore no resemblance to human hunger.

NARRATION: By the time he understood, it was already too late.

QUICK CUT — ANY GIVEN NIGHT

(An alley. Walls of dirty brick. A man sprawled on the ground. Glenn stands, staring at his hands. Juno two paces away, wiping the corner of her mouth with her thumb.)

JUNO: Better?

(Glenn doesn't answer. He looks at the man on the ground. Looks at his own hands. Looks back at the man.)

JUNO: You get used to it.

GLENN: I don't want to get used to it.

JUNO: Then you'll suffer a great deal.

(Glenn retches. His body folds in on itself, trying to expel something, but the stomach has already absorbed the blood and refuses to give it back. Juno watches him with an expression that, in another woman, would pass for tenderness.)

JUNO: Give it time.

NARRATION: That was how it happened.

QUICK CUT — THE HOUSE

NARRATION: What no one had warned him (because Juno had not considered it necessary, or because she had stopped caring centuries ago) was that the hunger does not distinguish. That someone recently turned lacks the filters one develops over the centuries. That the people you love taste exactly the same as a stranger in an alley.

NARRATION: It took Glenn several days to understand why he could not approach his own door.

(A familiar street. Glenn stops half a block away. The window of his house is lit. Diana moves behind the glass, doing something that cannot be made out from outside.)

(Glenn closes his eyes. Breathes.)

NARRATION: He can smell them. He can hear their hearts. Diana's, steady. Johannes's, faster, smaller.

NARRATION: Two heartbeats. That was how his new nature reduced them. They were not a wife and a son. They were two sounds inside a house.

(Glenn clenches his jaw. He does not move forward. He does not leave.)

NARRATION: He thought, with a clarity that disgusted him, that he had never loved them as much as in that moment. And that he was never going to be able to tell them.

NARRATION: He stayed a while longer. Then he left.

NARRATION: He returned the following night. And the one after that.

NARRATION: The pattern repeated itself. Glenn in the darkness, outside. The window lit, inside. Each night he stopped a meter farther away, as though he were learning to calculate the precise distance at which the hunger still permitted him to keep his sanity.

(On one of those nights, Juno appears beside him. He has not heard her arrive. The hand she places on his shoulder feels like a cold stone.)

JUNO: You know you can't go in.

GLENN: I know.

JUNO: And you know you can't keep doing this either.

(Glenn doesn't answer. Juno doesn't press him. It is, perhaps, the most generous gesture we will see from her for a long time to come. She leaves him there a moment longer and then walks away down the street.)

(Glenn looks at the window. Inside, Johannes, with the clumsy gait of a two-year-old, stumbles and falls. The cry arrives muffled by the glass. Diana steps into the frame, picks him up, comforts him.)

(He closes his eyes.)

NARRATION: He did not go in.

NARRATION: He told himself this was the hard choice. That he deserved some credit for having stayed outside. But he knew, in the one human corner he had left, that this was not a sacrifice. It was cowardice dressed as whatever else would let him feel less wretched.

NARRATION: He left at dawn. He left nothing behind. Not a note, not a message. He did not seek out any mutual acquaintance.

NARRATION: He told himself that, for them, it was better this way: as though he had died. People bury their dead and move on. Diana was young and could find another. And Johannes was not going to remember him.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: That last part was true. He would not remember.

QUICK CUT — EUROPE

NARRATION: Juno took him far away. She said he needed to see the world. That there was nothing worse for a fledgling than to remain near where he had been human.

NARRATION: In that, she was right.

(A room somewhere in Europe. Impersonal luxury, the kind of luxury one rents by the season. Juno undressed on the bed, leafing through a book in a language Glenn does not understand. Glenn at the window, his back to her, looking down at the street.)

JUNO: You're going to be like that all night.

GLENN: No.

JUNO: Yes.

(Glenn doesn't turn.)

JUNO: It's tedious, Glenn. You've been like this for weeks.

GLENN: How many?

JUNO: I don't know. Does it matter?

NARRATION: Glenn tried to calculate it. He realized no number came to him. And that was what was disturbing.

NARRATION: Time had begun to behave strangely. At first he tried to keep count. Then he gave up. Days and nights blurred together because only the nights existed, and every night was the same. A week in one city. Three in another. Months passing without anyone bothering to name them.

(Glenn finally turns toward Juno. She closes the book.)

JUNO: Come here.

GLENN: What for?

JUNO: What does it matter. It's all the same.

NARRATION: That was also true.

QUICK CUT — A PORTRAIT

NARRATION: There was something he did sometimes, when she was not there. Something he had not planned the first time he did it, and which, upon seeing it finished, produced in him a sensation closely resembling fear.

(A different room. Another city. Glenn before an easel. Candlelight, faint. On the canvas, a fair-haired woman with a serious expression and pale blue eyes.)

NARRATION: It was not Juno.

(Glenn stays looking at her for a long while. Then he covers the canvas with a cloth.)

NARRATION: He painted her from memory. And each time he did, memory corrected itself. He knew the more recent versions were less her. That he was painting the memory of a memory. That soon he would be painting something that was no longer Diana, but the idea he held of Diana: two very different things.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: He kept painting her anyway.

(He hides the canvas in a dark corner, where Juno will not find it.)

NARRATION: That small act of privacy was the only thing left that was truly his.

QUICK CUT — AN ARGUMENT WITHOUT VOLUME

(Another room. Another continent, probably. Juno on her feet, gesturing. Glenn seated, elbows on his knees, head bowed.)

NARRATION: We do not hear what they say. The distance is exactly enough to deny us the content, only the gestures. The body language of two people who no longer have anything new to say to each other and who, nevertheless, keep talking.

(Juno, eventually, falls silent. She leaves the room. Glenn does not lift his head.)

NARRATION: They fought over things they would forget by the next day. Juno said Glenn had changed. Glenn said Juno had never been what he thought she was. Both were right, and both knew that being right served no purpose.

NARRATION: There was a question Glenn never asked her: why she had chosen him. He suspected the answer was disappointing, and he preferred not to confirm it. He suspected, for example, that it had been out of boredom. Or because of the color of his hair. Or anything equally arbitrary.

NARRATION: Spending eternity as the result of a whim was something one could live with, so long as one did not know it with absolute certainty.

QUICK CUT — A HUNT

NARRATION: He learned to hunt with Juno. Not because he wanted to, but because there was no other option.

(An alley in shadow. A man on the ground. Glenn standing beside him. The man is around fifty. He wears a wedding ring. His face has an expression Glenn knows intimately: that of a man who has just lost money he did not have, rehearsing, on his way home, the lie he will tell his wife.)

NARRATION: Glenn kills him. Quickly. Without ceremony.

(Juno watches from the mouth of the alley.)

JUNO: Good. You're improving.

(Glenn does not move.)

JUNO: Let's go.

GLENN: He had a wife.

JUNO: *(with a half-smile, cynical)* They all have a wife.

GLENN: With children, perhaps.

JUNO: Yes, perhaps.

(Glenn looks at her.)

GLENN: Do you feel nothing?

NARRATION: Juno took a second to consider it. It was one of the few moments in which Glenn could see her actually thinking.

JUNO: At first, yes. Not anymore.

GLENN: How did you do it?

JUNO: Do what?

GLENN: Stop feeling it.

(Juno closes the distance. She places a hand on his cheek, cold, as always.)

JUNO: One does not stop feeling. What you feel simply wears down. Like everything.

GLENN: How long does it take?

JUNO: It depends.

GLENN: On what?

JUNO: On how much you resist.

(Glenn turns his face away. Juno lets her hand fall.)

NARRATION: She was right. It wore down. The first time had devastated him. By the tenth, no longer. The hundredth was the equivalent of washing his hands: a hygienic habit, something to be done, nothing more. Glenn did not know at what point he stopped counting. He only knew, on one night like any other, that the count had vanished.

NARRATION: He realized it the precise moment he realized it, and the revelation horrified him.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: It horrified him for a minute, at least. Afterward, the horror wore down too.

QUICK CUT — THE PEOPLE WHO STOPPED EXISTING

NARRATION: At some point during those years, he forgot Diana's face.

NARRATION: It did not happen all at once. It was a slow erosion, over months. First he lost the exact shape of her hands. Then the cadence of her voice. Then some gesture. One night he tried to remember how she sounded when she laughed, and the sound did not come.

NARRATION: He forced the memory. He tried in several ways. The only thing his mind returned to him was the echo of Juno's laughter. And that was worse than the silence.

(Glenn sitting in the darkness of a rented room, completely motionless.)

NARRATION: He sat with that impossibility. He waited to feel something large. Pain. Guilt. Something.

NARRATION: He felt nothing.

NARRATION: That was what made him understand the precise size of his own ruin. The tragedy had not been the night of the conversion. It had not been the dawn on which he fled his house. The tragedy was this: the moment he could not remember his wife's laugh, and discovered it made no difference to him.

NARRATION: He lost Johannes too. The boy's countenance dissolved. Only the eyes survived, because he had painted them too many times by then. The rest of the son was a blank outline.

NARRATION: He told himself it was the same as having buried them. Widowers buried their families, stopped weeping, moved on, and no one in the world blamed them for it.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: He knew it was not the same.

QUICK CUT — MIRROR

(A well-lit room. A full-length mirror with a carved frame. Glenn stands before it, impeccably dressed for some dinner, some function in which he has no interest whatsoever.)

(He looks at himself.)

NARRATION: He had now been immortal for fifteen years longer than he had been married. It was an absurd fact, but a fact nonetheless. He had been what he now was for longer than he had been a husband. For longer than he had been a father. For longer than he had been an Irish peasant.

NARRATION: That part of his life was beginning to be, statistically, the smaller one.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: And in time, it would become the smallest part of all. So small that one day it would turn into a margin of error.

(Glenn adjusts the collar of his shirt. Fixes his hair. The image in the mirror returns him to someone he has learned to recognize as himself, though he no longer resembles the man he was.)

NARRATION: The worst part was not the change. The worst part was that the change suited him.

QUICK CUT — JUNO LAUGHING

(A crowded salon. One of those European high-society parties Juno insisted on dragging him to. Juno and Glenn are seated together on a period sofa, facing the viewer.)

(Juno has one hand resting on Glenn's arm. With the other, she points forward, at something happening offscreen. Someone making a fool of himself, surely. Someone who does not know he is being watched.)

(Juno laughs. With abandon. The laugh is real.)

(Glenn doesn't.)

(He looks in the same direction as her. But his expression doesn't shift.)

NARRATION: She did it better than he did. That was the uncomfortable truth.

NARRATION: Juno had understood something about this existence that Glenn still could not grasp, and that perhaps he never would. Something about not resisting. About yielding to the weight and letting time turn you into whatever it was going to turn you into.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn had been resisting for fifteen years, and the only thing he had achieved by it was that the wearing-down hurt him twice as much. He knew he was going to end up in exactly the same place as her. Only he was going to arrive later, and far more tired.

(Juno keeps laughing. Eventually, Glenn nods slowly and imitates her, sketching something very close to a smile.)

NARRATION: That was another novelty: the smiles that came on their own, without needing to be felt. It was the body learning to act on its own, because the facade could not afford the luxury of showing how little remained inside.

QUICK CUT — THE WINDOW

(A room in some European city. Late afternoon. The window stands wide open, though it is not warm.)

(Juno stands before it, her back turned. She is still, but in a way Glenn does not recognize. She does not even lean against the frame; she is simply standing.)

(Glenn comes in looking for something: a coat, a hat. Inconsequential. He stops at the threshold.)

NARRATION: He had seen her do many things over those years. Laugh out loud in a salon. Bleed a man dry in an alley. Dress for a dinner like someone who knows the entire world is waiting for her.

NARRATION: But what he was seeing now did not fit into any of those categories. It was a much smaller picture: a woman looking at nothing.

(Glenn keeps quiet. Not because he wants to spy on her, but because the words fail him.)

(Juno speaks without turning. Her voice is the usual one, but the tone arrives a second out of step.)

JUNO: I thought you were downstairs.

GLENN: I was.

(Pause.)

GLENN: What are you looking at?

JUNO: Nothing.

(Glenn takes a step closer. He looks out. There is, in fact, nothing. An empty street. An unlit lamp. A stray dog crossing the cobblestones.)

(Juno turns.)

NARRATION: Glenn had never seen that expression on her. And yet, he recognized it immediately. It was like recognizing the sound of a foreign language without understanding a single word.

NARRATION: The fissure lasted exactly three seconds.

NARRATION: By the fourth, Juno was herself again.

(She approaches. Places a cold hand on his cheek.)

JUNO: *(with her usual irony)* Were you looking for me? How sweet.

(Glenn sketches something that can pass for a smile. They leave the room together.)

NARRATION: Glenn did not ask her again what she had been looking at. He knew, by instinct, that the answer would again be "nothing," and that it would be both true and false at the same time. He understood that there were things Juno looked at that were not in the street.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: He did not dwell on it either. The night went on. The days too. He forgot it with the same ease with which he was forgetting everything else.

NARRATION: He would remember it many years later. By then, he would know perfectly well what it was that she had seen.

QUICK CUT — A CONVERSATION OF NO IMPORTANCE

NARRATION: One night, Juno asked him a question. He would not be able to recall, later, what it was. Something banal. What he preferred for dinner, or what he thought of some guest.

NARRATION: And Glenn realized, in the middle of his own answer, that he was saying exactly what Juno wanted to hear.

NARRATION: The true revelation was not that, but the certainty that he had been doing it for years. He realized that he no longer knew what his actual opinion was on matters in which, before, he would have held a firm position.

(Glenn stops mid-sentence. Juno looks at him.)

JUNO: What?

GLENN: Nothing.

JUNO: Why are you stopping?

GLENN: I forgot what I was going to say.

(Juno accepts the answer without giving it any weight. She returns to what she was doing.)

NARRATION: Glenn spent the rest of the night trying to remember what he, really, thought about what he had been asked.

NARRATION: He did not succeed.

QUICK CUT — THE PORTRAIT, AGAIN

(The same room he uses as a studio. Glenn stands before the easel. He pulls back the dark cloth. From the canvas, the fair-haired woman returns his gaze.)

NARRATION: He had painted her so many times that he now knew her better as a painting than as a person.

(Glenn holds the brush in the air. He doesn't trace a single line. He merely looks at her.)

NARRATION: That night he understood something it had taken him years to put into words. The painting was not Diana. It had never been Diana. The canvas was the only corner of the world where the man who had married her still existed.

NARRATION: He painted her obsessively, not to remember her, but to keep from forgetting himself entirely.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The trick worked for some time, until it stopped working.

NARRATION: He kept painting her anyway.

(Glenn covers the canvas again with the cloth. Blows out the candle.)

QUICK CUT — THE INVITATION

NARRATION: Virginia. 1780.

NARRATION: He returned to Richmond without Juno. It was a custom he kept up from time to time, driven by bureaucratic matters. This time, something about a transfer of properties. Glenn did not bother with the details. He signed wherever he was told to sign.

(The study of his estate. On the desk, a stack of envelopes accumulated over weeks. Glenn handles them without enthusiasm.)

NARRATION: The routine was always the same. A stack of envelopes accumulated over weeks on his desk. Invitations, most of them. Glenn had spent years receiving invitations in every city he set foot in. There was always someone who had heard of him and wanted to see him with their own eyes. The "legendary" Sheridan.

(He opens the envelopes. He discards them one by one. One. Two. Three.)

(He stops at one. A thick card.)

NARRATION: Holland. The reception was that very night.

NARRATION: The name meant nothing to him. He set the invitation aside on the table without any particular reason. Boredom, perhaps.

NARRATION: He accepted. He dressed for the occasion. He put on the smile and climbed into the carriage.

NARRATION: He had no way of knowing that that night would be the first truly important thing to happen to him in fifteen years. Had he known, he would have prepared differently.

(END OF INTERMEZZO.)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The Holland Party. *Virginia. 1780.*

QUICK CUT — THE ARRIVAL

NARRATION: John Holland's mansion was a predictable excess. Overloaded candelabras, marble imported from Europe, and violins marking the tempo of a hurried dance.

NARRATION: Glenn had accepted the invitation out of pure inertia, which was the only thing moving him from one place to another these days.

(Glenn crosses the threshold of the main hall. Several heads turn as he passes. Not the entire room, but enough of them.)

NARRATION: Over the past fifteen years, Glenn had learned the mechanics of entering rooms like that one. It required no particular effort: the room took care of the rest of the work.

(A pair of women intercept him before he manages a third step. Glenn offers them a greeting of strict, protocol-bound courtesy. One of them holds his hand a fraction of a second too long. Glenn slips free so smoothly that she doesn't even notice she has been released.)

(A small man, round, his cheeks flushed from an excess of rum, breaks away from one of the little clusters of guests. He advances toward Glenn with the determination of a host doing his duty. He extends his hand several meters before reaching him.)

NARRATION: John Holland did not have much information on Glenn Sheridan. He knew what the rest of the county knew: the rumors, the financial reputation, the women.

NARRATION: He had invited him because his wife had suggested it, and because exhibiting Sheridan in one's own hall was the quickest way to certify the standing of the estate.

MR. HOLLAND: *(laughing, his hand already on Glenn's shoulder)* I must tell you, Sheridan, your reputation as a night owl precedes you. My wife was firmly convinced you were a myth, until you just walked through that door.

GLENN: *(sketching a hollow, practiced smile)* The sun lacks subtlety, Mr. Holland. Night is more generous to men of my nature.

NARRATION: Holland laughed with that peculiar laugh of men who understand only half of what they hear, and who applaud the other half just in case.

NARRATION: For the next several minutes, Glenn did what the occasion expected of him.

NARRATION: He drank without swallowing. He listened without hearing. He had been performing the routine for so long that his consciousness no longer needed to be present in the room to do it.

QUICK CUT — THE RECOGNITION

(And then, he sees him.)

(A young servant, at the back of the room. Black coat. He holds a tray of crystal glasses. He keeps his head bowed at that precise angle particular to heads that have not been granted permission to rise in years. He is barely a silhouette cut against the wall.)

(The sound of the violins begins to distort.)

GLENN: *(without taking his eyes off the boy)* That boy. The fair-haired one. Where did you get him?

MR. HOLLAND: *(glancing over his shoulder, and laughing)* Has the boy caught your eye, Sheridan? He's one of my favorites. He has exceptional features, don't you think? And very quiet. He doesn't say a word unless he's made to.

GLENN: ...

MR. HOLLAND: Are you interested?

NARRATION: Glenn did not allow himself to process what lay beneath the question.

GLENN: *(the manufactured calm holding intact, to the millimeter)* Call him over, please.

MR. HOLLAND: You want a closer look?

GLENN: Just for a moment.

NARRATION: Holland raised a hand. He did not raise it far. Owners like Holland knew by instinct that a minuscule gesture was enough when the body waiting on the other side of the room had spent an entire lifetime trained to detect it.

(The servant approaches. He stops a meter away. He bows, calculating the precise reverence that slaves owe to gentlemen. His gaze stays fixed on the floor.)

NARRATION: Glenn waited to see the face. He waited for it the way a man waits for the confirmation of a diagnosis he refuses to receive.

(The boy raises his eyes. Only for an instant. He performs the forbidden gesture: a slave does not raise his gaze before the master without express permission. And yet he does it anyway, as though something in the air had tugged his chin upward.)

NARRATION: They were the same blue eyes Glenn had spent fifteen years painting badly, from memory alone, in squalid studios scattered across three continents.

NARRATION: The same defiant curve of the lip. The same sharp expression of someone who learned, too soon, that the world would grant him nothing he did not wrench from it by his own means.

(Glenn's world tilts violently.)

NARRATION: And in that exact second, Glenn understood (not with the logic of the head, but through a mechanism far deeper and more primitive) that the boy had seen him first.

NARRATION: That he had been watching him for a good while. That Glenn's exact position in that room had been registered by the boy from the very instant he crossed the main door.

(The boy lowers his eyes. The fraction of a second closes.)

QUICK CUT — THE CONVERSATION

GLENN: He's... he's white.

(Pause.)

GLENN: You bought a white boy as a slave? As though he were a head of cattle at market?

MR. HOLLAND: *(letting out a small chuckle)* Technically, indebted. But in the Irish slums of Richmond, a coin is a coin. I found him some fifteen years ago.

MR. HOLLAND: His mother was a woman of the street. A desperate creature. She sold him to me for a handful of silver and the promise that I would feed him.

NARRATION: Glenn heard the word "*desperate*" and the term hung in the air a fraction of a second before it reached his brain.

NARRATION: It contained the weight of one winter, and the arrival of the next. It contained the exact value of a handful of silver coins. It contained a Diana alone, turning her back on the child for the last time.

NARRATION: The servant remained a meter away. Absolutely still. The tray held at half-height.

NARRATION: Glenn knew (because he himself had learned the hard way not to remain in rooms where his presence was a risk) that the boy was registering every damned word.

GLENN: *(in a strangled voice)* She sold him?

MR. HOLLAND: It's not as if she had many alternatives, I suppose. She said the boy was called Johannes. She begged me to treat him like a son.

(Holland adjusts his coat, with the satisfaction peculiar to a man who confuses purchasing power with moral virtue.)

MR. HOLLAND: Naturally, I did not. But look at him: clean, dressed, serving glasses to the finest men in Virginia. I'd say I did the woman a favor. Wouldn't you agree?

NARRATION: Glenn did not answer. He was no longer in the room.

MR. HOLLAND: I imagine that, at some point in your youth, you solicited her services. The physical resemblance is rather striking, wouldn't you say?

NARRATION: Glenn did not answer because, physically, he was incapable of it. The impulse to wring Holland's neck rose in waves that he had to contain and block, one by one.

NARRATION: Holland was handing him, from total ignorance, the most brutal translation of the past fifteen years.

NARRATION: The logic of the county dictated that a woman who sells her son can only be catalogued as a prostitute. It was a deduction of an almost perfect cruelty.

NARRATION: Diana had not worked as a prostitute. Diana had been a cornered woman with a child, in a time that made no provision for women alone; a woman who had executed the only transaction available to her to ensure the child ate.

NARRATION: But in Holland's head, cause and outcome were the same thing.

NARRATION: And Holland's head had functioned, all this time, as the only biography of Diana available in the world.

NARRATION: Holland had kept her pigeonholed as a whore in front of Johannes for the whole of the boy's short existence, tossing him details that he very probably altered according to the day's audience.

NARRATION: The boy had not altered the position of his head. But something in the angle of the tension in his neck had shifted by a micron.

NARRATION: Glenn knew the boy had spent years listening to variations of that same sentence. That he had learned the trade of not hearing it.

NARRATION: And he knew that, this time, he had heard it. Glenn did not know where he drew that certainty from. He simply noted it as a fact.

NARRATION: The waves of violence kept coming. Glenn counted them. One. Two. Three.

NARRATION: He calculated, using the one part of his brain still operating with any coldness, how many more surges he could contain before the body's machinery decided to skip the protocols and act on its own.

NARRATION: The resulting figure was: very few.

(Glenn turns toward Holland. His eyes have a dangerous sharpness.)

GLENN: His name. Now.

(Holland blinks, disconcerted. For a fraction of a second, something in Glenn's posture stops being entirely human. Holland perceives it without being able to identify what it is he is perceiving. Then the mirage dissolves and Glenn is Glenn again.)

MR. HOLLAND: Coltrane. Well, Coltrane Holland now.

(Holland sketches a small smile, like a man sharing some domestic anecdote.)

MR. HOLLAND: My wife assigned him the name. She maintained that "Johannes" did not sound appropriate for the service of our household.

NARRATION: Glenn registered the sentence. He registered it in full. He did not deduce, in that exact instant, everything he would end up doing with the information.

NARRATION: But the detail was filed away with the clarity of objects stored without any apparent use, which, a long time afterward, find their purpose.

NARRATION: What the sentence said, translated into the language of facts, was this: there is a woman in this house who watched a white child enter as a slave, and to whom the problem of the situation appeared to be the name.

GLENN: *(in a completely cold, flat tone)* I have to go.

MR. HOLLAND: Already? But the musicians have barely begun to—

(Glenn sets the untouched glass down on the nearest table and sets off toward the door. He does not say goodbye to Holland. He does not say goodbye to anyone at all.)

MR. HOLLAND: *(dismissing the boy with a wave of his hand)* Back to your work.

COLTRANE: Yes, master.

(Coltrane bows one last time. He turns. He moves off, carrying the tray toward the opposite side of the hall.)

NARRATION: Glenn watched the back move away. He noted that the stoop with which the boy bent to serve a guest was identical to the stoop with which Diana used to pick anything up off the floor.

NARRATION: Glenn turned on his heel. He did not look back again.

NARRATION: But he could feel the weight of the boy's eyes fixed on his own back. It was a dense hatred. A hatred rehearsed for years against a surname the boy had long heard circulating around the house, and which that night, at last, had acquired a face.

QUICK CUT — THE CARRIAGE

NARRATION: Outside, the temperature of the night hit him head-on. For the first time since he had inhabited that body, the immortal felt a genuine cold.

(He reaches his carriage. The driver looks at him, visibly confused by the premature departure. Glenn grips the cabin door with a force so excessive that the wood creaks.)

GLENN: *(to himself, in a voice he does not recognize as his own)* I found him.

(Pause.)

GLENN: I found our Johannes.

NARRATION: The "our" came out on its own. He was speaking to a woman who had not existed in his head for years, and who had just materialized again because of the piece of information Holland had let slip, oblivious to the magnitude of what he was letting slip.

NARRATION: Glenn already knew what he was going to do. He had known it from the second he saw the boy's face lift toward him in the hall.

NARRATION: What he could not yet calculate was the total cost of the operation.

(FADE TO BLACK)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The Transaction. *Virginia. ~1780. Days after the party.*

NARRATION: Glenn didn't negotiate. Men like Holland don't understand negotiation.

NARRATION: They understand one thing only, and Glenn had amassed that one thing over fifteen years, in quantities no mortal life could justify. He would pay him with it, Holland would accept, and neither of them would have to look the other in the eye while it happened.

NARRATION: That was the truly important part of the calculation. The rest was simple arithmetic.

NARRATION: Glenn would not set foot in that mansion again. He didn't trust what he would do with Holland close at hand. He didn't trust his own body, which had obeyed him for fifteen years with a precision that still surprised him, but which this time (he knew it with absolute certainty) would not honor the order to stay still.

NARRATION: He sent an intermediary.

QUICK CUT — THE PAPERS

(The Holland mansion. The study. Midday light filters in through a curtain that hasn't been fully drawn open in days. The "camera" holds at the threshold. We watch the scene from outside, with the caution of someone unwilling to step all the way into the room.)

(MR. HOLLAND sits behind the desk. THE INTERMEDIARY: an older man in a gray frock coat, a leather case held under one arm, stands facing him. He has not sat down. Nor has he been offered a chair.)

(The intermediary sets a bundle of banknotes down on the wood. He does it with the efficiency of a man who has closed many deals in which words carry no weight and money is everything.)

(Holland looks at the bundle. Looks at the intermediary. Looks back at the bundle.)

NARRATION: The amount was excessive. Holland recognized it at a glance, without needing to count.

NARRATION: He had spent twenty years buying and selling men, and in that time he had developed the same instinct a jeweler develops for gems: he knew, just by looking, when a price was being distorted by something unrelated to the value of the merchandise.

MR. HOLLAND: *(adjusting his collar)* This is a figure well above the boy's.

(The intermediary doesn't answer.)

MR. HOLLAND: Well above. Considerably so, I mean.

THE INTERMEDIARY: *(in a neutral voice)* My client has made his offer. It falls to the seller to accept it or decline it.

MR. HOLLAND: *(attempting a faint smile)* May I ask what this—

THE INTERMEDIARY: No.

(Holland blinks.)

NARRATION: For a moment Holland understood, without quite understanding it, that the man in front of him was not the one doing the negotiating.

NARRATION: He understood that the true buyer had not deigned to appear. And that this absence, translated into money, was exactly the exorbitant figure sitting on the table.

NARRATION: Holland signed the papers that same afternoon. He did it faster than he had signed cheaper things.

NARRATION: There was something about the exchange. It wasn't only the price: it was the price combined with the cold absence of the buyer, which suggested that any delay would be a very poor idea. He couldn't have explained why.

NARRATION: But the men who manage to survive to Holland's age do so because they have learned to obey that kind of instinct, even when it has no logical justification.

(A document changes hands.)

(Visual detail: The name written at the head of the document is Johannes Sheridan. The name is struck through with a thick line of ink, and Coltrane Holland is written above it in the ornate hand of some clerk.)

(The intermediary folds the document in half. Puts it away in the leather case. Gives a nod that means to be no courtesy, only a formality. Leaves the study.)

(Holland is left alone, looking at the bundle of money.)

NARRATION: Glenn didn't know the purchase had gone through until the intermediary returned to the estate at nightfall.

NARRATION: He didn't ask how it had gone. There was no need. The case held the bill of sale.

NARRATION: And with the document came the boy.

QUICK CUT — THE ARRIVAL

(Glenn's estate. Nightfall. The carriage stops at the main entrance.)

(Glenn waits on the porch. He hasn't come down the steps. He keeps his hands clasped behind his back; a posture unlike him, but one that serves him strategically right now because it keeps him from doing something stupid with them.)

(COLTRANE steps down from the carriage. He wears the same clothes he served in at the party, minus the coat. A linen shirt, coarse trousers, boots, a small bundle. He carries nothing else: there is no luggage, simply because at the Holland mansion there was nothing that belonged to him.)

(He stands by the carriage door. Studies the house. Looks at Glenn. He waits for instructions, because waiting for instructions is the only thing he knows upon entering a new property.)

NARRATION: Glenn had rehearsed several introductions in his head over the hours the intermediary's journey lasted. None of them worked.

NARRATION: They were all variations on a single concept (some kind of welcome) and all of them sounded, set against the silence of the evening, like the illegitimate speech of a man who has lost the right to make it.

(Glenn comes down the steps. Slowly. He stops a couple of paces from Coltrane; a distance shorter

than is comfortable, but not so short as to crowd him and seem threatening.)

GLENN: You're free.

(Coltrane looks at him. There is no reaction on his face. None.)

GLENN: I mean. The bill of sale. It's been signed. You're a free man.

COLTRANE: *(slowly)* Sir?

GLENN: No. Don't call me that.

COLTRANE: *(after a pause)* What should I call you?

(Glenn opens his mouth. Closes it.)

NARRATION: It was the question he had been dreading since the night of the carriage after the party, and one he still had no answer for.

NARRATION: *Father* was impossible. *Sheridan* was a cruelty. *Glenn* implied a level of intimacy for someone who had, technically, been bought that very afternoon.

NARRATION: There was no correct category. Every option available was either a lie or a wound.

GLENN: *(at last)* Glenn. That will do.

(Coltrane nods once. He doesn't say the name. Glenn knows he won't say it that night. Nor the next. Nor the one after. But that belongs to a problem of another kind.)

GLENN: Your room is upstairs. To the right of the hallway. It's the first door. Someone on staff already left you some clothes. If they don't fit, we'll sort it out tomorrow.

COLTRANE: Thank you.

GLENN: Don't thank me.

(It comes out too curt. Glenn realizes it the moment he says it. He tries to soften it and only makes it worse.)

GLENN: I mean... There's no need. It isn't... it isn't something to be thanked for in this house.

(Coltrane looks at him a moment longer, taking in the strange dynamic of the new master. Then he climbs the steps. He passes by him without brushing against him, and enters the house for the first time.)

(Glenn stays standing on the porch for a long while.)

NARRATION: He had bought his own son with the same coldness with which one buys a racehorse. Using the money he had accumulated over fifteen years carrying out acts he preferred not to remember.

NARRATION: And now that he had him, he was incapable of telling him why.

NARRATION: That was the one part of his logistics he hadn't foreseen. That the cost of silence was going to hurt far more than everything else.

(FADE TO BLACK)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

Cohabitation. *Virginia. ~1780*

NARRATION: Coltrane stayed. Not because Glenn asked him to. He stayed because it was standard procedure when a white man bought your freedom and you had no idea what to do with it.

NARRATION: They lived under the same roof for a couple of months. Glenn had no experience living with anyone other than Juno, and Juno didn't count: cohabiting with her had always amounted to a choreography of mutual evasions.

NARRATION: With Coltrane no choreography was possible. There was, simply, a house too large, holding two people who had no idea what to do with one another.

NARRATION: On the third day, Glenn informed him that on the estate he would have everything he needed. Legal freedom. A roof. Food. Clothing. And an education, if he asked for one.

NARRATION: Glenn heard himself reciting the words and concluded that he sounded exactly like an overseer running through a list of supplies. Coltrane nodded. Neither of them bought the speech. Neither bothered to mention it.

QUICK CUT — THE LETTERS

(The studio, afternoon. Oblique light comes in through the high window. GLENN and COLTRANE sit across from each other at a long table. Between them rests a sheet with the alphabet written in Glenn's hand, which is rough.)

(Coltrane studies the letters with the same concentration he used to apply to pouring a glass of wine without spilling a drop.)

GLENN: *(pointing at the paper)* This one.

COLTRANE: A.

GLENN: The next one.

COLTRANE: B.

GLENN: Good.

COLTRANE: I already knew them.

(Glenn looks up at him. Coltrane holds his gaze without challenging him, merely stating a fact.)

GLENN: Where did you learn them?

COLTRANE: Watching Holland's children when the tutor gave them lessons. I watched from the doorway.

GLENN: How long have you been able to read?

COLTRANE: *(running the calculation in his head)* Eight years.

NARRATION: Glenn absorbed the fact in absolute silence. Eight years of peering through cracks and filing the information away. Eight years of secretly taking in knowledge that was strictly forbidden to him under physical punishment.

NARRATION: Glenn felt something that didn't quite amount to pride, but wasn't far from it: the

recognition that this boy had developed methods of survival he himself had never had any need to put into practice.

GLENN: *(after a pause)* Then it seems you don't need my alphabet.

COLTRANE: No.

GLENN: What do you need?

(Coltrane looks away and examines the library that stretches toward the far end of the room: two floors of shelves crammed with volumes. It was the inventory Glenn had accumulated over fifteen years, acquiring entire lots of books in every European city where boredom had suffocated him.)

COLTRANE: *(without returning his gaze)* Time.

QUICK CUT — THE LIBRARY

(A still image. No line of dialogue.)

(Coltrane sunk into an armchair. To his left rises a stack of volumes that, with him seated, stands taller than he is. To his right, a second column, markedly lower: the copies he has already finished. A book rests open in his lap. The light indicates he has been reading without pause since dawn.)

NARRATION: Coltrane consumed the texts with the urgency of someone who has operated under a chronic deficit of time his whole life.

NARRATION: He processed his reading at a speed Glenn struggled to grasp at first. Coltrane wasn't reading fast out of impatience, or anxiety. He was reading at his baseline speed. And his baseline speed belonged to another scale.

NARRATION: He exhausted one volume and opened the next without granting himself a pause to absorb it. Greek philosophers, Latin texts, English treatise-writers from the previous century. A manual of navigation. A detailed herbal.

NARRATION: Somewhere in the stack, he opened a natural-history encyclopedia that had belonged to Holland's study and that Glenn had acquired along with the entire lot from the mansion, without examining what was inside. Coltrane recognized the encyclopedia at once. He didn't report it.

NARRATION: Glenn, for his part, watched him from the periphery. He didn't dare question him about what he was reading. He suspected the answer would be either excessively long or humiliatingly short; and that, in either scenario, he would come out the loser.

QUICK CUT — THE STUDIO

(Glenn's studio on the estate. It is a space radically different from the improvised studio in Richmond: this one has room, overhead light, and a structured layout. Oils mounted on stretchers lean against the walls. Blocks of marble half-roughed-out. An unfinished clay figure on an easel. A long table spreads out a multitude of sketches: graphite, charcoal, sanguine, tempera. The whole inventory is on view.)

(Almost all of it.)

(Coltrane comes through the entrance. Glenn has his back to him, absorbed in a canvas that, from the angle of the door, can't be seen. Coltrane runs his eyes over the room, touching nothing. Glenn notices his presence in the room but refrains from turning around.)

COLTRANE: What are you trying to convey?

(Glenn's hand hangs suspended in the air, the brush millimeters from the canvas. The question catches

him unprepared.)

GLENN: *(working out his answer)* I'm interested in capturing human emotions. The intrinsic reality of each model. The particular circumstance of each one. The aesthetics of the moment. I'm interested in turning ugliness into virtue. In representing the human essence—

(He stops himself. He corrects himself.)

GLENN: Mortal. The mortal essence. And extracting lessons from it.

(Coltrane doesn't answer right away. He fixes his attention on some painting at random: the portrait of a middle-aged woman, seated, her hands clasped in her lap. She is neither beautiful nor beautified. And yet there is something in the painting that forces the woman to return the viewer's gaze, as if she knew more than she lets on.)

COLTRANE: *(with a slight gesture)* What's under those cloths?

(Glenn turns around for the first time. His gaze goes to the three stretchers leaning against the back wall, veiled in dark cloth. They are the only ones in the entire room not on display.)

GLENN: Sketches.

COLTRANE: Of whom?

(A pause longer than a casual answer would take.)

GLENN: No one in particular.

NARRATION: Coltrane did not press. He redirected his attention toward the paintings that were on display. Glenn, in turn, resumed his brushwork.

NARRATION: Neither of them said aloud what both knew perfectly well: that the three veiled sketches were of Coltrane.

NARRATION: And that Glenn didn't dare uncover them, because doing so would have meant submitting himself to a brutal internal scrutiny. He would have had to work out whether he had painted those faces trying to reconstruct a memory that was already physically present in this room; whether he was trying to paint it for the first time with its new features; or worse still, whether, through the canvas, he was demanding something of his son that he didn't know how to name.

QUICK CUT — AN ORDINARY NIGHT

(Evening. Glenn adjusts his coat in front of a mirror in the hall. He looks at himself longer than strictly necessary.)

(Coltrane stands in the doorway of the library, holding a book in one hand.)

COLTRANE: Going out?

GLENN: Yes.

COLTRANE: *(turning his attention back to the text)* Mm.

(Glenn turns. For a moment his posture suggests he's about to offer an explanation. He discards the idea. He adjusts his shirt collar with precision, and goes out the front door.)

NARRATION: Glenn always came back before dawn. Sometimes with the scent of some woman on him. Other times with no scent at all.

NARRATION: Coltrane didn't ask. Glenn didn't justify himself. It was the only pact in the house that

both kept to the letter without ever having sat down to negotiate it.

NARRATION: Glenn weighed, more than once, whether to stop bringing women to the studio.

NARRATION: But he concluded that this would amount to admitting that he cared how Coltrane saw him, and the cost of that would be far higher than the cost of keeping the routine. So he kept the visits going. Not often, but with exactly enough regularity that he never had to consider whether his system had been altered.

QUICK CUT — A CLUMSY INSTRUCTION

(The kitchen. The following night. Coltrane stands by the window. Glenn bursts into the room, pours himself something to drink that he won't drink, and leans against the table.)

GLENN: Listen. About last night.

COLTRANE: What about last night?

GLENN: When you went off to bed without dinner.

COLTRANE: I'd eaten earlier.

GLENN: Right. Still. *(He pauses to measure his words.)* You have to feed yourself. Feed yourself properly. Three meals a day. You know that, don't you? Well. There you go.

(Coltrane looks at him. Not with scorn, but with something worse: with patience. He watches him with the resignation of someone who has to put up with a man trying to assemble a machine with neither a manual nor tools.)

COLTRANE: Good.

GLENN: Good.

(Glenn leaves the kitchen. Coltrane stays still, looking at the space he has just vacated.)

NARRATION: In situations like that one, Glenn justified himself by saying he was playing the part as well as he could. That no one had taught him to do this, and that attempting a clumsy move yielded a better balance than attempting nothing at all.

NARRATION: He was right.

NARRATION: What he kept quiet was the other side of it: something in him knew with painful certainty that, had he tried fifteen years ago (with the child he had deliberately erased from memory) the incompetence would have been exactly the same.

NARRATION: That he might never manage it. That this clumsy, belated feint at instruction served not as a repair of damages, but as confirmation of a bankruptcy that had already been consummated back when it truly mattered.

NARRATION: He told himself, when no one was listening, that he was an absolute fraud. A wretch.

NARRATION: And he told it to himself with the ease of someone who has come to accept an immovable fact.

NARRATION: Then he would shut himself away to drink without drinking anything.

QUICK CUT — THE DEFERRAL

(The library. Night. Coltrane sunk in the armchair, reading. Glenn stays on his feet beside the fireplace,

his gaze fixed on the fire.)

(Several minutes pass without a line of dialogue. The sound of a page being turned. The crackle of the logs.)

(Glenn opens his mouth.)

(He closes it again.)

NARRATION: There were many nights that went on like that. Glenn would arrive at the verge of saying it. He would form the first syllable in his throat. And, at the final instant, he would draw back.

NARRATION: He justified himself on the grounds that he lacked the proper moment. That the right occasion would arrive on its own. That when it presented itself, he would know how to recognise it.

NARRATION: He went on waiting for that moment. The weeks passed. The months passed.

NARRATION: The moment never came, because the perfect moment does not exist. The only thing that exists is the decision to speak. And Glenn did not make it.

NARRATION: He deferred the truth to eternity. He had one of those, after all. Time was going to be in surplus.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: What he needed, what he was incapable of petitioning for out loud, was forgiveness. And since he did not possess the courage to ask for it, neither could he permit himself the scenario in which it might be granted.

NARRATION: And so he packaged the two things (the confession and the forgiveness) in the same mental drawer, turned the key, and went on living in the house as though the drawer did not exist.

QUICK CUT — THE QUARTERS

(Night. The estate. At the far end of the garden, outlined in the darkness, the slaves' cabins.)

NARRATION: Glenn had acquired them along with the property six years earlier. Not because he required labour (Glenn needed assistance for almost nothing), but because they were listed as assets in the bill of sale, and he had not troubled himself to demand a different one.

NARRATION: He had ignored them from the signing of the document onward. He never approached the quarters. They did not come near the great house unless they were called for. That was the transaction, and it had operated in strict silence for years.

NARRATION: Coltrane, by contrast, located the exact position of the cabins during his first week on the estate. He began to make his way over there at night. He requested no authorisation. And no one in the house issued an order to prevent him.

(The camera follows him. He walks among the structures with the trained stealth of someone who knows he must not interrupt. He sits on a fallen log, a few metres from the last door. From there, he simply listens.)

(A woman's voice singing. Another joins her. Then a man's. A melody addressed to no one in particular; a piece that has gone on repeating itself for decades, in places far worse than this one.)

(Coltrane closes his eyes.)

NARRATION: One of the few records of happiness he kept from his childhood was that of listening to Annie sing. He used to say she had the voice of an angel. He did not put it forward as a metaphor. He

affirmed it with the absolute literalness of a child who has not yet learned to qualify the important things.

NARRATION: But Annie did not figure among these houses. Annie remained at the Holland mansion, two hours away by carriage. She was still property.

NARRATION: Coltrane had not stopped calculating, over and over, why he held papers of freedom and she did not. What he had voided, definitively, was the expectation of finding a formulation to that question that would allow him to live alongside it.

NARRATION: He came to listen to Glenn's slaves because those voices were the nearest sound he had, on that side of the county, to the sounds he had grown up with.

NARRATION: But Annie's timbre was not among them. That was the part he returned to verify every night: to confirm, in silence, her absence.

(The singing carries on. Coltrane does not accompany the melody. Nor does he weep. He confines himself to listening, holding his back too straight. The indelible posture of a servant that his body refuses to release, not even in the dark, not even when no one is watching him.)

QUICK CUT — THE WAVES

(The same night. A few hours later.)

(Glenn remains seated on the porch of the great house. He holds a glass he has not drunk from. From his position, with the acuity of his recent anatomy, he catches the same thing Coltrane is listening to on the other side of the garden.)

NARRATION: It was the first time, in the six years he had held title to the estate, that Glenn paid any attention to the sound his own slaves were emitting. He admitted it to himself with a degree of precision he found deeply uncomfortable, while he continued not to move from the porch.

NARRATION: Six years. He had never set foot in the quarters. He had never examined the faces. He had not even troubled himself to count how many individuals made up the lot.

NARRATION: He held the exact figure, yes. It was entered in a ledger he signed routinely without reading. The administrator handled the management. The administrator held the data.

NARRATION: This night, however, he did not withdraw indoors. This night, for reasons he refused to classify, he stayed on the porch long enough to truly hear.

(Glenn closes his eyes. Something in the entrails of those voices, he could not say what, since he lacks the vocabulary, tears open something inside him. It is not a specific pain. It is the recognition that there exists a kind of human voice he had erased from his own memory.)

NARRATION: Everything he had blocked out and sidestepped over the last fifteen years came down on him at once, advancing in consecutive waves. Glenn sat paralysed in his chair, his gaze fixed on nothing, cornered in his own memories.

NARRATION: He remembered, unable to hold it back, those days in the Irish District.

NARRATION: The modest little house where the small family he was part of had lived. The cramped plot where he had devoted himself to growing corn and stones, trying to survive on the balance of the harvest.

NARRATION: He remembered the woman he had taken as his wife. The same one who made him so happy with that peculiar personality of hers: the mixture of that smile and the maddening ill humour,

always justified.

NARRATION: He remembered the days split between sweat and canvas. The nights in the working-class taverns, where he devoted himself to squandering his money on beer, on petty wagers, and on cheap company to shorten the small hours.

NARRATION: He remembered his old companions, as broke as he was, and the good hours spent singing and cursing the rich and the black slaves they themselves would never come to own. He remembered the hardships endured and the balance of those nights when he had gone to sleep with an empty stomach, so as to surrender his ration to his wife and his son.

NARRATION: Yes. Him, too, he remembered.

NARRATION: The prickly little boy who had managed to resemble him in no respect at all, and for whom, paradoxically, he had felt an immense pride. The child who spent hours weeping because his hunger was insatiable, because he could not endure four hours in a row without taking something in. The one he had watched take his first steps, and heard say "papa" for the first time.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: And now, the child was a grown man. Seventeen years of life and accumulated survival. It was him. The young man identical to his mother, the one who had refused to acquire a single feature from his father. The son who had vanished from his life at the precise moment the suffering began.

NARRATION: The same man who was now there, on the other side of the garden, listening to the slaves' singing in complete silence.

NARRATION: A young man filled with a hatred so dense and so accumulated that Glenn could smell it from the porch without even meaning to.

NARRATION: He thought he deserved to hear that hostility. That it was the minimum punishment the night was offering him, and that to refuse it by rising from the chair would be one more cowardice on a list that was already long enough.

NARRATION: He thought, too, for the first time, that those voices reaching him from the other side of the garden belonged to human beings. To people.

NARRATION: It was an obvious observation. And one which, even so, his system had taken six full years to process.

NARRATION: He stayed holding the thought without knowing exactly what to do with it. After a while, he understood that this non-performance was, in itself, also a response.

(Glenn remains seated in the darkness. He does not move until the last echo of the singing has gone out completely.)

QUICK CUT — WHAT COLTRANE SEES

(The library. The afternoon of the following day.)

(Coltrane is reading. Glenn enters the room to fetch something: a book, an excuse. The object is the least of it.)

(Coltrane looks up. For a second, and only a second, he examines Glenn as though seeing him for the first time.)

(Glenn does not notice the look. He finds the book. He leaves the room.)

(Coltrane stays with his gaze fixed on the empty threshold.)

NARRATION: There was an anomaly in Glenn that Coltrane had spent weeks trying to classify.

NARRATION: It was not cruelty; Coltrane had been schooled in cruelty, and this did not fit the parameters. It was not coldness either, though at times he emulated it. It was a structural failure of a far rarer kind.

NARRATION: It was the constant impression that Glenn, in the biological sense in which men are men, was not entirely one. That he harboured something inside him that consumed no oxygen.

NARRATION: That, when the house fell silent, Glenn sank into an excessive stillness, adopting an immobility Coltrane had registered only in people who were deeply asleep, or dead.

NARRATION: Coltrane had discarded the hypothesis several times. He had told himself they were projections of his own head, that it was accumulated fatigue, that the Holland mansion had thrown his nervous system out of calibration.

NARRATION: But the night before, listening to the singing coming from the quarters, he had detected a frequency on the other side of the garden. A presence that did not correspond to that of a man listening. It was the presence of something that absorbed sound without belonging to this world.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Coltrane did not assign it a label yet. He lacked the vocabulary to classify it.

NARRATION: But he proceeded to file it away alongside the other irregularities of the house that did not add up: the canvases covered with cloth, the departures before dawn, the hermetic silence Glenn deployed every time a certain kind of question was put to him. It was all part of one and the same puzzle, whose edges Coltrane had not yet finished locating.

NARRATION: He suspected, without yet having the data to confirm it, that this puzzle contained the principal key: the exact reason a man, apparently a stranger, had liquidated a fortune for a boy to whom he owed absolutely nothing.

(FADE TO BLACK)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The resolution. Virginia. ~1780. Glenn's estate. Outer garden. Night.

NARRATION: Coltrane had been residing on the estate for a little over two months. Glenn had provided him with a room, clothing, food, and freedom of movement. Coltrane acknowledged receipt of all of it with the same inscrutable expression with which he accepted any order.

NARRATION: And, every night, he went out into the garden to look at the woods. Without exception. Always pointing in the same direction.

NARRATION: It took Glenn several days to notice that this angle of vision was not arbitrary. One afternoon, taking advantage of Coltrane's absence from the house, he verified it with a compass.

NARRATION: The instrument confirmed what he had already feared: the line was exact. From the stone bench to the Holland mansion. Two hours on horseback. A whole night, perhaps, on foot.

NARRATION: Glenn concluded that there existed men who oriented themselves toward the north, men

who oriented themselves toward the sea, and men who oriented themselves toward the exact place where they had left someone behind.

NARRATION: The third type was the most common, and also the least noticeable. It was the only one that required no compass.

(The night is mild. The sound of the cicadas, the friction of the air, the distant noise of a horse in the stable. COLTRANE is seated on a stone bench at the margins of the garden. His back straight, as usual. Scrutinising the darkness of the woods, as usual.)

(Behind him, GLENN approaches. His approach is not threatening: he keeps a respectful, silent safety distance. He carries a lamp in his hand. He does so more out of courtesy than necessity: his night vision is impeccable, but the light gives Coltrane the chance to detect his arrival without being startled.)

(It is the kind of gesture Glenn has begun to calculate over the past few weeks. Not all of them come out as planned.)

GLENN: *(in a low voice)* It's late, Coltrane. You shouldn't be out here.

(Coltrane does not turn his head. Glenn waits. As the answer fails to materialise, he tries again.)

GLENN: What's troubling you?

COLTRANE: *(without turning, lowering the volume of his voice)* I can't sleep.

GLENN: Why not?

(A pause. Coltrane seems to weigh whether it is worth giving the real answer or a fabricated one. He decides, devoid of theatrics, to give the former. Not out of an excess of trust, but out of energy conservation: holding up false answers is more tiring.)

COLTRANE: The overseer's whistle. The coughing in the damp. The constant shouting. I can't get them out of my head.

NARRATION: Coltrane did not divert his eyes from the same point. His entire account came to a single open wound of guilt. The specific guilt of the survivor who managed to get out: the kind nothing mitigates, for the simple reason that it has no way of being settled.

COLTRANE: They're all I know.

(A pause.)

COLTRANE: Why am I the only one who's free?

(Glenn halts his advance a few paces from the bench. He does not take a seat. He does not dare sit down: to share the bench would imply a level of familiarity neither of them has authorised yet.)

GLENN: *(with a caution that feels foreign to him)* You're white. You didn't deserve to be a slave.

(Coltrane, at last, turns around.)

(In Coltrane's face there is something Glenn had not anticipated: there is no gratitude, no relief. There is pain. A pain that is genuine, visceral, and furious.)

COLTRANE: *(his voice saturated with that rage)* No one deserves to be a slave!

(Pause.)

COLTRANE: No one!

(Glenn does not retreat. He lets the sentence land whole. He registers, with a precision he finds deeply

uncomfortable, that it is the first time in two months Coltrane has raised his voice at him.)

COLTRANE: I know you have enough gold and influence to free the rest.

(A brief pause.)

COLTRANE: All of them!

(Coltrane makes as if to rise from the bench. But he does not quite get to his feet: his body has not yet unlearned the rule against standing before a white man without prior authorisation. The motion stops halfway, when the body remembers the protocols of survival. He sits back down.)

(But the eyes, this time, do not lower.)

COLTRANE: Why only me?

(Glenn keeps silent. It is impossible for him to hand over the true answer: the one that would require opening a confession he keeps under lock and key for the rest of eternity. And eternity, by definition, is not now.)

COLTRANE: *(swallowing, holding his gaze head-on)* I'm begging you. The ones at Holland.

(A minimal pause. Coltrane's eyes stray for a fraction of a second toward the quarters set at the far end of Glenn's garden.)

COLTRANE: The ones here too.

(Glenn does not answer.)

NARRATION: Glenn had been thinking, over the past few weeks, about formulating a satisfactory answer to some version of this question. He knew with certainty it would eventually arrive.

NARRATION: What he had not forecast was the form. He had not foreseen that Coltrane would reach the point of begging him. That he would beg *him*. The man who had literally just bought him.

(Glenn inhales the night air.)

NARRATION: Any of the arguments he might marshal in this instant belonged to a level of conversation he was not yet prepared to sustain.

(Coltrane studies him a moment longer. Then, very slowly, he redirects his gaze toward the woods. The movement gives off a kind of ancient resignation; the sort of renunciation a body accumulates when it has begged too many things of too many people, and not one has ever been granted.)

(In that movement: simple, devoid of intention, barely a body turning on a stone bench, the linen shirt shifts. The tendon of the neck draws tight. The cloth creases and gives over the left shoulder.)

(Glenn sees it.)

(It is only a fragment. A minimal strip of skin exposed between the collar of the shirt and the root of the arm. But it proves to be enough to reveal two parallel marks, one above the other. They are thick, white against the pale skin, and they have that glossy surface texture exclusive to third-degree burns that have healed badly.)

NARRATION: They were not recent injuries. They were old. They dated, probably, from when Coltrane was twelve. Or ten.

NARRATION: Old enough for an overseer to rule that a boy of white complexion, but with the bearing of someone raised by a black woman, required a public correction to make certain no one on the plantation grew confused about where his place was.

NARRATION: Glenn had seen them before. Not that night: over the course of the past two months. He had caught them in passing when Coltrane washed himself at the back of the kitchen, or when he changed his shirt during afternoons of suffocating heat.

NARRATION: He had seen them, and looked away at once. He had registered them and nothing more, without processing them.

NARRATION: But this time, he was incapable of turning his eyes away.

(Coltrane, absorbed in the woods, does not notice the visual intrusion.)

NARRATION: There existed a very meticulous catalogue of the typologies of scars on the backs of slaves. And Glenn, who had invested fifteen years in ignoring the backs of the slaves on his own estate entirely, finished memorising that catalogue that very night.

NARRATION: He had been taking it in gradually over two months of looking without wanting to look, to be exact. And the lesson concluded in that precise second.

NARRATION: There was the standard furrow left by the common whip. There was the irregular abrasion left by the knotted whip. And then there was the relief left by the red-hot iron. The typologies were distinct. They carried author's signatures.

NARRATION: Coltrane's mark bore the unmistakable signature of the iron.

NARRATION: Glenn deduced, without need to apply any formula, that a superior at the Holland mansion had determined, years earlier, that the white boy required a sterner reminder than the rest.

NARRATION: Because the others possessed the right skin tone for the scar to end up blending into the shadows of the body. He did not. On him, the branding had to stand out. It had to be a legible message.

NARRATION: And, in that same instant, Glenn also understood that he had been the owner of this information for two months, and had been choosing, deliberately, to do absolutely nothing with it.

NARRATION: He understood that he had bought his son, transferred him to his estate, assigned him a room, clothing, and a library, and had gone on "dining" across from him every night without daring to ask what the hell, exactly, had happened to him inside that mansion.

NARRATION: He understood that this omission was also a form of cowardice. Possibly the most comfortable one of all.

(Coltrane goes on looking at the woods. He is unaware of what Glenn has just seen.)

(He speaks again. The volume of his voice has dropped several tones, declaring a burden he has been carrying in absolute solitude for too long.)

(Coltrane raises his eyes toward Glenn again.)

COLTRANE: Annie is expecting a child.

(Glenn goes completely still.)

NARRATION: Glenn tried to preserve a neutral countenance. A muscle in his jaw drew tight without his body managing to prevent it.

NARRATION: In reality, he already knew. He had intercepted the echo of that information in Coltrane's mind days earlier, and, operating as he did with so many other things, he had deliberately opted to ignore it.

NARRATION: But hearing it aloud reached another magnitude. Hearing it aloud sealed off every avenue of escape.

COLTRANE: *(in a low voice, vibrating with a very contained desperation)* And I know, in the deepest part of me, that the child is not John Holland's.

(A pause.)

COLTRANE: I believe it with certainty. It's mine.

(Glenn remained silent for several seconds.)

NARRATION: The physical distance between the two of them drew tight like a material that has spent too long at its limit without quite breaking.

NARRATION: Glenn processed multiple variables in those seconds. He thought of Annie, a woman he did not know in person, and whose name he had only registered by rummaging through Coltrane's thoughts during the rare instants when the boy let his guard down.

NARRATION: He thought of the child on the way, and of the child standing in front of him. He thought of the scar from the iron.

NARRATION: But, above all, he thought, with a clarity that had spent weeks waiting its turn, that the verdict was already signed.

NARRATION: He had taken the decision on the porch, the night he heard the slaves sing. He had ratified it barely a moment ago, when the linen cloth had slid over Coltrane's shoulder.

NARRATION: The confession about Annie was, quite simply, the last piece of the file. It was not the one that tipped the scales; it was the one that granted him legal permission to carry out what it had already been decided he was going to carry out anyway.

NARRATION: This time there would be no reprieves. This time the instant was exact. The instant was now.

(At last, Glenn turned his back on Coltrane and set off in the direction of the carriage house.)

(He did not run. He quickened his pace. It was a structured walk that admitted no room for negotiation.)

COLTRANE: *(startled, springing to his feet)* Now?

(Glenn did not halt his advance.)

COLTRANE: Seriously? What are you going to do?

(Glenn stopped dead then. Only for a second. He did not turn his body. He kept his head slightly tilted, in the posture of one appraising something in the distance. He was not analysing Coltrane's question, but calculating something else: how many hours of useful darkness the night had left, and whether he needed to take any additional tool.)

GLENN: *(turning his face just enough for Coltrane to see his profile)* Wait for me in the carriage.

(Glenn resumed his march.)

COLTRANE: *(raising his pitch, run through by a disquiet entirely unprecedented in him)* Are you going to talk to him?

(Glenn answered him in a flat voice, without emphasis, which proved to be infinitely worse than a shout.)

GLENN: We're not going to talk, Coltrane.

(Coltrane stayed nailed beside the stone bench, watching Glenn's back dissolve into the gloom.)

NARRATION: He did not call him by his name. He did not try to stop him.

NARRATION: A faction of himself (a recondite, dark layer he would refuse to acknowledge until long afterward) had already deduced what Glenn was setting out to do. And it also knew, with absolute certainty, that it did not wish to stop him.

NARRATION: That destructive faction was him too. And that was going to be, precisely, the part of his mind that would have to learn to live alongside the consequences of what was about to happen.

(SLOW FADE TO BLACK)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The Massacre and the Liberation. *Virginia. ~1780. The Holland estate and its surroundings. Night.*

NARRATION: There was no negotiation of any kind. Glenn had said they were not going to talk.

NARRATION: He kept his word.

QUICK CUT — THE CARRIAGE

(The carriage sits stopped at the bend in the path, just before the estate comes into view. Glenn climbs down. Coltrane remains inside. They do not exchange a single word. The distribution of roles had been assumed without any need for debate.)

NARRATION: Coltrane had obeyed the instructions. He had climbed into the carriage first, waiting while Glenn went back for something. A whole life of obeying without posing questions is not unlearned in a mere two months.

NARRATION: But this time that obedience was laced with a murkier component: the suspicion that, in some very deep layer of his being, he too wished to set out on that journey.

NARRATION: What Glenn was about to execute was not an act of passion. He had had fifteen years to excise his taste for passion. What he had cultivated in its place was far more efficient: a clinical precision with which he could carry out any task without a tremor in his pulse.

NARRATION: And his hands were enough for him. They were his only patrimony where gifts were concerned, and Glenn had concluded some time ago that he had no need to accumulate any more.

NARRATION: While others like him invested years in learning to move objects with thought, to manipulate fire by will, or to intrude into another's mind and disarrange it the way one enters and leaves a hotel room, Glenn had settled for the initial endowment: a brute strength whose metric was difficult to put into words, and two hands perfectly trained to apply it.

NARRATION: That night, that was going to be more than enough.

(Glenn walks along the path. His pace is steady. He is in no hurry at all.)

QUICK CUT — THE MANSION

(The Holland mansion stands erect in the night. Nearly every window throws light. The family is probably still at dinner, or preparing to retire to bed. The unalterable routine, for the last time.)

(Glenn pushes the front door, which yields without offering resistance. Inside, in the vestibule, a butler turns his head at the sound of the intrusion.)

(He does not manage to utter a word.)

NARRATION: The first thing Glenn drew from his new strength, in those first months, was that human necks did not possess the firmness he had supposed.

NARRATION: During his childhood on the farm, he had assumed that a man's bones would offer the same resistance as the bones of the cattle he used to help butcher. Work for a saw.

NARRATION: He was wrong. An adult man's neck gave with less effort than the required to snap a branch. The first time he confirmed it, he was horrified. After that, no longer.

NARRATION: That night, he felt no horror either.

(Glenn continues his advance down the corridor. The overseer comes out of a side office, alerted by an almost imperceptible noise. Glenn does not alter his rhythm. He intercepts him. He neutralizes him in a single motion, and keeps walking.)

QUICK CUT — THE KITCHEN

(The cook pokes her head out to assess the source of the noise. She stops in the doorway and sees him.)

(Glenn observes her for an instant. Then he shifts his gaze to the back of the kitchen, where three slaves: two women and an old man with floured hands, have been left petrified before the table.)

(Glenn fixes his eyes on the cook again. Then he goes absolutely still, scrutinizing the three slaves at the back. He does not address them. He issues no gestured instruction. He simply looks at them.)

NARRATION: Glenn gave them the strictly necessary amount of time. Lacking the technical capacity to submerge himself in a mind beyond its most superficial layer, he confined himself to reading that first coating.

NARRATION: He registered the information he required. The slaves stayed anchored in place, hands on the table, mute.

NARRATION: Glenn had not entered the house for them. If any trait had survived intact through the years he had spent pretending to be a drunken farmer, it was his natural instinct for distinguishing who owed what to whom.

NARRATION: And the man from whom the night's debt was owed in full was in another part of the mansion.

QUICK CUT — THE STUDY

(Mr. Holland in his study. He looks up from the paperwork on his desk. He discovers Glenn planted in the doorway.)

(He does not manage to rise to his feet.)

(Glenn lifts him out of the chair, holding him by the collar of his shirt with a single hand. Not to hurt him yet, but to establish direct eye contact.)

(Two seconds pass.)

NARRATION: Glenn felt no need to pronounce anything. Mr. Holland found nothing to verbalize that might help him. The conversation concluded without ever having begun.

NARRATION: Holland expired assimilating two certainties. The first: that the profit margin he had obtained from the sale of the fair-haired boy had turned out, in the end, to be an unforgivable miscalculation.

NARRATION: The second: that the intuition which, weeks earlier, had advised him to sign the transaction swiftly and without asking questions, would be logged as the last useful intuition of his existence.

(Glenn releases the body, which drops to the floor, already turned into a useless mass.)

QUICK CUT — THE MASTER BEDROOM

(Mrs. Holland wakes. She has heard something. She lights a candle. She leans out, in her nightgown, into the darkness of the corridor.)

(Glenn waits for her at the far end.)

(She lets out no scream. The hand holding the candlestick begins to tremble.)

NARRATION: Glenn did not consider the woman innocent.

NARRATION: He had deduced, crossing the comment her husband had let slip at the party with the superficial readings he had taken of him, that Mrs. Holland was the true architect of the daily suffering. She was the one who erased the original names to assign slave nomenclatures. The one who had stripped Johannes of his identity to assign him "Coltrane."

NARRATION: He was certain that she herself had ordered the first pair of shackles forged to his measure, when the child was barely eight years old. Glenn had managed to project the image: her, seated stoically before the boy, measuring the diameter of his wrist and demanding that the blacksmith leave him room to grow.

NARRATION: Glenn did not speak to the people he was about to liquidate.

NARRATION: But with her, for the span of one entire second, he weighed the temptation to make an exception.

NARRATION: Discipline won.

(The candle falls. It goes out as it strikes the floor.)

QUICK CUT — THE OAK

(The hundred-year-old oak, set at the southern boundary of the property. It is the same tree beneath which the Hollands received their guests during the warm months. The same one from which, according to the records Glenn had drawn from the surroundings, more than one slave had been hanged as a corrective measure.)

(Glenn reaches the trunk carrying the two bodies. He bears one over each shoulder, like a day laborer hauling two sacks of grain. He sets them down in the grass.)

(He draws from the inner pocket of his coat two lengths of rope. He had knotted them himself on the carriage box, during the journey, while Coltrane remained inside the cabin, sunk in an absolute silence.)

(He throws the first end over the lowest, sturdiest branch. He fixes the anchor. He raises Mr. Holland's body, holding it by the neck, and lets it hang. The branch creaks, protesting, but it holds. The branches of that oak were designed to tolerate greater strains.)

(He repeats the procedure with the second body. He finishes. He takes a step back. He checks the result.)

NARRATION: Glenn had left no margin for improvisation that night. Hanging the bodies from the oak had figured in his planning for weeks.

NARRATION: The choice required no exhaustive analysis, only a concise one: the tree belonged to them, and from that early morning on it would belong to their dead, and so it would remain for the rest of the days the oak had left of being a tree.

QUICK CUT — THE FIRE

(Glenn heads back toward the main residence. He veers off toward the barn. He unties the knot of one of the lanterns hanging at the entrance. He opens it. The flame inside flickers, alive.)

(He tilts it and rests the edge against a heap of dry straw, and stays watching a couple of seconds: the exact time needed to certify that combustion has begun. The straw is highly volatile.)

(He leaves the enclosure before the heat becomes an inconvenience. He resumes his march toward the house.)

NARRATION: The fire demanded no help beyond the first spark.

NARRATION: The old accumulated straw, the beams desiccated by decades of summer exposure, the heavy cloth curtains, the imported tablecloths, the furniture woods polished with wax year after year... the Holland mansion had no idea it had spent its entire existence preparing to burn.

NARRATION: Glenn had only come to remind it.

(He crosses the vestibule once more. He brings the exposed flame to the hem of the curtain in the main dining room. He brings the flame to the dried flowers in a vase. He climbs the main staircase and brings it to the bedding of Mrs. Holland's bedroom, which remains as rumpled as she left it when she rose a few minutes earlier.)

(Satisfied, Glenn walks out the front door, with the unhurried ease of a farmhand who has just called his workday done.)

QUICK CUT — THE QUARTERS

(The slave quarters, at the far end of the property. A child wakes with a start. His mother presses her hand against his mouth. "Shhh." Heavy footsteps are heard on the gravel. A door opening.)

(An old man steps out into the yard. He raises his eyes toward the structure of the main mansion. And, in a second, he understands everything.)

(The old man closes the door behind him. He does not go back inside. He stays planted in the middle of the yard, his face lit, wearing an expression no one in his long life had seen him display.)

(Around him, the doors begin to open, one after another. At first with frightened slowness. Then, with the growing certainty that what is happening out there does not belong to the territory of dreams... or of nightmares.)

FIRST IMAGE

(CG: The front clearing of the estate. In the background, the mansion burning: violent orange light cut against the black of the night. Off to one side, bathed in the glow of the flames, the low branches of the

oak hold two dark forms that hang completely motionless.)

(In the foreground, the slaves emerging into open ground: bodies outlined in silhouette, faces lit only halfway. A man covering his mouth with both hands, not yet knowing whether what he is about to let out is a burst of laughter or a scream. A woman with a baby pressed against her chest, watching the mansion burn with utterly dry eyes. A small child who does not understand what he is witnessing, but who is learning. An old woman who drops heavily to her knees against the earth: not out of fear, but out of something else.)

(And at the very back, at the edge of the yard, a figure standing, motionless, impeccable, his back to the fire.)

(Glenn.)

NARRATION: Glenn did not run. He did not shout. He needed to do neither. In the midst of the absolute chaos, he was the only one at peace.

NARRATION: The slaves came out into the night. Some broke into a stampede across the croplands. Some laughed hysterically. Others wept. Most, simply, did not know exactly what they were supposed to feel in a moment like this.

NARRATION: Some interrupted their flight on making out the silhouette of the tree, and stayed contemplating the bodies with an expression that has no name in any language in the world. Because for a word to exist that designates an emotion, the collective experience of feeling it must exist first; and that experience, that night, was entirely unknown.

NARRATION: One woman (one of the oldest of the slaves) approached the oak. She did not go so far as to touch the bodies. She only planted herself before them, hands resting on her hips, and appraised the scene for a long while.

NARRATION: Then she nodded a single time, like someone closing a matter, and walked away without looking back.

NARRATION: Others passed by without stopping. Many ran off toward the edge of the woods and did not slacken their pace. Glenn intercepted none of them. His task that night belonged to another category.

QUICK CUT — THE CARRIAGE

(Coltrane opens, at last, the cabin door. He climbs down. The driver does not look his way. He has worked on Glenn's payroll enough years to know that there are early mornings when the work demands keeping one's eyes fixed elsewhere.)

(Coltrane begins to walk toward the orange glow. He does not run. He is not capable of running. His body does not yet know how to quicken its pace without having received express permission from a master to do so.)

NARRATION: What Glenn had omitted to consider, throughout all the planning phases of that massacre, was whether the boy wished to witness the result or not.

NARRATION: He had taken it for granted. He, in his place, would have wanted to see it. Glenn still found it almost impossible to trace the line separating what *he* himself would have wished from what his son would actually want.

QUICK CUT — THE CLEARING

(Coltrane crosses the last bend in the path that opens onto the clearing of the main house. He stops dead.)

(What lies before his eyes is burning in perfect order.)

(The dozens of slaves move in small groups, scattered without pattern across the whole clearing. Some try to head toward him on recognizing him. Others are too stunned by the visual impact to head anywhere at all.)

(And at the very center of the whole picture, cut against the fire, is she.)

QUICK CUT — ANNIE

(Annie finds him first. She comes walking, without running. She is barefoot. She wears a blanket thrown over her shoulders. The swell of her belly shows beneath the cloth.)

(Coltrane recognizes her and his body locks.)

(She stops a few paces away.)

(They stay like that a moment. Each one calculating whether his own body still remembers how to do what was never permitted them in front of the mansion.)

(Annie takes the first step. Coltrane the second.)

NARRATION: What happens next has none of the elegance of a reunion. It is clumsy. Annie raises a hand toward his face and leaves it suspended in the air a second, irresolute, as though what she is about to touch does not match the boy she knew.

NARRATION: Coltrane does not wait for her to decide. He takes her by the shoulders and draws her toward him.

(They embrace.)

NARRATION: It is a brief contact. And it is hard. Annie's belly comes between them and they both notice it.

NARRATION: Coltrane feels the bones of her back, sharper than he remembered them. Annie perceives in him something that did not figure in her memories: an unfamiliar density, a different way of breathing.

(They separate.)

SECOND IMAGE

(CG: Annie and Coltrane in the clearing. She with the blanket over her shoulders, the belly marked beneath the cloth, her eyes fixed on him. He with his head tilted slightly toward her, his hands still halfway between her body and his own, not knowing exactly where to leave them. Behind, far off, the glow of the fire. The blaze does not touch them yet: it reaches them as a heat at the edge of the skin.)

NARRATION: It was not a sustained embrace. There was no room for it.

NARRATION: But both of them would remember it for the rest of their lives with a precision neither of them had requested. Definitive things are engraved that way: without asking authorization to occupy space in the memory.

NARRATION: That early morning, they believed it was a beginning. They projected the coming

months, the child about to be born, Glenn's estate as a perimeter within which the possibility of a life might fit.

NARRATION: Annie considered it with caution. Coltrane processed it with a relief he did not yet allow himself to label. Both were wrong in the forecast.

NARRATION: The magnitude of that error would reveal itself to them later. For now, in the clearing, they had just embraced for the last time without knowing it. And that ignorance, seen in perspective, was an act of mercy.

ANNIE: *(in a low voice)* Cole. What happened?

(Coltrane does not answer.)

(Annie turns her head, slowly. She scans the whole scene: the barn, the mansion in flames, the scattered groups. And at the end, without meaning to, her eyes come to rest on the tree.)

(She stays fixed on it.)

NARRATION: Annie had not accumulated a great volume of images in her life. That was the very definition of being a slave: existing within a minuscule, predictable radius. But she had seen enough.

NARRATION: She had seen other men hang from that same oak, in different years, for different offenses. Analyzing the two figures now, she deduced at once that the author behind all this operated with the same technique. She knew exactly how it was done. The only difference was that, this time, the subjects were the Hollands.

NARRATION: She knew, without anyone telling her, that a normal man does not operate that way.

NARRATION: A normal man, when he means to free slaves, organizes a clandestine escape. A normal man, when he seeks revenge, uses a firearm. A normal man, when he sets fire to a property, ends up with burns or ash on his own clothing.

NARRATION: And a normal man never raises two adults to a high branch, alone, in the dead of night, without leaving the slightest trace of fatigue in the process.

NARRATION: Nothing before her eyes was the work of a normal man.

(Annie fixes her gaze on Coltrane again. She scrutinizes him as though trying to measure how much of all this had been known to him beforehand.)

NARRATION: Whether he had left her alone on the Holland estate foreseeing that this slaughter was going to occur. Whether, beneath all that silence, he was still the boy who used to lie down beside her in the stable.

(Coltrane lowers his face. He cannot hold her gaze.)

QUICK CUT — THE FOOT OF THE TREE

(Coltrane advances. Annie does not follow him. She remains exactly where she was.)

(He reaches the foot of the trunk. He lifts his face and looks.)

NARRATION: He fixed his eyes on the oak. He did not look away for a long time.

NARRATION: What he experienced had no label in his archive. It was not relief, because relief presupposes that the pain concludes, and that pain was not going to conclude.

NARRATION: It was not vengeance, because vengeance requires execution by one's own hand, and he had executed nothing.

NARRATION: It was not justice, because he had gone too long without believing in justice.

NARRATION: The closest he came to classifying it happened years later, in a sentence he never put to anyone: that for a minute, beneath that tree, he felt that a part of him had stopped weighing on him.

NARRATION: That a ballast he had carried for years had been lifted down off him. And that on lifting it down, he discovered that beneath it was not what he expected. There was no peace. There was only something more rancid, harder to quantify, and that particular weight was never going to be lifted down at all.

NARRATION: But for a minute, while he assessed the tree, he believed it would be. He believed the cycle had ended.

NARRATION: And that was the exact minute (he would process it afterward) in which the last human fragment inside him took its leave without his being able to notice its departure.

QUICK CUT — THE TRIAD

(Annie approaches from behind. She does not place herself at his side. She positions herself slightly behind. Not as a gesture of submission, but for another reason: because she has not yet determined whether she wishes to remain beside him, behind him, or far from him.)

(The "behind" is the only location from which she can keep observing him without being forced to make the decision.)

(Glenn breaks into the frame. He advances without hurry. He crosses the clearing with the ease of an owner who has walked it hundreds of times, though it is his first time on the ground. He stops behind the two of them.)

THIRD IMAGE

(CG: The perfect triad. Coltrane in the foreground, facing the oak. Annie a step behind, ignoring the blaze to fix her eyes on Coltrane's profile; her face is pure horror tinged with a resolve still unnameable. At the back, Glenn, closing the group. Impeccable. Not a single speck of ash on his clothing. He gives Coltrane one of those looks of his that grant no information at all. Then he lifts his eyes toward the tree.)

(None of the three utters a single word.)

(It is not necessary.)

NARRATION: Annie knew, without anyone confirming it for her, that the boy before her was no longer the one she had known.

NARRATION: She understood that the events of that early morning had finished altering him. And that she did not know whether she would be able to live with that.

NARRATION: There once existed a version of Glenn Sheridan (the drinking farmer of Richmond, the one who squandered canvases painting models in squalid little rooms) that would have felt profoundly sickened before this scene.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: That version had been squandered fifteen years ago.

(The mansion fire goes on consuming itself in the background. The static image holds on screen a few seconds longer than is tolerable.)

(FADE TO BLACK)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The conversion. *Virginia, ~1780.*

NARRATION: The authorities' investigation lasted less than a week. Slave revolt, they concluded.

NARRATION: The masters hanged, the mansion reduced to ashes, the slaves gone. The numbers added up without needing further audit. Case closed.

NARRATION: It was the most convenient explanation for everyone involved in the county. In the Virginia of 1780, convenience carried considerable weight.

QUICK CUT — THE DISTRIBUTION

NARRATION: The house reorganized itself in the first days.

NARRATION: Annie was placed in the room on the first floor, the one facing the east garden. It was the best in the estate after Glenn's own: a large window, a wide bed, and a door with a bolt on the inside.

NARRATION: Glenn had ordered it prepared before dawn. The initiative had been entirely his; Coltrane had not had to ask.

NARRATION: And although Annie did not thank him for the room when it was shown to her, she did take it in with her eyes in a way Glenn had never recognized before: with the expression of a young woman acknowledging, after a whole life, what it means to have the power to close a door from the inside.

NARRATION: Coltrane stayed in his room in the west wing. Glenn in his, in the north wing. The other women who had arrived with Annie chose, out of habit, two rooms in the service quarters.

NARRATION: The men settled in the annex pavilion, next to the houses already occupied by Glenn's former slaves. People who had been waiting, for years, without knowing they were waiting, for a night like the one of the fire.

NARRATION: It was the first time in six years the estate had real people living in it. Glenn had not noticed, until that moment, how silent the property had been. The stillness he had always mistaken for an architectural virtue turned out to be, simply, absence.

(Beat.)

NARRATION: The distribution among the three of them (Glenn, Coltrane, Annie) settled without anyone having to articulate it.

NARRATION: Annie did not enter Coltrane's room. Coltrane did not cross Annie's threshold. Glenn did not enter either. Each remained in the square that belonged to them, as though the house were a chessboard, and the only rule in force was not to step into the others'.

NARRATION: Glenn observed the dynamic for several days, without quite understanding why the arrangement unsettled him so.

(FADE TO BLACK.)

QUICK CUT — THE KITCHEN THRESHOLD

(An ordinary night. The kitchen of the estate.)

(Annie is sitting at the table. Her hair is tied up with a cloth. She is peeling something: potatoes, apples; it hardly matters. Coltrane is speaking to her in a low voice, leaning over the wood. Glenn hears them from the threshold.)

(Annie laughs.)

(It is a brief laugh, without sound. It lights up her face for half a second and goes out at once, because she learned long ago that the laughter of women of her condition must not take up volume in rooms that do not belong to them.)

(But the laugh existed.)

(Coltrane smiles.)

NARRATION: Glenn looked at them from the threshold for a stretch of time he did not bother to count. Long enough to register the whole picture.

NARRATION: The two young people in the kitchen. She, six months pregnant. He, seventeen years old, trying to learn how to move inside a house that did not belong to anyone like him. The trembling light of the candles outlining their contours.

NARRATION: It was, possibly, the first time since he had left his home in Richmond that he had seen something like this so close. A possible life. Imperfect, cut short, but possible.

NARRATION: It was exactly the kind of thing a man who was not him would have known how to safeguard.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn turned away in the hallway without making the slightest sound. The decision, already made, did not allow witnesses.

QUICK CUT — THE INVITATION

(That same night.)

(Glenn is standing in the threshold of the room assigned to Coltrane. He does not knock. He waits for Coltrane to look up from the book he is reading.)

(Coltrane looks up.)

GLENN: Come with me.

COLTRANE: Where?

GLENN: To my study.

(Coltrane closes the book. He sets it on the bed, slipping a marker between the pages: the methodical gesture of someone who knows he will not be opening it again that night.)

NARRATION: During the few months he had been living in the house, Coltrane had absorbed one fact: Glenn did not cross the door of his room.

NARRATION: It was a rule of boundaries neither of them had ever stated aloud, but that both observed strictly. Glenn had not yet learned how to remain alone with Coltrane without placing a book, a canvas, or some physical excuse between the two of them.

NARRATION: That the red-haired man should be standing in his threshold that night, breaking the rule, meant something imminent.

(Coltrane gets up and follows him.)

QUICK CUT — THE STUDY

(Glenn's study. A single lamp lit.)

(The room has walls covered in books, an easel covered with a sheet in one corner, and two armchairs facing each other over a low table. There is no fire in the hearth. It is October and the room is markedly cold. Glenn is no longer affected by temperature, and it does not cross his mind that Coltrane is.)

(Glenn closes the door.)

NARRATION: He closed it carefully. Not with the stealth of someone who does not wish to be heard in the house, but with the slowness of someone postponing something imminent.

NARRATION: Each small movement was a reprieve. Coltrane noticed it at once. He had invested an entire childhood at the Holland mansion learning to interpret the reprieves of the masters.

(Glenn turns toward the room. Coltrane remains standing near the armchairs, his hands hanging at his sides, not knowing exactly where to place them.)

GLENN: Sit down, please.

COLTRANE: *(does not obey the order)* Why have you called me here?

NARRATION: Glenn had rehearsed this moment. And he had rehearsed it badly. The speech he had prepared for weeks slipped from his mind the exact instant he went to look for it; the typical carelessness of important words when the time finally comes to use them.

GLENN: To speak.

NARRATION: The phrase sounded clumsy, hollow. Glenn noticed it at once.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: He closed his eyes for a second, without meaning to. When he opened them again, he assumed the reprieve had run out. The verbal clumsiness was only another form of delay, and delay was no longer going to spare him from what he had to do.

GLENN: Come a little closer, please.

(Coltrane does not move a muscle.)

COLTRANE: What are you?

NARRATION: He said it without altering the volume of his voice. Without a tone of accusation. He framed it as a question that had already come with an answer before entering the room, and that was only awaiting the formality of confirmation.

NARRATION: Glenn had not contemplated that question. He had anticipated every possible question from a former slave. Not that one.

(Glenn does not answer with words. He does not answer with anything.)

(Coltrane does not take his eyes off his face.)

NARRATION: In the course of a few seconds, Glenn processed several things at once.

NARRATION: He took in that Coltrane had known the whole time. He took in his own stupidity for believing that a boy who had survived the Holland mansion would not learn to detect the scent of predators.

NARRATION: Above all, he registered that he would no longer have to explain anything. And he understood that this was the cruelty of the night: that the saving of words was going to be paid for by Coltrane, not by him.

(Glenn falls into absolute stillness. So does Coltrane.)

NARRATION: The boy was looking for something else. A validation that silence, by its very nature, was never going to give him.

(A very long pause.)

(Coltrane takes a step toward Glenn.)

GLENN: *(barely above a whisper)* This doesn't have to happen.

COLTRANE: I know.

NARRATION: It wasn't true. It did have to happen. The only person in the room who still didn't understand that the verdict was already settled was Glenn, and he finished understanding it at that exact moment.

GLENN: I can leave you alone.

COLTRANE: No.

(Pause.)

COLTRANE: Do it.

NARRATION: Glenn looked at him. The expression Coltrane returned was not that of a boy requesting something. It was that of someone who had spent years internalizing that the things that happen to him do not ask permission, and that the only exercise of will left to him is to decide whether to oppose them or not.

NARRATION: Glenn could have read what lived beneath that face. He had the ability to do it. He had used it a thousand times: on strangers, on debtors, on Holland himself. He could have known, with absolute precision, whether this was what Coltrane really wanted.

NARRATION: He didn't.

NARRATION: He chose, instead, to take refuge in ignorance. If he was going to turn him, he would do it by exercising the supreme cowardice of not asking his mind what his own ears were not willing to hear.

NARRATION: Coltrane did not oppose it.

NARRATION: Glenn would have preferred that he did.

(FADE TO BLACK)

QUICK CUT — AFTER

(The same room. The oil level of the lamp has gone down, dimming the light.)

(Coltrane is sitting in one of the armchairs. Still. Absolutely inert.)

NARRATION: Glenn had executed what he believed he had to do. He had done it with the profound

revulsion of someone who is aware of what he is drinking.

NARRATION: It wasn't just any blood. It was the closest to his own that he was ever going to taste. It had a flavor he recognized without wanting to, and that he made extra effort not to remember.

NARRATION: When he stopped, Coltrane was still breathing. Faintly, but breathing. That was all the physiology of the conversion required. He did not stop a milliliter before or a milliliter after. The drainage calculation had been exact. If Glenn was a master of anything, it was precision.

NARRATION: Then he proceeded with the return of the blood. An exchange he found equally repugnant.

(Coltrane opens his eyes.)

NARRATION: They were no longer Diana's eyes.

NARRATION: Glenn had not anticipated that loss. He had spent months crossing paths with those eyes in the hallways of the estate, encountering the last remnant of his wife in the face of his son, and he had reached a point where the sight no longer caused him pain.

NARRATION: The face was still, physically, the same. But the gaze belonged to another creature.

NARRATION: What Coltrane was absorbing with those new eyes was also different. Glenn did not need to read his mind to corroborate it: he himself had experienced it years before, beneath a tree.

NARRATION: The shadows assuming solid edges. The edges revealing underlying layers. A leaf in the garden, thirty paces away, returning his gaze with a level of detail in its veins that the human eye could not interpret. The world taking on, for the first time, a wholly new way of existing.

NARRATION: Glenn granted him the time needed to look.

(Pause.)

GLENN: *(from the other end of the room)* You're hungry.

NARRATION: It was not a question. Coltrane did not answer. He was, in fact, hungry. He registered it the moment he heard Glenn's statement. It was a kind of hunger he had never experienced and that, nevertheless, he identified at once. As if he had been waiting for it since before he was born.

GLENN: Let's go.

QUICK CUT — THE HUNT

(The scene stays in black. There are no images.)

NARRATION: They left through the back door, so as not to wake Annie. Coltrane did not wish to disturb her, and Glenn preferred to keep Annie from seeing Coltrane in the light of that night. For once in their shared existence, the interests of the two aligned.

NARRATION: Of what occurred over the following hours, neither of them would ever speak again. Ever.

NARRATION: And not from an excess of shame, but out of operational prudence: speaking of the matter would have materialized it. It would have turned it into a fact set in cement.

NARRATION: And both of them preferred for the night to be reduced to what it strictly was: a dark, long stretch, full of methodical guidance Coltrane had not requested and Glenn had imparted only out of obligation.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: They returned to the estate before dawn.

QUICK CUT — THE STUDY, AGAIN

(Glenn alone. The lamp is out. The room is in absolute dimness.)

(He is sitting in the same armchair Coltrane had occupied a couple of hours earlier. His hands rest on his lap. He has not washed them. It would have been an incongruity to do so: in his new existence there was no stain that did not vanish on its own with the passing of the hours.)

NARRATION: He thought, for the first time in a very long time, of his mother's face. He could not explain why.

NARRATION: Coltrane had withdrawn to his room. He was going to sleep as the newly turned sleep: as those who have just died a little do.

NARRATION: Glenn knew this from his own experience. He had slept that way once, and Juno had watched him from the corner of a room without making a single sound.

NARRATION: No one was watching him now.

NARRATION: Glenn had imagined for years that the moment of doing to another what Juno had done to him would constitute a moment of a certain cosmic correspondence.

NARRATION: It had taken him until that very night to understand that what Juno had felt when she turned him bore no similarity to what he was experiencing now. What had guided Juno (Glenn analyzed it from here with unprecedented sharpness) had been a kind of frivolous, almost distracted impulse. What he was feeling belonged to another category altogether.

NARRATION: He had transferred the weight. He had spent more than fifteen years accumulating something dire that had no label, and that night, without uttering it, without quite understanding why he had chosen that precise moment, he had dealt it to Coltrane.

NARRATION: Coltrane had not requested it. Coltrane did not even possess the parameters to interpret what he had received. But he had received it. Glenn had let it go, and anything let go is bound to strike something.

(Beat.)

NARRATION: The room felt emptier than it had hours earlier.

NARRATION: Glenn, too.

(FADE TO BLACK.)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The Two Farewells. *Virginia. ~1780–1782.*

(An ordinary night. A week after the massacre.)

(Glenn passes down the corridor adjoining the kitchen. He was headed elsewhere, but he stops in the doorway without having decided to. He watches a scene that is already beginning to turn ordinary:

Annie seated at the table, peeling a piece of fruit. Coltrane across from her, not too close, an empty stool marking the distance between them, talking to her in a low voice about nothing in particular; only to keep the air moving.)

(Annie laughs. It is half a laugh. Her face lights for half a second and goes out. Coltrane smiles.)

NARRATION: Glenn watched them from the doorway with an attention that startled even him. He was trying to understand how the thing he was seeing worked. And it did not come easily.

NARRATION: What he had before him was a young man with barely seven days of immortality, seated a metre and a half from the woman he loved. A woman six months pregnant.

NARRATION: A woman whose blood reached Coltrane through the pores of her skin, through the friction of the cloth of her dress, through the wave of heat she displaced in the air as she moved.

NARRATION: And Coltrane had not moved. He spoke to her in a low voice, with the absolute concentration of someone holding an extremely fragile object. And Annie gave him back half a smile.

NARRATION: Glenn thought, without having planned to, of Diana.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: He thought of what he himself had done sixteen years earlier. Of the small hours in which he had left the house with nothing but what he had on. Of how he had not gone to the cradle to say goodbye to the child. Of how he had not dared say goodbye to Diana. Of how he had not even thought to try.

NARRATION: He had handed Juno, during those first weeks, a more creditable version of the story: that he had fled to protect Diana. So as not to risk harming her. Out of love.

NARRATION: Juno had nodded without believing a single word. Juno had spent centuries watching newly turned men tell themselves clean versions of their own flight, and she knew the pattern.

NARRATION: The truth (Glenn saw it now, laid bare from the kitchen doorway) was far simpler: he had not stayed because he lacked the courage.

NARRATION: Becoming what he was and remaining at Diana's side would have required a kind of endurance he did not, at that time, possess. He had left, quite simply, because leaving was easier than trying.

NARRATION: Coltrane, by contrast, had stayed.

NARRATION: Coltrane, who was seven days immortal, who had been on edge for weeks, who had asked for none of this, sat a metre and a half from Annie, holding himself in check and holding her gaze when she laughed.

NARRATION: Coltrane was carrying out, without anyone having told him it was possible, exactly what he himself had not even attempted.

(Long pause.)

(Glenn draws back from the doorway before either of them sees him. He goes down to the study. He sits in the armchair without opening any book.)

NARRATION: For sixteen years he had believed of himself, without ever having put it into words, that his flight had been a form of nobility. That a less noble man would have stayed to do harm. That he had left out of love.

NARRATION: Coltrane had just proved to him, without meaning to, that the whole structure was a lie.

NARRATION: The information arrived too late: for Diana, for himself, for everything. But it arrived.

NARRATION: And Glenn, who had learned to file everything away, found that he had no drawer in which to file this.

(FADE TO BLACK)

QUICK CUT — THE CONVERSATION GLENN SHOULD NOT HEAR

(Three weeks later. Glenn in his study. A single lit candle. An open book he is not reading.)

NARRATION: He heard it without meaning to. The ears of the immortal do not switch off, and Glenn had never developed the discipline required to ignore what was not his to hear.

NARRATION: Annie and Coltrane were sitting outside, on the bench at the edge of the garden. They were speaking in low voices, with the eagerness of people who are no longer in any hurry to finish things.

NARRATION: Glenn caught three words and knew at once that he should catch no more.

NARRATION: The three words were: *what are you*.

NARRATION: He closed the book. He did not do it in order not to hear: he knew there was no way to block the sound. He closed it out of a kind of respect he had not practised in a long time and did not expect to feel again. This was Coltrane's conversation, not his.

NARRATION: He heard the whole of it anyway.

NARRATION: Annie was not asking in order to condemn; she was asking to confirm what she already knew. Glenn had appraised many voices in his life, in many rooms, and he recognised perfectly the difference between a question that seeks an answer and a question that seeks closure.

NARRATION: Annie's was the second. And when Coltrane did not answer, Glenn knew (with the precision of someone who has spent years estimating the exact weight of silences) that that absence of an answer had just closed the conversation.

NARRATION: Then he heard something else. Annie saying something about raising the child far away. Coltrane, not answering. Annie saying something about not hating him. Coltrane, not answering.

NARRATION: And then, what Glenn did not expect.

NARRATION: Annie, stifling a cry.

NARRATION: Glenn did not know what she was reacting to. It was a sound too brief and too contained to reconstruct the scene from the study. But it was (this much he did manage to identify) a cry of horror.

NARRATION: Not of fear. Of horror. Glenn knew the difference well: fear attaches to the unknown; horror attaches to something just recognised. And Annie had just recognised something.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Whatever it was, it had confirmed the suspicion she had been harbouring for weeks. Glenn did not need to know what exactly it had been. What mattered to him was the effect.

NARRATION: The decision that woman had been silently putting off for three weeks had just been made, and it was going to fall to him to sign a cheque before daybreak.

(FADE TO BLACK)

QUICK CUT — THE COACH HOUSE. BEFORE DAWN

(Glenn stands inside the coach house. The light has not yet shown above the horizon. There are three women in the yard: Annie, another with a bundle, and a third with her belongings knotted in a cloth. Annie carries little. Everything she owns fits in a cloth bag.)

(Coltrane is outside, some fifteen metres off, keeping his distance. He has not moved. Glenn has been watching him from the shadows with the private impression of looking at a young horse that has been split clean in half, and does not yet know it is split because it is still standing.)

(GLENN approaches ANNIE. He holds out an envelope. It is not bulky, but it holds exactly enough. Glenn has gone over the sum twice during the night.)

GLENN: *(in a low voice, without ceremony)* For the journey. And for the first months.

(Annie looks at the envelope. Then she looks at him. Glenn holds her gaze expecting nothing in particular: neither thanks nor reproach. He is prepared to accept whatever she decides to do with the envelope.)

(Annie takes it. She does not give thanks; Glenn did not expect any.)

ANNIE: *(without raising her voice, indicating ever so faintly with her eyes toward where Coltrane stands)* How long has he been like this?

NARRATION: Glenn grasped the full breadth of the question without needing to ask for clarification. How long has he been what he is. How long has he been in this house with you, being *that*. How long have you let me live with that under the same roof without warning me.

GLENN: Three weeks.

(Annie nods, very slowly.)

ANNIE: And you?

NARRATION: Glenn was on the point of lying. It was the easiest thing. Offer a credible number, a sober story, and settle the matter.

NARRATION: But the woman was already leaving, and lying to someone who already has one foot out the door is an effort with no return. Annie, besides, was not the sort to spread the information: she was the sort who took it all to the grave.

GLENN: Sixteen years.

NARRATION: Seen from outside, Annie seemed not to have reacted. She simply processed it.

NARRATION: Glenn, watching her, could make out the gears turning. She was a woman accustomed to doing silent sums to survive, and Glenn saw the exact moment the sums tallied.

NARRATION: Sixteen years. Coltrane was seventeen. His mother had sold him to the Hollands shortly before he turned two.

NARRATION: And a man with sixteen years as an immortal who appeared for a single night at a county party, picked out one slave among a hundred without ever having seen him, paid the debt without haggling, and took him home... that man was no casual buyer.

NARRATION: That man was something else.

NARRATION: Annie did not say it aloud. There was no need.

NARRATION: Glenn watched her file the information away. He watched her store it the way women like Annie stored dangerous things: in a mental drawer that would stay shut until the end of her days.

NARRATION: Not because she would forget it, but because she had learned that certain truths, once taken out of their drawers, did far more harm outside than in.

ANNIE: *(looking toward the distance where Coltrane stands, but without looking at him directly)* Look after him.

GLENN: *(without thinking)* I will.

NARRATION: He said it too quickly. With too much sincerity. Even he was surprised by the lack of control in his tone.

NARRATION: It had been years since he had affirmed anything without first running the answer through at least three filters. That *"I will"* had come out on its own, the way directives surface when the body has already decided them long before consulting the head.

NARRATION: Annie noticed. Glenn saw that she noticed. He saw, too, that that *"I will,"* spoken with that unusual bareness, was possibly the only thing Annie would take from that estate she would consider truly useful.

ANNIE: *(nods once)* God help you, then.

NARRATION: She did not say it with sarcasm: she no longer had the energy for that. She said it with the literalness of a woman who believes in God and who hands out blessings to whoever might need them, regardless of whether they deserve them or not.

NARRATION: Glenn could not remember the last time anyone had spoken to him of God without irony. He took a second too long to register that the words were meant in earnest.

NARRATION: By the time he finally accepted it, it was too late to offer a reply: Annie had turned around and was walking toward the other two women. The conversation was over.

QUICK CUT — LAST IMAGE

(Coltrane outside the coach house, keeping his distance. Glenn within, in the half-dark. The three women moving off down a dirt road. Annie does not turn back. The other two do, once. The dawn beginning to open on the horizon like a slow wound.)

NARRATION: Coltrane did not move until the women's figures vanished beyond the bend. Glenn did not come out of the coach house.

NARRATION: The two of them stayed like that, separated by a few metres and by the whole space of the yard, for a stretch of time neither of them bothered to count.

(FADE TO BLACK)

QUICK CUT — THE HOUSE, AFTER

NARRATION: Glenn had lived alone with Juno for fifteen years. He knew, therefore, what it was to share space with someone without truly living alongside them.

NARRATION: What he discovered in the months following Annie's departure was that living with Coltrane was a dynamic of another nature. The difference revealed itself to Glenn over time, and it was structurally simple: with Juno, he had been the pupil. With Coltrane, without having chosen it, he had become the master.

NARRATION: And masters could not vanish into a room, just like that. Masters were watched under constant scrutiny.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The months passed in staggered interrogations.

NARRATION: Coltrane did not press. He did not insist. He only let the questions fall at irregular intervals: two in a single night, none in five days, one in isolation in the library, three in a row during a walk through the woods.

NARRATION: He did it with the same silent technique by which he had learned to steal vocabulary from the doorway of the Holland children's schoolroom. Each question was cheap to ask, but extremely expensive to answer. Glenn noticed after a month. Coltrane had known from the first.

COLTRANE: *(one night, with no prior context)* How old were you when you were turned?

GLENN: Thirty-five.

COLTRANE: And how old are you now?

(A pause.)

GLENN: The same.

(Coltrane looks at him for a moment.)

COLTRANE: Who did it?

GLENN: *(without looking away)* No one you know.

COLTRANE: Is she still alive?

(A longer pause.)

GLENN: Yes.

COLTRANE: Where does she live?

GLENN: In Europe.

COLTRANE: Does she know I exist?

NARRATION: Glenn was slow to answer this one. It was the first question of the night for which he had no evasive manoeuvre already formulated.

GLENN: No.

COLTRANE: Are you going to tell her?

GLENN: I don't think so.

COLTRANE: Why not?

GLENN: *(with a neutrality that functioned, in itself, as an answer)* Because I don't think it's any of her concern.

NARRATION: Coltrane nodded slowly. Not as a sign of acceptance, but of recording.

NARRATION: Glenn had begun to recognise that gesture: it was the confirmation of someone filing information away to access it later, when he was alone and the supplier of the content was no longer present.

NARRATION: The quantity of dossiers Coltrane was filing began to unsettle him. But it unsettled him slowly; with the kind of unease that does not compete with other urgencies for the simple reason that there were no other urgencies.

NARRATION: Glenn no longer had a human life to defend. For fifteen years, his entire life had been Juno. And now that Juno was gone, the empty space filled with the presence of Coltrane. Which was not exactly living, but was not exactly nothing either.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: It was, as Glenn would discover one early morning, something closer to a calm he had never experienced before.

NARRATION: That kind of deceptive calm people mistake for happiness when they have gone too long without being happy.

NARRATION: It was hard for him to admit. Hard, because validating that calm meant having to admit too many other things he still preferred to keep in the dark.

(FADE TO BLACK)

QUICK CUT — THE SIGNAL

NARRATION: They had been operating like that for a little over a year when the signal arrived.

NARRATION: Glenn was not doing anything in particular. It was an ordinary night at the end of summer. He had "dined" with Coltrane (the two of them performed the choreography of sitting together at the table without touching a bite, solely to give the day a shape) and afterward he had withdrawn to the porch with a glass of liquor that had for months been a strictly symbolic object.

NARRATION: Coltrane was on his usual stone bench, at the edge of the garden, looking toward the line of the woods.

NARRATION: The night had the monotonous consistency of all nights. A half moon. Warm air. The distant smell of the horses in the stable. On evenings like that one, Glenn permitted himself a degree of mental inactivity that in other eras he would have classified as a structural hazard, but that now resembled simple routine maintenance.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: And then, without warning, Glenn's consciousness left the porch.

NARRATION: Not entirely. Physically, his body remained anchored where it had been a second earlier: seated, glass in hand, his back resting against the back of the chair. But his attention had detached from the flesh and was somewhere else.

NARRATION: The sensation was almost identical to the lucid dreams he remembered from his biological life: the ones that came when exhaustion overcame you sitting in a chair and sleep broke in without transition. You went on perceiving the acoustics of the room, but you inhabited another space at the same time.

NARRATION: The other place was a forest.

NARRATION: Trees that belonged neither to Virginia, nor to any place in the geography he could identify. The light was different: further north, colder, older.

NARRATION: A residence in the background, barely suggested among the branches, with the exact silhouette of the European stone constructions he had stopped registering in his memory long ago, because looking at them was inconvenient for him.

NARRATION: And then the rest arrived. Without a name and without tangible form.

NARRATION: Decades of a residue that had been accumulating in the most absolute silence. A cage

with no physical bars. A weeping that had exhausted every avenue of escape. A despair that was neither explosive nor loud, but domestic. The suffocation of someone who has grown tired of harbouring hope, but has found nothing else to replace it with.

NARRATION: Glenn took the impact and deciphered it because it was real. And the real still managed to pierce him, despite him having spent sixteen years emptying out inside.

NARRATION: He understood it on a level the rational mind never grazed: he understood it beneath analysis, in that stratum where the things that had once been true went on recognising one another.

NARRATION: Juno.

(Long pause.)

NARRATION: The transmission lasted a couple of seconds. Perhaps less. When it cut off, Glenn returned to the porch with the violent jolt of someone coming back from a dream that felt quite real until the exact instant of waking.

NARRATION: The glass was still intact in his hand. He had not spilled a drop. It was a physiological feat: the flesh had managed to hold the posture in the absence of the pilot.

NARRATION: So paralysed was he by the impact that, after a few minutes, he registered by ear something he had never before caught with such clarity.

NARRATION: From the far end of the garden, head turned, Coltrane was watching him.

COLTRANE: *(from the stone bench, without altering his volume)* Is something the matter?

GLENN: *(without moving a muscle)* No.

COLTRANE: Are you sure?

GLENN: Yes. I'm fine.

(A pause.)

COLTRANE: As you wish.

NARRATION: Glenn added nothing more, and Coltrane did not insist.

NARRATION: That was one of the few skills Coltrane had kept intact since the years in the Holland mansion: the absolute capacity not to press when pressing yielded no gain. Any other individual would have put the question a couple more times. Coltrane merely filed the detail away for another occasion.

NARRATION: Glenn rose from the porch after a long while. He left the glass on the table. He crossed the garden and passed within centimetres of Coltrane's bench, without uttering a word. Coltrane did not look up.

(FADE TO BLACK)

QUICK CUT — THE STUDY. BEFORE DAWN

(Glenn seated at the desk. A single candle lights the room. Paper, ink, pen. He is not writing: he is thinking. He holds the pen in his hand, suspended in the air.)

NARRATION: Glenn had not returned to Europe since the night of that fateful Holland invitation. Two years had passed.

NARRATION: He had not avoided crossing the ocean out of fear, but out of inertia. Out of a specific kind of retroactive shame he did not allow himself to examine: the certainty that fleeing to Europe, at

the time, had been the only effective tool for not looking back. And returning meant, necessarily, having to look.

NARRATION: But Juno was there. Somewhere on a map for which he had no coordinates. And Juno had just emitted something she never, in their fifteen years living together, had emitted.

NARRATION: Juno did not ask. Juno took. Either she grew bored, or she laughed, or she turned on her heel and left. Asking was an organizational failure of the weak, and Juno lived in a permanent denial of weakness.

NARRATION: That she should have emitted a request (and that, though it contained not a single word, had been unmistakably a request) meant that a catastrophic event had occurred. An event that, moreover, she was incapable of resolving on her own.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn considered ignoring it. He thought of letting the small hours pass. Of letting the week pass. Of allowing the static of the signal to dissolve in time.

NARRATION: He thought of returning to the administrative rhythm of the blank dinners and the deferred questions. He thought of staying, in short, exactly where he was.

NARRATION: And then he realised (not by way of a logical conclusion, but as one verifies a physical law) that it was already impossible for him.

NARRATION: The damage was done. The transmission had pulled him out of his torpor, and awakenings of that magnitude do not permit a voluntary return to the previous sleep.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: He lowered his hand. He set the pen to the paper. He began to write.

NARRATION: Not to Juno. To his accountant in Philadelphia.

(FADE TO BLACK)

NARRATION: It took him eleven days to organise what needed to be organised. Accounts. Documents. Two letters to debtors in Boston whom Glenn was going to permit, for the only time in his existence, not to repay him.

NARRATION: He sent strict instructions to the accountant: during his absence, Coltrane would answer for the property, and the businessmen of the county would have to deal with him exactly as if they were dealing with Glenn Sheridan himself.

NARRATION: The estate could stay standing without his presence. Of that he was sure. What he was not sure of was whether Coltrane could stay standing within it.

NARRATION: Finally, he addressed him on the night of the eleventh day.

QUICK CUT — THE STUDY. NIGHT

(Glenn stands beside the desk. Coltrane is in the doorway. Only one lamp remains lit. Glenn has not asked him to come in. Coltrane has taken it in without needing to be told. The conversation, Glenn deduces it from the rigidity in the young man's posture, had already been anticipated by Coltrane long before he was summoned.)

GLENN: I have to leave...

(Coltrane neither reacts nor blinks.)

GLENN: ...To Europe.

(Pause.)

COLTRANE: When will you leave?

GLENN: The day after tomorrow. A ship sails from Norfolk.

COLTRANE: How long will you be over there?

(Glenn thinks about it. He weighs the variables. There are none in sight.)

GLENN: I don't know.

NARRATION: Coltrane had learned over the past year to mask almost everything. But not everything absolutely. There existed a very fine band, just beneath the eyes, where emotions still surfaced for a minimal instant before being sealed and put away in the file.

NARRATION: Glenn had learned to watch that band.

COLTRANE: Is it her?

NARRATION: The question struck him. Glenn had anticipated it for eleven days, and even so, the precision of the shot managed to disarm him for a second.

GLENN: Yes.

COLTRANE: Is she in danger?

GLENN: *(slowly)* That I don't know either.

COLTRANE: But you think so.

GLENN: I do.

(Pause.)

COLTRANE: Are you going to come back?

GLENN: Yes.

COLTRANE: When?

GLENN: That I don't know yet.

NARRATION: Coltrane nodded. It was the same aseptic nod as ever.

GLENN: The estate is yours for as long as you wish to occupy it. My accountant in Philadelphia has precise instructions. The men of the county already know that in my absence you answer for everything. If you should come to need anything—

COLTRANE: *(cutting him off)* I'm not going to need anything.

NARRATION: Glenn let out a faint snort. It was true. Coltrane had learned to need nothing from anyone a very long time ago. Legal freedom had served only to confirm an old habit of survival.

(A pause. The two of them stay looking in different directions, avoiding each other.)

GLENN: Coltrane.

(The one addressed looks up.)

NARRATION: Glenn wanted to add something. He had an irrational urge to confess it, to extract what lay buried beneath all the logistics.

NARRATION: That sentence. The one he had been trying to articulate over the past eleven days without success. The only one that, were he to speak it aloud, might (perhaps) make the next decade more bearable. Or the rest of eternity.

NARRATION: But that sentence, that night, had no shape. Glenn rummaged through his file and pulled out the only thing he had to hand.

GLENN: ...Take care of yourself.

NARRATION: It was poor. Wretched, in fact. Glenn knew it the exact moment he heard himself say it. Coltrane knew it too. The two of them decided, by tacit agreement, to ignore the magnitude of the failure.

COLTRANE: (*nods. Once.*) Have a safe journey.

NARRATION: It was a butler's line. Coltrane had used it hundreds of times in the entrance hall of the Holland mansion to see off his masters' guests. He was using it now with a coldness and a precision that were entirely deliberate.

NARRATION: Glenn understood the blow, and recognised at once that he had thoroughly earned it.

NARRATION: He left the study without adding a single word. Coltrane stayed planted in the doorway, holding the rigidly erect posture of habit. He did not follow him with his eyes. He did not turn his head.

NARRATION: Glenn walked down the corridor without looking back, which was the only manoeuvre he knew for leaving places.

NARRATION: When he had fled Virginia the first time, sixteen years earlier, he had thought he heard Diana calling him from very far away. This time there was no call. The whole house sank into the absolute silence in which Coltrane had always kept it.

(*FADE TO BLACK*)

QUICK CUT — THE CROSSING

(*Somewhere in the Atlantic Ocean.*)

NARRATION: The ship was one of the slow ones. Glenn had chosen it on purpose. He had four weeks ahead of him, and he had not had that quantity of time to himself in a couple of years. He used them to not think.

NARRATION: The problem with not-thinking, when one has been what he was for ages, is that it has different textures.

NARRATION: There is a busy not-thinking: the kind performed at high-society parties, at card games, in the doorways of certain rooms.

NARRATION: There is an empty not-thinking: the kind sustained from a hotel, staring at ceilings in cities whose names were forgotten the next day.

NARRATION: And then there is a shipboard not-thinking, which resembles neither of them, because the ocean allows no one to detach entirely. The ocean insists: it is indifferent and yet it will not leave you in peace.

NARRATION: Glenn had known this since the outbound passage (the other one, the first, the one he made alongside Juno) but this time the mass of water carried a different weight. This time it dragged two people through his head, not one. And the two of them were located in opposite hemispheres.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The woman's signal returned on the twelfth night.

QUICK CUT — THE CABIN

(It is night. The wood of the ship creaks. The candle is out: Glenn does not need it.)

(GLENN lies fully dressed, his eyes open wide. He is not sleeping. He has not slept since he set sail from Norfolk.)

NARRATION: The transmission came as it had the first time, without warning. The difference lay in that, now, Glenn knew what it was before it unfolded, and that granted him enough slack to lower the defences he had, without meaning to, raised over the years.

NARRATION: The images projected themselves again: The forest. The residence. The northern light.

NARRATION: But this time there was more. A great deal more.

NARRATION: Decades of an inventory Glenn had not even imagined. The deep impression of a woman shut in without walls: it was not the Juno he knew. It was not the one who laughed at parties, nor the one who turned her face away, weary, when he complained during the first year.

NARRATION: It was another. A far older one. A version Glenn had never seen, not even in the periods when he had been closest to her; because *that* Juno had hidden beneath all the other Junos, layer upon layer, like an object buried in the foundations of successive houses.

NARRATION: And at a certain distance, slipping into the images, there was something Glenn could not name. It was not a person. It was the exact spot where a person ought to be but where, on the contrary, there was nothing he could recognise.

NARRATION: It was a more ancient presence. Denser. More inert. So inert it seemed not to be there (but it was). Glenn felt it the way one feels, walking through a room in the dark, the brush of a heavy object one does not remember buying.

NARRATION: It was not Juno. It resembled absolutely no one he knew. And it ordered him, without words and without reasoning, with the same crushing clarity with which the body says "*no*," one single thing: *stay away*.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn did not stay away. He was a man who had been ignoring his own body's "*stay away*" since before he died.

NARRATION: It was one of his old human virtues (reckless courage, the imprudence that disguises itself as nobility) and, like many human virtues, it had not been wiped from him entirely after the conversion. It had only changed its handwriting.

NARRATION: The only thing Glenn did was process the new pieces of the map. A northern forest. A European residence. Juno trapped with *that*.

NARRATION: And an instinct of the body warning him, even before he knew what monster dwelt behind the warning, that the decision to involve himself there was going to cost him a price.

(Long pause.)

NARRATION: He accepted it with a lightness that later, prostrate on the ground, would strike him as obscene. But that night, in the cabin, he still did not know how much the bill came to.

NARRATION: He thought, briefly, of Coltrane. He thought of him the way one thinks of a door one has left ajar on leaving the house: with an indecipherable mixture of irritation and relief. *I'll be back*, he

told himself. *It won't be for long.*

NARRATION: That was going to be the sentence he would later remember with the same scorching shame with which a man remembers the bets he lost through overconfidence. *It won't be for long.*

NARRATION: And it was. It was, throughout the half year of convalescence. And then it was, throughout everything else.

NARRATION: But that night he did not know it. That night, Glenn Sheridan only opened his eyes in the darkness of the cabin. He heard the wood of the ship creak under the weight of the water, and he began to reckon how many days remained until he touched dry land.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The ocean went on being indifferent.

(FADE TO BLACK)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The Foolish Knight. *EUROPE. ~1785*

NARRATION: Glenn spent about two years looking for her without knowing he was looking for her.

NARRATION: After Virginia. After Coltrane looking at him the way one looks at a stranger. After the final slammed door neither of them wanted to hear.

NARRATION: Glenn boarded a ship and crossed the ocean again. He told himself he was going back to Europe because it was older than America and therefore more hospitable to his kind of problem.

NARRATION: That was one explanation. But not the real one.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The oddities arrived uninvited. He was walking down a street in Paris when the smell of a perfume Juno sometimes wore struck him. In Prague, at an inn, he thought he heard her laugh down a corridor.

NARRATION: It took him barely a second to process the error: he remembered that Juno would never set foot in that sort of place.

NARRATION: He realized what was actually happening after the third or fourth incident. It was not a failure of his own memory. It was not him remembering pieces of her by accident.

NARRATION: It was her, transmitting fragmented messages.

QUICK CUT — THE SIGNAL

(A rented room somewhere in the north. Glenn sits on a narrow bed, fully dressed. Not a bed he has slept in. Not that he makes a habit of sleeping.)

NARRATION: First, an image: a forest of conifers. Not a remarkable one, not a spectacular one: just one like any other. But it came with a detail Juno would never have designed: the light fell in a particular way, oblique, as if the moon's glow could not penetrate it in full. The kind of forest no one

has ventured into in centuries.

NARRATION: After the image came something Glenn struggled to classify. Not an isolated emotion, but decades of compressed pressure: a weeping addressed to no one, a cage seen from the inside, the sensation of shrinking at an almost imperceptible rate.

NARRATION: He deduced that not even Juno herself would have known how to describe exactly what she was transmitting.

NARRATION: Glenn decoded the signal as follows: Juno was asking him to find her. But at the same time, begging him not to.

(Pause.)

(GLENN rises from the bed. He remains standing a moment, looking out through a window onto an empty street.)

NARRATION: Any man with more than a decade of immortality behind him would have calculated that a signal so abstract admitted multiple readings, and that the vast majority of them required no intervention on his part. Any man with experience would have chosen inaction.

NARRATION: Glenn was not that kind of man. He never had been, and never would be. He had grown very good at accumulating capital, but he still ran a chronic deficit of survival instinct.

NARRATION: He left that very night.

QUICK CUT — THE FOREST

(Glenn walks among the trees. It is night. The moon is waning.)

NARRATION: Finding the forest took him three weeks. He did it by pure elimination: each forest he crossed was not the one from Juno's memory, until, all at once, one of them was.

NARRATION: It was not the oblique light alone that let him identify it. It was a sensation his instinct fired like an irrefutable warning, and that his mind chose to ignore.

NARRATION: He advanced among the trunks with the tactical patience he had acquired hunting with Juno. But beneath that patience, a more primitive layer was at work, almost animal: the Irish farmer who still knew, with precision, when he had stepped onto land that was not his own.

(GLENN stops and looks up.)

NARRATION: Two hundred meters off, among the trees, stood a house with thick walls. No ostentation. No lights burning. Glenn knew, with no need for prior assessment, that inside there was someone (or something) awake.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: And then, before taking the next step, he felt the presence.

NARRATION: It did not resemble any he knew. It did not resemble Juno's, which was dense but familiar, like a room one enters twice a day. It did not resemble his own, which recognized itself in others of his kind the way one recognizes oneself in a broken mirror. It was something else.

NARRATION: It was something archaic. Like an entity no longer in any hurry, because it had spent millennia observing time from the outside.

NARRATION: It was overwhelmingly denser than anything he had registered to date. Not dense in the sense of size, but of material: like a structure that weighed more per cubic centimeter. A being with lead

instead of bones.

NARRATION: But above all, it was an inert presence. The stillness of something that refuses to move unless it is genuinely worth the trouble.

NARRATION: A stillness that was not the absence of movement, nor emptiness, but a colossal, contained pressure. Like the bottom of the ocean, which stays inert because the crushing weight of the water above it is beyond comprehension.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn had a moment of lucidity. His own mind issued a clear order: leave.

NARRATION: Leave without looking back. Forget the forest, the signals, and everything you are feeling right now, because what breathes inside that house operates under no rule you have learned in your entire existence.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn dismissed the order.

NARRATION: He told himself, for lack of a sounder argument, that Juno was there. And that if Juno had sent him a signal, it was because she truly needed him.

NARRATION: It was the logic of foolish knights. The only one they know.

NARRATION: He took the next step.

QUICK CUT — THE ROOM

(INTERIOR. A room with thick walls. Stone floor. A low table. A pair of dark-wood chairs. Few ornaments, their origin unidentifiable to anyone born in the last millennium.)

(AISON sits at the table, poring over an ancient manuscript propped on his knees. He wears a dark tunic and sandals. His hair falls past his shoulders and is white. Not the white of age.)

(JUNO stands a few steps behind Aison's chair. Neither too close nor too far. Like a satellite orbiting a planet.)

(GLENN enters. He stops at the threshold.)

NARRATION: The first thing he saw was not Aison. It was Juno.

NARRATION: And what he saw in her did not fit any of the versions he knew. It was not the Juno of the parties, the one who laughed out loud. It was not the one who had declared to him *"I am the queen of your dreams"* with the wholeness of someone who believed herself regent of the night.

NARRATION: It was, now that he made the connection, the Juno who would remain staring at nothing through a windowpane.

NARRATION: It was a lesser Juno, reduced in some sense that had nothing to do with physical dimensions. A version of herself that had spent too long being lesser to be whole again.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn understood in that second, without anyone having to put it into words, that she had been like this for an incalculable stretch of time, long before she sent out the signals.

NARRATION: The distress call he had received months earlier, in the courtyard of his estate in Virginia, was simply the first time in centuries she had allowed herself to acknowledge that something

was wrong.

NARRATION: The rage reached Glenn afterward. Like a delayed echo.

(JUNO looks up. She sees Glenn at the threshold. Her face transforms.)

NARRATION: Juno's face did what it could in the scant margin of time it had. Glenn read her as he had always read faces: whole, in a single glance.

NARRATION: It was a single warning, repeated with different emphases: "No. No, no, no. What are you doing? Turn around. Leave."

NARRATION: And beneath that, in a layer Glenn was in no condition to process yet, another, darker sentence: "I'm sorry. I didn't tell you who he was. I didn't tell you what he was. This is all my fault."

(AISON goes on reading. He has not looked up. He is absorbed in the text.)

(Glenn finally takes Aison in. He sees a man who might be thirty, or any other age, because his face offers not a single anchor point. He is good-looking, in a serene, archaic way that does not interest Glenn.)

NARRATION: What he did register as an irregularity was the pallor. Or rather, the absolute absence of color.

NARRATION: His skin did not read as human skin. The hair looked as if it had been that immaculate white since the moment of his conception. And the eyes, fixed on the manuscript, held a colorlessness Glenn had never seen, not in humans, not in immortals.

NARRATION: Glenn had seen immortals with many variations of appearance over the years. But he had never seen this. Anyone in his condition with even minimal practice would have read that visual oddity as a definitive warning, operated outside the limits of any known metric.

NARRATION: Once again, Glenn chose to dismiss his own instinct.

GLENN: *(advancing a step, raising his voice toward Juno)* Come.

(Pause.)

GLENN: Let's get out of here.

NARRATION: Glenn had spent weeks mentally rehearsing this intervention. He had practiced the approach. He had logical arguments prepared and calibrated threats. But faced with the density of that room, he was unable to articulate any of it.

(JUNO closes her eyes for an instant. A gesture of pure resignation.)

GLENN: *(addressing Juno, refusing to look at Aison)* Let's go. Now. Whatever's keeping you here doesn't matter. We'll fix it afterward. Come.

NARRATION: Juno did not move. Not because she did not want to obey the impulse. She did not move because she already knew exactly what was about to happen next, and was busy calculating, in the last functioning corner of her mind, how to manage the damage afterward.

GLENN: *(louder, his voice climbing, getting it more wrong)* Juno, look at me!

(AISON does not look up. He does not interrupt his reading. His colorless eyes go on moving across the text. His face remains utterly impassive.)

AISON: *(without altering his rhythm, his eyes moving to the next line)* Quiet.

NARRATION: The word landed in the room at the same instant Aison's left eye finished the sentence

and dropped to the next line.

NARRATION: Aison did not blink. He did not mark the page with his finger. He did not execute a single physical movement to indicate his attention had been interrupted.

NARRATION: That was what would hurt Glenn most afterward, once there finally was an afterward. Not the brutality of the act itself. But the fact that his presence was not even worth enough to merit the other man lifting his eyes from the page.

NARRATION: A single word. Said in the exact tone one uses to order a stray dog to stop barking: without conviction, without anger.

NARRATION: It did not work. Glenn opened his mouth to issue one more order.

(He does not manage to say it.)

NARRATION: The sound came first. It did not come from outside, but from within Glenn himself.

NARRATION: It was a sound no organism was built to make, and yet his body produced it. He heard it resonate from inside his own ribcage, but with the acoustics of someone hearing it from the room next door.

NARRATION: That was, afterward, one of the things he would struggle most to take in: that the pain arrived with a measurable delay behind the sound, and that, for a fraction of a second, the noise of his own destruction struck him as simply curious.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Then came the pain. And, after that, the stone floor.

NARRATION: Glenn did not register the fall. He remembered having been standing, and he remembered being on the floor, but there was no bridge between the two states. His consciousness had been suspended.

(GLENN is on the floor. Face up. His cheek crushed against the cold stone. He cannot move. Not one bone functions within the usual parameters. Apparently, only his skull has remained intact.)

NARRATION: Glenn tried to take an inventory. It was the old reflex of the Irish farmer he had been: checking which parts of the body were still working after a brawl, to know which ones to carry to the healer.

NARRATION: He started with the feet. The feet did not respond. The legs did not either. The ribs no longer had the shape of ribs. The arms were not there. The fingers...

(Aison turns a page. The brush of the paper is sharp in the silence of the room.)

NARRATION: That detail would be the hardest one to file away in memory. The fact that, for Aison, the intervention had been so routine and so minuscule that he did not even take the trouble to lift his eyes and confirm the result.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: That was when Glenn saw Juno. He saw her from the floor, in a fragmented sequence: first, her feet advancing toward him; then, her knees giving way; and last, her face, entering Glenn's field of vision from above.

NARRATION: Juno had not planned the movement. And yet, she had moved.

NARRATION: That was the anomaly. The distinction was not trivial. In the centuries she had spent orbiting the albino, Juno had learned never to move before calculating it.

NARRATION: Moving without thinking was a luxury that had been revoked the day Aison found her dying in an alley in France. Ever since, each of her gestures passed through a strict internal customs that weighed whether Aison would authorize it or not.

NARRATION: This time the customs dissolved. This time, Juno's body executed the action in the only way that made sense, and her mind was informed of the insubordination only a second later.

(JUNO kneels beside Glenn. She lays a trembling hand on his face.)

JUNO: *(low, almost to herself)* Stupid. Stupid. Stupid.

NARRATION: She said it three times because each one had a different assignment. The first was for Glenn, for the error of having come. The second was for herself, for the stupidity of having sent the signal. The third had no clear recipient; it was, simply, the only thing that came to her lips.

(Behind Juno, AISON goes on reading. He is a blurred figure at the back of the frame. He lifts his eyes. He observes the pair for one second in silence. Then he returns to his reading.)

NARRATION: Juno raised her eyes toward the albino. She looked at him for a length of time she did not bother to count.

NARRATION: She was not asking permission. She had spent centuries asking for it, and that had always been the final concession that kept her in the house: believing that having his permission was enough. This time she did not request it. She looked at him the way one looks at an object one is about to be rid of.

(Aison does not look up again.)

NARRATION: There are decisions that are made before they are decided. This was one of them.

NARRATION: Juno had knelt to come to Glenn's aid without thinking, and in doing so, she had left suspended in the air (just above the empty chair where she had spent centuries standing) the version of herself that had inhabited that house.

NARRATION: The Juno who rose to her feet was going to be another woman. There was nothing left to decide; the restructuring was already represented in the very gesture of having touched the floor.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Juno slid her hands under Glenn's back and the hollows of his knees. She lifted him as if he weighed nothing, which was true.

(She walks toward the door.)

NARRATION: At the threshold of the exit, Juno stopped. She did not turn.

NARRATION: It was the last gesture she would execute under that roof, and she did not intend to do it looking at Aison. To look at him on the way out would have meant conceding that the farewell belonged to him. And Juno had decided, firmly, that the farewell was something she owed to herself.

NARRATION: She went out toward the forest carrying Glenn.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Aison turned another page.

(FADE TO BLACK.)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The Nurse. *EUROPE.* ~1785–1786.

NARRATION: Juno had been many things over the centuries. Daughter. Fugitive. Widow of a wedding that never took place. Creature. Lover. Mirror. Salon queen.

NARRATION: Nurse, only once, to a dying man.

NARRATION: She would be one again. A second time.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: She would do it with a rigorously internal clumsiness. Her hands knew how to move; her instinct did not. She was going to make mistakes with her whole body present, which is, probably, the only way mistakes end up done well.

QUICK CUT — THE HOUSE IN THE FOREST

NARRATION: It was a small house Juno had bought from a ruined peasant two centuries earlier, in one of those impulses by which an immortal of means fills her map with places she has no intention of returning to.

NARRATION: That night, at last, she returned. And she did so carrying a sack of bones in the shape of a man.

(EXTERIOR. NIGHT. A clearing among conifers. The house: low stone walls, a thatched roof, a single chimney. The window unlit, because there is no one to light it.)

NARRATION: Juno pushed the door open with her elbow. The wood gave way. The lock had spent two centuries as a mere iron ornament.

(INTERIOR. Half-light. A carved wooden bed. A low table. A chair. A cold hearth. The air thick with the dust of centuries.)

NARRATION: The bed had been there from the beginning. Juno had commissioned it from an Italian cabinetmaker back when she still thought she would use the house. She never did. The piece had remained, waiting for a guest no one had bothered to summon.

NARRATION: That night, two centuries later, the guest arrived.

(JUNO enters. She carries GLENN in her arms. She lays him on the bed with the meticulousness one applies to a very fragile object. Not yet with the care one gives a beloved body, but with the urgency of someone aware she is holding something on the verge of breaking entirely.)

NARRATION: She arranged his arms at his sides. She straightened his legs. She did what she intuited had to be done with a body in the state in which Aison had left Glenn.

NARRATION: She did it with the inexpert caution of a woman who had never been allowed near a cradle, trying to assemble a child too large.

(JUNO remains standing beside the bed. She looks at Glenn. She does not sit.)

NARRATION: She did not know how to sit either. Not like that. Not to keep vigil.

(Long pause.)

NARRATION: She would learn.

QUICK CUT — WHAT'S NOT IN THE MANUAL

NARRATION: The first thing she learned was that an immortal with every bone splintered does not heal on his own.

NARRATION: She learned that healing came through blood. A great deal of blood. Quantities that far exceeded what a healthy body would ask for to sustain itself. The drain behaved differently when the goal was reconstruction rather than simple upkeep.

NARRATION: She learned, too, that she would be the one to bring it. She had no one to delegate to.

(EXTERIOR. NIGHT. A path. Juno returns carrying a human body. She bears it on her shoulder effortlessly, like someone hauling a sack of grain. She enters the house. She drops it beside the bed with a dull thud.)

JUNO: Drink.

(Glenn does not move. His eyes search for hers. His whole body still refuses to obey any command.)

JUNO: Don't make me do it for you.

(Pause.)

GLENN: *(voice barely a thread)* I'm sorry.

NARRATION: Juno snorted. She decided not to remark on the fact that, in practice, she was acting as a mother for the first time in her life. It would have sounded absurd, and she knew it.

NARRATION: But she took up the burden. She had discovered that tasks carried out without being labeled are carried out all the same, and sometimes even better.

(Image: Juno leaning over Glenn, one hand cradling the back of his neck, the other bringing something the shot does not show. Glenn drinks with visible effort, his eyes closed.)

NARRATION: Glenn would remember almost nothing of those first weeks.

NARRATION: He would remember the smell of the blood, which turned out to be strangely different when one consumed it without having had to hunt it.

NARRATION: He would remember the ceiling of the house and the crack in a beam that drew a shape resembling a pine branch.

NARRATION: He would remember Juno coming in and out of the room at hourly intervals that did not seem to follow any logic.

NARRATION: But he would remember, above all else, one thing: that Juno, throughout all those weeks, did not speak to him of anything that was not strictly practical.

NARRATION: She did not say she was sorry. She did not say thank you. She did not utter a single word that could have registered as a balancing of accounts between them.

NARRATION: That, when Glenn had time to think it through afterward, was what sustained him most. That Juno was not trying to settle any debt. That the care, for the first time in his existence, was not a transaction.

QUICK CUT — THE FIRST MOVEMENT

NARRATION: One morning, at some hazy point in the second month, Glenn moved a finger.

(INTERIOR. The room is the same. Outside, a grayish cast confirms it is winter. JUNO sits in the chair. Her pale hands work at an embroidery frame, tracing a pattern of exquisite complexity, stitch after stitch, in absolute silence.)

(GLENN lies on his back, as always. And then, suddenly: the index finger of his left hand lifts a few millimeters into the air and falls back onto the blanket.)

GLENN: Look.

(Juno stops the needle. She lifts her gaze. She sees it.)

JUNO: Did you do that on purpose?

GLENN: I think so.

JUNO: Do it again.

(Glenn tries. The finger does not respond. He tries again. Nothing. On the third contraction, the finger obeys and moves.)

JUNO: *(without smiling, but with a new shade in her voice)* Good.

NARRATION: It was not congratulation. It was a "good" that meant precisely this: I have seen what you just did, and I do not need to add anything further on the matter.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn closed his eyes.

NARRATION: For a man laid out with his skeleton in pieces, in a borrowed bed, inside a house in a forest he did not know, that single word carried the weight of a peace treaty.

QUICK CUT — THE QUESTION THAT HAD BEEN WAITING TWENTY YEARS

NARRATION: Glenn had been wrestling with a question he had been asking himself since shortly after his conversion. He had kept it hidden behind other, more manageable questions, such as, for example, why he had not been able to bring himself near Diana, while Coltrane had managed to stay a meter from Annie.

NARRATION: The underlying question was smaller, but far more insidious. It was this: Why me?

NARRATION: Glenn had answered it in many ways over those twenty years, all of them wrong. That it had been his features. That it had been the hair: that red that drew attention in taverns. That it had been a matter of timing.

NARRATION: Or that it had been for nothing. That had always been the worst possible answer: to have been the outcome of nothing.

NARRATION: That particular night, at some unspecified point in the fourth month, Glenn allowed himself to put the question into words.

(INTERIOR. NIGHT. The room. The hearth lit: one of Juno's few concessions to comfort — not to her own, but to the room's. GLENN sits against the carved headboard, his arms on the blankets. He still cannot walk, but he can hold himself upright for several hours at a time. JUNO sits in the chair. She is not embroidering. She is looking at the fire.)

GLENN: Why me?

(Juno does not take her eyes off the fire. She takes her time answering.)

JUNO: I've been waiting a long time for that question.

GLENN: How long?

JUNO: About as long as you have.

(Pause.)

GLENN: And do you know the answer?

JUNO: Almost.

NARRATION: That was the most honest answer Glenn was going to receive in his entire existence, and he would never fully understand it.

NARRATION: For Juno to say "Almost" meant that she possessed only half the answer. The other half (the real wound that had driven her decision) she was unable to see.

NARRATION: But she handed him the half she had, which was already more than anyone had given him before.

JUNO: I saw you in a tavern. It wasn't the first time I'd seen you. You'd been there for months, you and your friends. But that night I noticed you.

GLENN: Why?

JUNO: Because you laughed like someone who had nothing left to lose.

(Pause.)

GLENN: That's not true.

JUNO: It is. Laughter is the last thing to go. When you laugh the way you laughed that night, it's because there's nothing left behind it.

NARRATION: Glenn wanted to protest. He could not: he knew it was true. Even if he had not wanted to see it then.

NARRATION: The Diana of those days was already worn out. The small Johannes of that time already sensed the absence that inhabited his father. And he himself laughed in the taverns with an intensity that, at the time, had seemed to him like life.

(Pause.)

JUNO: I didn't choose you on a whim, if that's what you wanted to know.

GLENN: *(relieved)* Yes.

JUNO: I chose you because I saw something in you that I recognized. Something specific.

GLENN: What was it?

(Juno takes her time. She thinks about it. She turns and, for the first time that night, looks at him.)

JUNO: That you'd be able to bear what was going to happen to you. Most can't. They break in the first years. You didn't.

NARRATION: Glenn did not answer. It was true; he did not break. Though he had come within millimeters of doing so. He let the answer settle in the room.

NARRATION: What Juno did not say (because she did not know how to put it into words) was the rest.

NARRATION: That she needed to choose someone after centuries of having been, herself, chosen. That the verb "to turn," in her mouth, meant something radically different from what it meant in Aison's.

NARRATION: In Juno's mouth it meant "to be the cause of." And for someone who had spent two and a half centuries being merely the effect, being the cause of something was as urgent as breathing.

NARRATION: That, Glenn was not going to hear that night. In fact, he would never hear it. But the half he did hear was enough.

NARRATION: It was enough that Juno had seen something. It was enough that the something had a name, even if the name was vague. It was enough to know that his eternity had not depended on the color of his hair.

NARRATION: That night Glenn allowed himself to close his eyes the way an exhausted immortal closes them: the body still, the mind shutting down in stages. It was the first time in years he had allowed himself to do so without the weight of the question lurking at the nape of his neck.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The question did not leave entirely. It only shrank a little. He considered that to be all he could ask for.

QUICK CUT — WHAT JUNO HAD NEVER SAID

NARRATION: The reciprocity came two months later, without warning.

(INTERIOR. Afternoon. Glenn can walk now, though slowly. He sits on the floor in front of the hearth. It is an unusual choice, given that he has a bed and a chair, but sometimes convalescent bodies choose the floor because the floor demands no balance. Juno is sitting beside him. The two of them watch the fire.)

GLENN: How did he find you?

(Juno takes a moment to understand. When she does, she closes her eyes briefly.)

JUNO: You mean Aison?

GLENN: Yes.

(Long pause.)

JUNO: I was dying.

NARRATION: It was the most naked sentence Juno had spoken about herself in two hundred and fifty years. Across that span she had told it in many ways (embellished, made ironic, hidden in salon jokes) but never like this. Without wrapping.

JUNO: The plague. In France. I was young. I was lying in a street, in a corner. I stank as though I were already dead. And then he appeared.

GLENN: And what did he say to you?

JUNO: He asked me if I wanted to live.

GLENN: What did you answer?

JUNO: I told him yes.

(Pause.)

JUNO: I've spent more than two and a half centuries asking myself whether that was the right answer.

NARRATION: Glenn did not reply. He knew better than anyone that there was nothing to say. That there are questions an immortal asks the fire, and not another immortal.

NARRATION: But he did something that Juno, in two hundred and fifty years, had never received: he took her hand.

NARRATION: He did it without drama. He took it the way one takes the hand of someone sitting beside one in front of a hearth: with no implication beyond the existence of the gesture itself.

NARRATION: Juno looked at both intertwined hands with genuine curiosity. As if observing an unknown phenomenon she had never experienced before, one occurring wholly apart from her will.

NARRATION: She did not withdraw it. And that, for a woman who had spent centuries calculating and weighing every gesture, was the closest thing to an experiment.

(Long pause.)

NARRATION: They stayed that way until the hearth asked for more wood. When Juno rose to add the logs, she let go of Glenn's hand with the naturalness of someone who assumes she will pick it up again later.

NARRATION: And Glenn understood, without needing to confirm it, that it would be so.

QUICK CUT — THE EMBROIDERY

NARRATION: The piece was finished one afternoon in March, six months and eleven days after the first stitch. Juno cut the thread with her teeth. She looked at the frame just long enough to confirm the work was done, and laid it on the table without further ceremony.

(GLENN is standing for the first time in a long while. He still walks with a certain stiffness, but he walks. He approaches the table and looks at the cloth.)

NARRATION: What he saw was an intricate field of tiny flowers on a dark ground. Dozens. Hundreds, perhaps. Each one resolved with a patience Glenn did not know how to begin to assess.

NARRATION: He recognized some (the daisies, the violets) and ignored the names of the rest. What he did know, without ever having seen a piece like it, was that he was looking at something not made anywhere he had ever had access to in his life.

GLENN: Juno.

JUNO: What.

GLENN: What is this?

(Juno looks up. She assesses the cloth in its entirety. She takes it with a quick, efficient motion and folds it. She holds it out to Glenn.)

JUNO: You can keep it.

GLENN: ...

JUNO: But don't get any ideas. I didn't make it thinking of you. I just needed to keep my hands occupied.

NARRATION: Glenn received the cloth with both hands, because something in the weight of the piece

(which was physically light) required him to use both hands. He did not know what to say. He chose silence.

NARRATION: What Glenn did not know, and what he would never come to confirm, was that this was the first piece Juno had deliberately handed to anyone in her entire existence.

NARRATION: She had not abandoned it on an armchair, nor had she absentmindedly given it to some passing maid. It was being handed over, with her arm extended, her eyes meeting his, and the word *keep it* pronounced aloud.

NARRATION: All of Juno's previous works had scattered across the world through abandonment or indifference. This one did not.

NARRATION: Of course, Juno never put it in those terms either. After handing over the cloth, Juno simply turned back toward the fire, because the flames had already begun to thin, and the logs, after all, did not throw themselves on.

QUICK CUT — THE HOUSE WITHOUT A PATIENT

NARRATION: A little over six months after the night of the bones, Glenn walked to the door without holding on to anything.

NARRATION: He pushed it with his elbow, the way he had seen Juno do. The wood gave way. The lock was still a useless mechanism.

(EXTERIOR. DUSK. The clearing among conifers. Glenn stands in the doorway. Juno, behind him, remains inside the house.)

JUNO: Where are you going?

GLENN: To see whether I still know how to walk.

JUNO: You know you do.

GLENN: Let me confirm it.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn walked. Not far: a hundred steps or so, in a straight line, to the trunk of the first tree. He touched the bark with his hand, like a child touching the wall at the end of a race. Then he turned back.

NARRATION: When he got back to the door, Juno was still there.

JUNO: You're ready.

(Glenn nods.)

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Neither of them put into words what both of them knew: that "ready" meant something more than being healed.

NARRATION: It meant that the cabin, from that moment on, ceased to have any operational justification. That a cured patient is, by definition, a guest who leaves. And that a guest who does not leave is something different: a category for which neither of them had a definition available.

NARRATION: Glenn did not leave that day. Nor the next.

NARRATION: But they both knew the departure was a settled fact.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: They would leave several weeks later. They would walk the road together as far as the first crossroads, and then take opposite directions.

NARRATION: Juno would return to the capitals and to the salons, picking up from the outside the thread of what she had put on hold the day she dragged Glenn into the forest. Glenn would go somewhere else, not yet knowing exactly where.

NARRATION: The house remained empty. The carved wooden bed waited, once again, for a guest who would not arrive for centuries. The lock would go on being useless.

NARRATION: What did not stay behind, neither in the house nor in either of them, was the other thing. The other they carried with them for the rest of their respective existences.

NARRATION: Glenn no longer suffered under the weight of his question. And Juno no longer let go of anyone's hand assuming she could pick it up later.

NARRATION: It was the deepest bond they were going to have. And both of them, in strict silence, knew it.

(FADE TO BLACK.)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

Glenn is finally alone. *EUROPE. 19th Century.*

NARRACIÓN: There is a kind of solitude one chooses and a kind of solitude one inherits. Glenn's, on that first morning after the crossroads, was of the second kind, though it took him a few years to tell the difference.

NARRACIÓN: At first glance it looked like freedom: he had a body that obeyed him again. He had enough money to cross borders without explaining himself. He had the two languages he had been raised with and another pair half-learned.

NARRACIÓN: And above all, no one was waiting for him anywhere. For a man who had spent twenty years calculating the exact hour of his returns, that absence felt, in the first months, like setting down a weight.

NARRACIÓN: What took longer to notice was the other side of the matter. The trouble with shedding every burden is that one forgets the burden was also the counterweight. And a body without a counterweight, however light it may feel at first, in time ends up spinning alone on its own axis.

(Pause.)

NARRACIÓN: Glenn spent almost the whole 19th century that way.

QUICK CUT — THE CROSSROADS

(A road in the north. Dawn breaks without enthusiasm. There is mud in the wheel ruts and two pairs of footprints that part ways right there: Juno's heading east. Glenn's heading south.)

(Juno pauses for a moment. She does not look back. Neither does Glenn. They had exhausted

everything they had to say to each other over the previous six months, and they both knew that anything they added now would be mere ornament.)

JUNO: *(without turning)* Write to me.

GLENN: Where to?

JUNO: You'll find a way.

NARRACIÓN: It was the most generous sentence Juno knew how to utter, and Glenn recognized it as such.

NARRACIÓN: It meant she trusted he would find her, and that she, for her part, would not let herself be found easily. It was a pact of pursuit and resistance disguised as a farewell.

(Glenn nods, though she cannot see him. He adjusts the collar of his coat. He starts walking.)

NARRACIÓN: A hundred steps in, it dawned on him that this was the first time in his existence he had walked without a destination, or a person waiting on the other side.

NARRACIÓN: It was a concrete freedom.

NARRACIÓN: It lasted about ten minutes.

QUICK CUT — THE FIRST OFFICE

(A port city in the north. Indeterminate year, late 18th century edging into the 19th. Glenn has rented a room above a print shop. He has acquired a table, a lamp, two chairs, a ledger, and a quill. A strictly functional office. Ugly, no apologies.)

(GLENN sits behind the desk. Across from him, a MAN of about forty (a moneylender or something of that ilk) sweats visibly.)

THE MAN: I assure you the sum will be complete by the end of the month.

GLENN: It will be complete this week.

THE MAN: That's impossible.

GLENN: *(calmly)* It's impossible for you.

NARRACIÓN: Glenn had discovered, with the surprise of a man who at fifty discovers he has a good ear for a language he has never studied, that he possessed a particular talent for this.

NARRACIÓN: It was not the talent of force. Any dock thug had that. It was the talent of stillness: the capacity to remain seated, watching, without moving a single muscle, while the other man, inside, went through everything he had to go through.

NARRACIÓN: It was because he was a little bit dead. Only a dead man can hold a pause like that.

NARRACIÓN: The living always end up filling the silence with something, even if only a sigh, because they have a clock working against them. Glenn no longer had one.

NARRACIÓN: And men like the one now sweating across from him felt that difference without being able to catalogue it. What they grasped was that the person on the other side of the table did not seem to be in a hurry, or afraid, or to have anything at stake. That was what undid them.

GLENN: This week. I'll say it once more, for the record.

THE MAN: *(after a long pause)* This week.

(Glenn nods.)

NARRACIÓN: He did not raise his voice to that man. He almost never had to, with any of them. It was enough to sit and wait. It was almost indecent how good he was at it.

(Pause.)

NARRACIÓN: And equally obscene how little it cost him.

QUICK CUT — THE METHOD

NARRACIÓN: Glenn learned early that the trade had few rules, but that none of them allowed any margin for exception.

NARRACIÓN: The first was not to appear angry. Anger was an amateur's tool. A man who gets angry is asking the other man to fear him, and men who ask for fear almost always end up not receiving it. Glenn asked for nothing. That was the terrifying part.

NARRACIÓN: The second was not to threaten what he was not prepared to carry out. Empty threats were like bad checks: sooner or later someone was going to walk into the bank and try to cash one. Glenn never wrote a bad check.

NARRACIÓN: The third was not to step in personally if he could avoid it. Not out of delicacy, but out of operational efficiency. Glenn's presence during an event was a compromising detail the operation did not require. Any drunkard could break another man's arm. Glenn did not hire drunken thugs. He hired methodical men, paid them well, and moved to another city when necessary.

NARRACIÓN: The fourth, and the most important, was to leave no debts open. If a man owed him money, either the money came in, or the man ceased to exist. There was no third category.

NARRACIÓN: This, though it sounded barbarous, was in fact the cleanest part of the trade. Other moneylenders lived off renewed debt, off deferred interest, off the debtor's perpetual anguish. Not Glenn. Glenn did not want anguish. He wanted closure.

NARRACIÓN: Every account closed by a deadline, and past that date, it no longer existed. It was almost a work ethic, if one looked at it from a certain angle. From no other.

(Pause.)

NARRACIÓN: Glenn did not bother to look at it from any other.

QUICK CUT — THE ARMS

NARRACIÓN: The arms business came to him by accident, like almost everything that would later define his fortune.

NARRACIÓN: A client, unable to pay in coin, offered him a shipment of muzzle-loading rifles he had stored in a warehouse in Antwerp. Glenn accepted, thinking he would resell them within a week and be rid of the problem.

NARRACIÓN: It took him three days. He tripled the figure of the original debt.

NARRACIÓN: He thought about it that night, sitting in an inn, smoking with his eyes fixed on the ceiling. He thought: *this is easier than money.*

NARRACIÓN: He thought: *money is an idea a country can stop backing tomorrow. A rifle, no. A rifle is a rifle. It weighs the same here as anywhere else. There is always someone, somewhere, who wants one, for some reason that is no concern of mine.*

NARRACIÓN: That last sentence was the one that sealed the trade. *For some reason that is no concern of mine.* He adopted it as an administrative mantra. It was a natural extension of his policy of not asking.

NARRACIÓN: When a buyer came to ask the price, Glenn gave the price. When the buyer paid, Glenn delivered. He did not look into who the rifles would be aimed at, or in which war, or under what flag. The century was lavish with wars and flags. There was always a new one. There were always new buyers.

(Pause.)

NARRACIÓN: Glenn had been an Irish peasant. He had grown up watching his father haggle over a cow. The rifles, looked at coldly, were exactly the same as the cow, only with more zeros. There was no real difference.

NARRACIÓN: That was what he told himself.

NARRACIÓN: He told himself that for a long time. And almost always, he believed it.

QUICK CUT — THE PROXIES

NARRACIÓN: The first time Glenn did not appear in person for an important negotiation, he felt exposed. It did not last long. A week later, he felt relieved. Then, quite simply, he forgot that it had ever been necessary to be present.

NARRACIÓN: By 1830 he had five men answering for him in five cities. By 1850 he had fourteen.

NARRACIÓN: None of them knew the others. None had seen Glenn in years. Some were not entirely sure he existed: they received instructions by letter, remittances by courier pouch, itinerary directives by messenger. They did what was asked of them. They were paid well.

NARRACIÓN: Glenn learned, during those years, that there is nothing more efficient for the exercise of power than a well-organized absence.

NARRACIÓN: A man present can be wounded, bribed, read. An absence cannot. An absence can only be obeyed.

NARRACIÓN: For someone who, by nature, already inhabited the midpoint between presence and absence, it was an almost comfortable discovery. Almost natural. As though the trade had been designed for creatures like him, and humans had merely been imitating it clumsily for decades.

(Pause.)

NARRACIÓN: This was one of the things Glenn thought about sometimes, sitting alone before the fireplace of some villa that belonged to him and to which he had not returned in two years. That money, debt, and threat were human inventions emulating, with difficulty, something the dead did without effort.

NARRACIÓN: That he, quite simply, operated at an advantage. That this was no merit. It was a structural inequality.

NARRACIÓN: That last thought (the structural-inequality part) was the kind of thought a younger Glenn would have rejected as unpleasant. This Glenn accepted it with a lightness that he himself noticed.

QUICK CUT — THE AUDIENCE

(A private office. End of the century. Brussels, probably, or Vienna. The light is the same in all those cities. Heavy curtains. A low fire in the fireplace. Gas lamps. GLENN's desk, too clean, is the clearest sign that almost all the work has already been done before anything ever reaches it.)

(Glenn smokes. Signs a document. He does not look up when the door opens.)

(Two MEN in dark overcoats enter, bringing a third with them. He is KAUFMANN: fifty years old, a good suit ruined, four days unshaven. Neither bound nor free. They deposit him in the chair across from the desk. The two men take two steps back and remain flanking the door. They do not leave.)

(Glenn finishes signing. Then he looks up.)

GLENN: Mr. Kaufmann.

KAUFMANN: Sir.

GLENN: I have owed you this conversation for several days. I apologize for the delay.

NARRACIÓN: That a man like Glenn would apologize for the delay was the kind of gesture that tended to unsettle the interlocutor. Courtesy was a form of violence. Glenn knew it and used it. It was not cynicism: it was craft.

KAUFMANN: It is of no importance, sir.

GLENN: It is to you. You have spent the last four days in a windowless room. I am certain it has not been comfortable.

KAUFMANN: I have been in worse places.

GLENN: *(without smiling)* No doubt.

(Pause.)

GLENN: Do you know why you are here?

KAUFMANN: I have an idea.

GLENN: I would like to hear it.

KAUFMANN: *(slowly)* For the March operation.

GLENN: Be more specific.

KAUFMANN: For the decision I made, in March, without consulting you.

GLENN: That formulation is too generous to your person, Mr. Kaufmann. Rephrase it.

(Long pause. Kaufmann breathes through his nose.)

KAUFMANN: For having disobeyed you in March.

GLENN: Better.

NARRACIÓN: Glenn was not feeding his own ego by demanding the correction. He was teaching that man, in the last lucid minutes Kaufmann would have before his throat closed with fear, to call things by their name.

NARRACIÓN: It was almost a pedagogy. The only pedagogy Glenn still offered, by then, and only under this kind of circumstance.

KAUFMANN: Mr. Sheridan, if I may—

GLENN: Do not use my surname. No one does. This is not a good moment to start.

KAUFMANN: Forgive me.

GLENN: There is no need to apologize. I am merely explaining it to you.

(Pause.)

GLENN: Continue.

KAUFMANN: I have been in your service for twelve years.

GLENN: Eleven years and seven months, per the contract. Continue.

KAUFMANN: I have worked well for you.

GLENN: *(nodding once)* On the whole, yes.

KAUFMANN: The March matter was a hasty decision. I had partial information, and—

GLENN: The information was complete. The messenger I sent to Lyon delivered to you all six envelopes. I have the receipt signed in your hand. What you had was haste, not partial information. And haste, in your case, cost eighteen thousand francs and the trust of a client who had been doing business with this house for forty years.

GLENN: I'll give you another chance.

(Kaufmann closes his eyes. Glenn waits: he is in no hurry.)

KAUFMANN: *(in a low voice)* I have a wife.

GLENN: I know.

KAUFMANN: I have four children.

GLENN: Mm.

KAUFMANN: Do you know their names?

GLENN: No.

NARRACIÓN: It was a classic question. It always came, at some point, in these conversations. A cornered man tries to become, in the other man's eyes, something more than an entry in a ledger.

NARRACIÓN: He offers data. He offers a specific wife, specific children, ages, trades. He does so because he believes the specificity will be his defense.

NARRACIÓN: It is not. Specificity is, precisely, the kind of information that, in these cases, is demanded of the debtor who is not offering it.

KAUFMANN: Helene. And the children are Friedrich, Maria, Anna, and the little one is called Otto.

GLENN: I do not recall having asked.

KAUFMANN: I have told you anyway.

GLENN: So you have.

(Pause.)

KAUFMANN: Is it all the same to you?

NARRACIÓN: It was a good question. Glenn himself had put it to Juno several times, decades earlier. He could not offer him the correct answer, but he could offer something like it.

GLENN: It is not all the same to me, Mr. Kaufmann. It is, in fact, the very opposite.

KAUFMANN: *(confused)* What do you mean?

GLENN: If it were all the same to me, I could afford to be flexible. Indifference, contrary to what is believed, is what gives one room to maneuver. Discipline does not.

GLENN: I cannot afford to treat a man with four children differently from a man who lives alone with his dog. The moment I allowed it, the others would know by tomorrow, and the next decision would not be mine: it would be made by the first man clever enough to guess which argument softens me.

(Pause.)

GLENN: And from that point on, my business is finished in six months. And with it, the salaries of several hundred men like you, who also have Helenes and Friedrichs at home. That is what matters to me. Not your children. Other men's.

KAUFMANN: That is a rationalization.

GLENN: It is. I see no problem.

(Long pause.)

NARRACIÓN: Kaufmann did two things in the seconds that followed. The first was to look at Glenn the way one looks at a building and realizes one cannot scale it. The second was to let his shoulders drop, because there was no longer anyone left to convince.

KAUFMANN: Is there a way to pay for it?

GLENN: Of course.

KAUFMANN: How?

GLENN: With what is about to happen to you.

NARRACIÓN: Glenn did not specify. Not out of cruelty, but out of economy. What was about to happen, the men at the back of the room knew. Glenn knew. Kaufmann would know in a matter of minutes. Saying it aloud would change nothing.

GLENN: I only ask one last favor of you.

KAUFMANN: *(with a touch of bitter irony)* Of course.

GLENN: Do not resist. It will do you no good, and will only prolong the inevitable.

KAUFMANN: *(after a pause)* Very well.

GLENN: Thank you, Mr. Kaufmann.

NARRACIÓN: He meant the "thank you." It was the only part of the conversation that was not strictly necessary.

(Glenn makes a small gesture with two fingers. The two men approach. Kaufmann stands without their having to touch him. He walks toward the door between them. Before leaving, he turns for a moment.)

KAUFMANN: Are you going to remember my name next week?

GLENN: *(without rising)* No, Mr. Kaufmann.

KAUFMANN: *(defeated)* Good.

NARRACIÓN: The word "good" left Kaufmann's mouth in the exact tone Juno had used, years earlier, on the day Glenn had managed to move a finger for the first time after his whole skeleton had been

broken to pieces.

NARRACIÓN: He noticed it. He had not been granted permission to notice things like that in decades, but he noticed them all the same.

NARRACIÓN: Which did not, by any means, mean that he was going to do anything with them.

(Kaufmann leaves. The door closes. Glenn remains seated.)

(Long pause.)

NARRACIÓN: The only thing Glenn did that afternoon outside the established procedure was the following.

NARRACIÓN: When the men at the back returned, an hour later, to confirm that everything had run its course, Glenn already had on his desk a sheet of detailed instructions: a monthly allowance, modest but sufficient, paid into an account in the name of Helene Kaufmann, widow, from an unnamed source.

NARRACIÓN: It was to be maintained for twenty years. It was to carry no name or signature. And if any of the Kaufmanns (Friedrich, Maria, Anna, Otto) ever asked who was sending it, the official answer was to be: "a creditor of your father's who preferred to settle the debt."

(He hands the sheet to the man. The man reads it. He raises his eyebrows, a millimeter and a half, before returning them to their original position.)

THE MAN: Anything else, sir?

GLENN: No. Leave me.

NARRACIÓN: When he was alone, Glenn crushed the cigar in the ashtray and lit another. He did not look out the window. He did not stand up. He did not go to the mirror. He stayed seated for exactly one hour (he measured it by the bells).

NARRACIÓN: That hour he confessed to no one. He had no one to confess it to. And had he had someone, he would never have called it by its true name: grief.

NARRACIÓN: And grief, in the inner patrimony of the Glenn of those years, was a dangerous column that he, under no circumstances, allowed himself to open. So he did not linger on it.

NARRACIÓN: The hour ended. The ink had not dried. He poured himself a brandy he was not going to drink and went back to signing the papers he had had pending since the morning.

NARRACIÓN: If anyone had said to Glenn that night, "what you did today is going to add to the rest," Glenn would have nodded politely and would not have known what was being said to him.

NARRACIÓN: It would take him decades to know. And when at last he did know, the revelation would come to him in another language, and by then there would be no turning back.

QUICK CUT — THE STRANGER IN THE NIGHT

(Some street. Some city. A winter afternoon, edging into evening.)

(Glenn walks unhurried. He wears a good coat, the kind that absorbs light.)

(In the doorway of a closed building, a MAN sits on the ground. Fifty-something, in rags, a blanket over his knees, a thin dog beside him. He has asked three passersby for alms before Glenn comes along. All three walked past.)

(Glenn stops.)

GLENN: Good afternoon.

THE MAN: (blinks, unused to being addressed) Afternoon.

GLENN: Have you been here long?

THE MAN: *(with a certain suspicion)* Are you with the police?

GLENN: No.

THE MAN: Are you a priest?

GLENN: *(with a minuscule smile)* Not that either.

THE MAN: Then what's it to you?

GLENN: Fair point.

(Glenn crouches. The way he does it: without unnecessarily wrinkling his coat, without letting his knee touch the ground, shows he has learned to come down to the level of men like this one without making a show of it.)

GLENN: I have a proposition for you. I pay for a hot meal and a drink. You tell me how you ended up here. Does that suit you?

THE MAN: *(after a long pause)* And if you don't like the story?

GLENN: The meal is paid in advance. The story is a bonus.

NARRACIÓN: The man hesitated a few seconds longer, calculating the offer. Glenn waited without pressing him.

NARRACIÓN: It was the same stillness with which he waited for the surrender of moneylenders; but that stillness, directed at a beggar in a doorway, produced a different side effect.

NARRACIÓN: The man, who had forgotten what it was to be waited for by anyone, nodded.

QUICK CUT — A TAVERN. ONE HOUR LATER

(The man eats like an animal. The dog, under the table, waits for crumbs. Glenn watches him without impatience, smoking.)

NARRACIÓN: The story the man told him that night had the expected parts (a job lost, a wife ill, an expensive doctor, a loan, another loan) and a part Glenn did not expect.

NARRACIÓN: The man had been a watchmaker. He had made small pocket watches, with mechanisms he had devised himself. His hands were ruined now, but he explained them with a vivacity that the rest of the account did not contain. Glenn listened without interrupting.

NARRACIÓN: When the man finished, Glenn drew from an inner pocket a sum that was considerably greater than what a meal with a story warranted. He laid it on the table.

THE MAN: It is too much.

GLENN: Perhaps.

THE MAN: Why?

GLENN: *(slowly)* Because I liked the part about the watches.

NARRACIÓN: Glenn rose. He adjusted his coat. Before leaving, he set down for the dog the meat from his own plate, which he had not touched.

NARRACIÓN: Out in the street, walking toward his carriage, he registered a thought he did not care to linger on for long: that night, listening to a ruined watchmaker speak of mechanisms, he had been more awake than in all the months before.

NARRACIÓN: It was a fact that would put his entire trade in doubt if he allowed himself to look at it head-on.

NARRACIÓN: He did not allow himself. He got into the carriage. He gave the driver the address of the villa.

(Pause.)

NARRACIÓN: Even so, for years, in different cities, he repeated the experiment. A meal, a story, an envelope of money. He never helped the same person twice.

NARRACIÓN: It was, throughout the century, the only habit that produced no dividends and protected no territory. The one column in the ledger that always ran in the red, and that he never bothered to balance.

NARRACIÓN: Had he been asked why he did it, he would not have known how to answer. Had Coltrane been asked, Coltrane would probably have settled it in a single sentence; but no one was going to ask Coltrane, and in any case, Coltrane was not there.

QUICK CUT — THE FIRST WALLS

(A villa somewhere in central Europe. Vast halls. Glenn, alone, with a cigar, walking past the walls newly populated with works.)

NARRACIÓN: He bought the first painting because the wall was empty and the emptiness bothered him.

NARRACIÓN: He bought the second because the dealer he had negotiated with had struck him as agreeable.

NARRACIÓN: He bought the third because he was beginning to understand that canvases had a market of their own, and that this market obeyed laws he already knew by heart: supply, scarcity, desire, patience.

NARRACIÓN: By the fifth painting, he had stopped thinking about the walls. He was beginning to think about the paintings.

NARRACIÓN: This matters for a reason Glenn, at the time, had no way of intuiting. He was almost exactly a hundred years away from meeting Paul.

NARRACIÓN: A century away from the day when collecting, now merely the costly pastime of a rich man without company, would become something else. But there is no need to dwell on that yet. The outcome belongs to another chapter, another century, another variant of solitude.

NARRACIÓN: What matters in this moment is that the muscle is forming.

NARRACIÓN: Glenn is learning to look at paintings with the attention another man would give to a field or a woman. He is learning to stand motionless for half an hour in front of a portrait that did not come from his own hands. He is learning to study people painted by others. That is what matters.

(Pause.)

NARRACIÓN: What use that skill would be to him, Glenn did not know. He assumed it would be of no use at all.

NARRACIÓN: Most of the things an immortal learns are of no use to him. Until suddenly, one night, they are of use for everything.

QUICK CUT — THE UNWRITTEN LETTER

(A desk. A lamp. Clean paper. Ink. Pen. Glenn seated, pen in hand. He looks at the paper with the expression not of a man who has nothing to say, but of a man who has too much and does not know where to begin.)

(He writes at the top:)

Coltrane,

(He looks at the two syllables. He crosses them out. He writes beneath:)

Johannes,

(He looks at the three syllables. He crosses them out as well. He starts over.)

Coltrane,

(This time he leaves the name. He sets down the pen. He waits.)

NARRACIÓN: What Glenn wanted to tell him came down, in fact, to a single thing: he wanted to communicate that he was well.

NARRACIÓN: Not the "I am well" of social formula. He wanted to say it in a strictly literal sense: that he still existed. That he had not died in a Paris gutter. That the Virginia estate could continue to rely on the monthly allotment, and that no creditor would ever come knocking on Coltrane's door for anything that was not his to answer.

NARRACIÓN: What Glenn did not want to tell him (what even then he knew he would never put on paper) was the rest of the balance.

NARRACIÓN: That he had not thought of Diana in years. That it had been even longer since he had thought of the son the two of them had had. That he owned villas in places the farmer of 1764 could not have so much as pronounced.

NARRACIÓN: That he had ordered the deaths of men he had never seen. That he had sold rifles to buyers he had never looked in the eye.

NARRACIÓN: That the Irishman who had once accepted an invitation to the Holland party no longer existed, and would never exist again. That he, Glenn, was the only thing that had been left in his place. A balance he was no longer sure was worth signing with the same name.

NARRACIÓN: He could not write any of that in a letter. Not for lack of space. But because the moment a single line was drawn, the next already demanded the one after.

NARRACIÓN: By the fifth line, Glenn would no longer be writing to Coltrane, but confessing to him. And Coltrane had not offered himself for such a role, nor would he ever, nor would he forgive Glenn for the mere fact of having considered it.

(Long pause.)

NARRACIÓN: He crossed out "Coltrane" again.

NARRACIÓN: That night he wrote, instead, a brief letter to his accountant in Philadelphia. It ordered that the monthly allotment to the estate be increased by twenty percent, without explanation.

NARRACIÓN: The accountant, who had not asked for explanations in years, would carry out the order

the next day. Coltrane would notice the increase. He would not ask. He would invest it.

NARRACIÓN: That would be the conversation between the two of them for the next several decades. Figures that rose in silence. Trust that bore no words. Affection that went unsigned.

NARRACIÓN: It seemed to Glenn, that night, that it was almost enough.

(Pause.)

NARRACIÓN: Almost.

QUICK CUT — THE MIRROR, AGAIN

(A room. A full-length mirror, similar to the one at the estate in Virginia. Glenn stops before it for a moment.)

NARRACIÓN: What had changed since the last time he had stood in front of a mirror like this was not the reflection. It was something else:

NARRACIÓN: That it no longer surprised him.

NARRACIÓN: Looking at himself had ceased to be an act of comparison with the past. It had become, quite simply, a confirmation of inventory.

NARRACIÓN: Still here. Good. Onward.

NARRACIÓN: He looked away long before a living man would have. Not out of discomfort, but out of operational efficiency.

NARRACIÓN: He had documents to sign.

(FADE TO BLACK)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The confrontation. *A European city. Some moment in the twentieth century.*

NARRATION: Glenn saw it coming three days before it happened, though he didn't know what he was seeing at the time. Later, much later, he would arrange the clues in his head with the same methodology used to arrange evidence for a crime already solved: with the clinical calm of someone who already knows the ending.

NARRATION: The first clue was an anomalous silence on one of his lines. A proxy in Hamburg who had operated for two decades with the punctuality of a Swiss watch did not report on Tuesday. He reported on Wednesday. Glenn demanded no explanations: to do so amounted to showing concern, and to show concern was to lose his footing.

NARRATION: The second clue was an innocuous conversation in a Prague tavern. A man Glenn didn't know from anywhere mentioned an American who had been around the district for days, asking questions. Blond, impeccable manners, very strange English, a German vocabulary superior to that of the locals themselves. The stranger gave no names. He offered sums.

GLENN: And what sort of questions was he asking?

THE MAN: Old things. From the thirties. From the forties. He was looking for certain people.

GLENN: And did anyone answer him?

THE MAN: Some did.

(Glenn nods. Not a single muscle in his face betrays interest.)

NARRATION: Glenn settled the bill, left the man double what the coffee was worth, and stepped out into the cold of the street. He lit a cigarette. The first drag against his frozen lung came with a clarity he hadn't felt in decades. An almost nostalgic clarity.

NARRATION: The third clue never came. And it was, precisely, the absence of a third clue that confirmed the diagnosis. That an American would ask two questions and then not ask the third was the worst possible scenario. It meant he already had what he needed.

NARRATION: Glenn knew at that instant that Coltrane would knock on his door that very week. He did not wonder about the methods. Nor did he care.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: What he did think that night, while he smoked leaning against the window frame of his empty flat, was that he had been waiting one hundred and seventy years for this to happen. He thought that feeling even the slightest hint of relief at knowing the reckoning had finally arrived was something obscene.

NARRATION: And he decided he was going to feel it anyway.

QUICK CUT — THE DOORBELL

(A flat in a European city. Deep night. Lights low. GLENN is seated in an armchair, holding a glass he has no intention of drinking. In the background, a radio plays a music program he isn't listening to.)

(The doorbell rings.)

NARRATION: It wasn't an aggressive ring, or an impatient one. It was a single one. The exact pressure of a well-mannered finger, belonging to someone who knows he doesn't need to insist because he knows he's expected.

(Glenn sets the glass on the table. He stands. He walks toward the door.)

NARRATION: It took him four seconds to reach the entryway. In that minuscule passage, Glenn's brain processed several things at once, all of them irrelevant. He thought his tie was badly knotted. He thought he should have turned the radio off. And he noticed that the wood of the entryway creaked at a specific point he'd never bothered to repair. He thought that creak was going to stay in his memory, associated forever with the disaster about to cross his door.

(He opens it.)

NARRATION: Coltrane had stopped being seventeen years old almost two centuries ago, but his face was still the face of a boy. The difference lay in the structure holding the face up. The boy now wore a tailored coat, a grey silk scarf, and the immovable weight of a man who has deliberately crossed an ocean.

COLTRANE: Glenn.

GLENN: Come in.

NARRATION: Glenn wasn't surprised by the steadiness of his own voice. Across the three nights of

vigil that preceded this, he had decided not to feign a single thing. Trying to perform in front of Coltrane would not only have been useless; it would have struck him as a profound disrespect.

(Coltrane crosses the threshold. He makes no move to take off his coat. Glenn closes the door behind him.)

(Shot of the entryway: the sitting room is glimpsed at the back. Coltrane stops exactly at the border between the two rooms. He does not advance into the sitting room. Glenn does not make the mistake of asking him to.)

GLENN: Can I offer you anything?

COLTRANE: No.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn had already scanned him. He did it in the half-second between opening the door and hearing his own name. And in that sweep, he saw that Coltrane was contained. Not calm: contained. It was an important distinction. A calm man does not need to clench his jaw. Coltrane had his clenched.

COLTRANE: I know everything.

GLENN: Alright.

COLTRANE: *(barely raising his eyebrows, incredulous)* Alright?

GLENN: Yes. Alright.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: In his meticulous preparation for that night, Glenn had also decided not to ask how the hell he had found out. To demand the details of the leak would have been the reaction of an administrator looking to plug a breach. And the last thing Glenn wanted to be in that room was an administrator, even though by this point in his existence, it was the only thing he knew how to be.

COLTRANE: Aren't you going to ask me how I found out?

GLENN: No.

COLTRANE: Why not?

GLENN: Because it doesn't matter.

NARRATION: In the mouth of any other man, or in any other context, the answer would have sounded like an evasive, cowardly maneuver. Coltrane decoded it for what it really was: the first act of genuine acknowledgment Glenn had ever conceded him in his life. Glenn Sheridan, the man who had spent a century demanding that his thugs and spies render account, was voluntarily relinquishing control of the information.

COLTRANE: *(slowly, weighing him)* Good.

NARRATION: Glenn registered the word. And the tone in which it was said.

(Coltrane takes a single step into the sitting room. His gaze sweeps over the furniture, the canvases on the walls, the lit fireplace. It is not a curious look. It is the cold scrutiny of an appraiser calculating the value of the spoils before a seizure.)

COLTRANE: Nice place.

GLENN: One of many.

COLTRANE: I know.

NARRATION: Glenn caught the nuance. Coltrane did not only know there were others; he knew exactly how many there were. Probably with more precision than Glenn himself kept track of.

COLTRANE: The suit you're wearing is elegant too.

GLENN: Coltrane.

COLTRANE: Yes?

GLENN: Say it already.

COLTRANE: Say what?

GLENN: What you came to say.

NARRATION: Glenn did not raise his voice or shift a millimetre of his posture. He didn't do it out of any show of bravery, but to spare himself the effort: he had spent three days waiting for this; the ceremonial prologue felt exhausting.

(Coltrane watches him in silence. Slowly, he removes the silk scarf. He folds it and tucks it into a pocket. The coat stays on.)

COLTRANE: "Coltrane" is the name imposed on me by the wife of the man my mother sold me to. For thirty-five pounds sterling.

NARRATION: Glenn felt the first stab beneath his ribs. He knew perfectly well where the conversation was heading. But there are blows for which, no matter the prior simulations or the mental armour, one is never prepared.

COLTRANE: Thirty-five miserable pounds, Glenn.

(A very long pause. The air in the room turns to lead.)

COLTRANE: Do you have the faintest idea what kind of life (if you could call it a life) I dragged through on the Hollands' plantation?

(Glenn remains silent. His eyes fixed on Coltrane.)

COLTRANE: You came back fifteen years later.

GLENN: ...

COLTRANE: You found me in a ballroom. And you decided to buy me.

GLENN: ...

COLTRANE: Like a piece of furniture. Without saying a single word to me.

GLENN: ...

NARRATION: Coltrane was executing the same interrogation technique Glenn had spent decades perfecting in his office, but with one substantial improvement: Coltrane did not wait for the other man to answer. He chained the statements together. It is the most devastating psychological mechanism for extracting the truth from a man, because it leaves no room to fabricate a lie.

NARRATION: Glenn knew the system perfectly. He had used it on hundreds of cornered men. Being on the receiving end now was almost pedagogical.

COLTRANE: Do you know how long that damn question kept circling in my head? "Why me?"

GLENN: ...

COLTRANE: *(raising his voice for the first and only time, tearing through his own control)* "Why me?" "Why me?!"

GLENN: ...

(Pause. Coltrane composes himself.)

COLTRANE: Why did you stay silent about it?

(Glenn does not answer immediately. Of the entire interrogation, this is the only response he has had to assemble himself, in real time, and it is costing him.)

GLENN: Because I took it for granted that you were never going to forgive me.

COLTRANE: And that was excuse enough not to tell me?

GLENN: At the time, it was.

COLTRANE: That's the act of a coward.

GLENN: It is.

COLTRANE: *(he scrutinizes him, not as a question but as a verdict)* You're not going to defend yourself.

GLENN: No.

(Coltrane exhales slowly.)

COLTRANE: *(lowering his voice)* You're making this harder than I thought.

(A very long pause. Coltrane fixes his gaze on the wood of the floor. Glenn does not take his eyes off him. In the background, the radio continues playing a piece of music that neither of them hears.)

COLTRANE: I've spent two months deciding what to do to you when I finally had you in front of me.

GLENN: I can imagine.

COLTRANE: I thought about killing you.

GLENN: I would have understood.

COLTRANE: It would have done me no good.

GLENN: ...

COLTRANE: I thought about dismantling you. I know exactly how to do it. I've known for years. I learned it by watching you, all this time, without you knowing I was watching.

GLENN: I can imagine that too.

COLTRANE: I thought about never showing up again. About leaving you forever with the gnawing of not knowing whether I had discovered the truth or not.

GLENN: *(in a murmur)* That would have been the worst.

COLTRANE: I know. That's why it was the option I considered the longest.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: Glenn closed his eyes for a second. When he opened them again, Coltrane was still watching him with those blue eyes that seemed to have been born for the sole purpose of judging him.

COLTRANE: I'm not going to do any of those three things.

GLENN: ...

COLTRANE: Not because you don't deserve them.

GLENN: ...

COLTRANE: But because all three would cost me. A drain I'm not interested in taking on. And I think I've already paid enough on your account.

NARRATION: That line did get to him. Glenn felt something in the center of his chest he hadn't felt in decades and for which he no longer had a name. It wasn't pain, but the somber recognition that the pain was intact beneath everything, waiting.

NARRATION: That the almost two centuries between the Virginia estate and this shadowed room had not been a cure, but had always been a reprieve.

(Coltrane turns toward the door. Just before crossing the threshold, he stops. He does not look back.)

NARRATION: And it's right there. In that suspended millisecond, in which Coltrane is about to leave and Glenn has no idea what words will come out of his mouth when the boy turns around.

[DECISION 2]

(Coltrane...)

[PATH A] (Forgives the debt)

[PATH B] (Leaves the account open)

PATH A — The immediate concession

(Coltrane turns. Not completely: only half his body. Just enough for Glenn to see his profile.)

(A pause that Glenn finds hard to measure.)

COLTRANE: What was she like?

GLENN: Who?

COLTRANE: My mother.

NARRATION: The question struck Glenn from an angle he was not prepared for. He had anticipated rage, calculation, even indifference. Not this. Not a son asking about his mother.

NARRATION: Glenn sat down. His head did not decide it. His knees gave out on their own.

GLENN: She was... *(he interrupts himself)* She was short. She came up to here. *(he touches his shoulder)*

(What follows, he says with the urgency of someone uncovering a canvas he had kept facing the wall for fifteen years.)

GLENN: Her hands were very rough for someone so young. She had been working in the house for years by the time I showed up. When someone said something to her that struck her as stupid, she had a gesture, a way of pressing her lips together... She learned that from your grandmother, I suppose, though I never met your grandmother.

(Coltrane doesn't move. His eyes are simply fixed on him.)

COLTRANE: Go on.

NARRATION: Glenn spoke for an hour. He didn't cry: physically, he couldn't. But his voice broke three times, on small details, on phrases that seemed to carry no cost. Once when he mentioned a blue dress Diana had worn one Sunday. Another when he mentioned how she always reproached him. The third when he remembered the last time he had seen her, without saying anything to her, beside the window of the house.

NARRATION: Coltrane listened without interrupting. When Glenn finished (only then) he finally took off his coat. He laid it on the back of the chair. It was a small gesture, but it carried a precise weight: taking off the coat meant staying.

COLTRANE: *(after a long silence)* I ended up doing almost the same thing.

GLENN: How?

COLTRANE: With Annie. With my son.

NARRATION: Glenn didn't know how to process the information.

COLTRANE: Annie didn't want to see me again the moment she found out what I was.

GLENN: That I know.

COLTRANE: I watched the boy from a distance. I tried to speak to him once, when he was already a grown man, twice my apparent age. It didn't work.

(Long pause.)

COLTRANE: I didn't come to forgive you. I came to tell you that I no longer have the strength to keep up the grudge. But don't misread this.

GLENN: I don't.

COLTRANE: It is what it is.

NARRATION: Glenn accepted it. Coltrane sat down for the first time in the chair by the entryway. It was two in the morning. The radio was still on. Neither of them turned it off.

NARRATION: They talked until dawn. Not about Diana, or Annie, or the plantation: about small things. What each of them had been reading. A deep-sea fish that looked like it had come from another dimension. A painting Glenn had bought in March. The ash of a volcano in eruption. An Asian city in the thirties.

NARRATION: The conversation had the air of two men who have lived through an earthquake and are checking, without saying so, that the building is still standing.

NARRATION: When Coltrane left, before dawn, he didn't say "I'll come back." There was no need. He had taken off his coat. He didn't need to give any more signals.

NARRATION: He came back. Many times. For the rest of the centuries, Glenn would have him near. Not always in the same city, not always on the same continent, but always reachable. A call that was answered on the first ring. A letter that wasn't long in coming. Dinners spaced out, but real. The shape of a relationship that has been through the worst and has sat down at the table.

NARRATION: It was not tenderness. It was something rarer and, possibly, more lasting. They were two men who no longer had anything to hide from each other.

(FADE TO BLACK.)

PATH B — The distance

(Coltrane does not turn. Glenn looks at his back, his hand on the doorknob, and understands that he is not going to turn.)

COLTRANE: I don't know when I'm going to see you again.

GLENN: I understand.

COLTRANE: It may be years.

GLENN: ...

COLTRANE: It may be many years.

GLENN: ...

(Pause.)

COLTRANE: I'm not going to look for you. If we cross paths it will be because one of us happens to be in the same city as the other. Nothing more.

GLENN: I understand.

COLTRANE: Is that the only thing you know how to say tonight?

GLENN: Yes. I'm sorry.

NARRATION: Coltrane breathed. It was a strange breath: with a bit of laughter at the end, no joy in it. The laugh of someone who recognizes, in the middle of a dreadful situation, a small and exact truth.

COLTRANE: Good.

NARRATION: The word fell on Glenn again, as it had the two times before. This time, however, no concession came with it. It was a closing.

(Coltrane opens the door. He steps out. He closes it behind him with the same care he had used on the bell.)

(Glenn stays standing for a long while in the middle of the room. The glass he poured earlier is still where he left it. The radio keeps playing a piece he doesn't hear.)

NARRATION: That night Glenn did not sit down. He stayed on his feet, smoking, until the light began to come in through the east window.

NARRATION: When it came in, he put out the cigarette, turned off the radio, and went to the bedroom. He slept, for the first time in decades, the fourteen straight hours an immortal's body can sleep when there is nothing left for it to watch over.

NARRATION: When he woke, he was a different kind of man. Not better, not worse. Just different.

(Pause.)

NARRATION: The years went by without anyone counting them.

NARRATION: The first time they crossed paths was in Rome, on a narrow street near the Campo de' Fiori. Glenn was in a hurry. He saw him from behind and knew, without seeing his face, that it was him. Coltrane turned.

NARRATION: Their eyes met. Glenn thought for an instant that he was going to smile. Coltrane did not smile, but he nodded once. Glenn nodded back. They walked past each other.

NARRATION: That night, in the hotel, Glenn felt his chest burn with pain.

NARRATION: The next meeting was four years later in Istanbul. The one after, eight years on. The one

after that, two. There was no pattern.

NARRATION: Each time they greeted each other with a more complete gesture. The sixth time, they spoke. The seventh, they sat down together in a café. By then, enough decades had passed that neither of them was keeping count.

NARRATION: What was left between them was a relationship shaped like the things that survive a wound that never fully closed: warm, real, slightly fragile. With one millimeter of air between the two bodies that others might not notice, but that neither of them would ever cross.

(FADE TO BLACK.)

CHAPTER 1 — GLENN

The first encounter with Paul. *Spain, second half of the 20th century.*

NARRATION: To Glenn, geography had never been of any use. Cities were distinguished only by the language of their insults and the value of their currency. Hamburg was worth the same as Lyon, and Lyon the same as Trieste. He slept in rooms he would forget within a couple of years. He fed without hunger. He charged. He paid.

NARRATION: After Coltrane (who had become the only measure of time in his internal calendar) the map turned even more unintelligible. Certain streets suddenly carried more weight than others. Certain lights, at certain hours, would leave him paralyzed in the middle of a sidewalk without knowing why. He had reached the point of preferring not to ask himself. To answer would have meant admitting he was waiting for something, and Glenn had signed an unbreakable pact with himself: never again to expect anything from anyone.

NARRATION: How he ended up in Andalusia was a question for which he had no answer. He took a train south out of inertia. He got off at a station that was barely a wooden bench and a faded sign. He ordered a beer and a tapa he never touched, and stayed watching the olive trees on the other side of the tracks until the few local businesses in the area began to close. Afterward, he walked without direction. Not to explore, but to keep from rotting of boredom.

QUICK CUT — THE MARKET

NARRATION: The merchants were already packing up, calling it a day. Paul was on the other side, in front of a flower stall. He appeared to be almost thirty, by the biological clock that had stopped in him several centuries earlier. He was tall, fair-haired, with that specific serenity of men who have been beautiful for so long that they have forgotten they are.

NARRATION: What stopped Glenn was not the face, but something else: Paul was not looking at the flowers as he chose them. He was touching them. He passed his fingertips over the petals, tilted a stem, pressed the base to check its firmness. He was looking at a bouquet with his hands. Glenn had seen that kind of gesture before.

NARRATION: He came a little closer to confirm his suspicion. Paul's eyes were open and his head was oriented toward the stall, but the pupils did not move with the bouquets. They did not sweep. They did not correct the angle. They held still and stayed there, lacking the constant, involuntary microscopy

with which a living eye examines the world.

NARRATION: And there was one more detail, which Glenn would corroborate shortly afterward: they shone too much. The glint the streetlamps drew from them stayed fixed, characteristic of a polished surface that lacks the fine liquid film of a human eye. Glenn had seen them before, at a wedding in Prague, on a gentleman who had left his original eye in a trench. Prosthetic. Expensive. Well made. But prosthetic in the end.

NARRATION: Glenn registered the fact without reacting. People lost things all the time.

NARRATION: The vendor, an old woman with a kerchief on her head, turned toward him for an instant. She looked at him fixedly for a couple of seconds without apparent reason, and then went back to what she was doing. Glenn found it strange, but gave it no weight.

NARRATION: Paul paid for the bouquet of white gladioli. He refused the change. He turned toward the exit of the market and set off walking with a precision that struck Glenn as suspiciously sharp for a blind man. He walked as though Paul's body were following invisible instructions.

NARRATION: And Glenn, who had spent fifteen decades calculating every millimeter of his decisions, did something he had not planned. He approached the stall, pointed at some white lilies, left a few pesetas, and followed after him.

QUICK CUT — THE PATH

(PAUL walks ahead of GLENN at about forty paces' distance.)

NARRATION: It took Glenn a kilometer to understand that Paul knew he was being followed. Worse still: he was letting himself be followed. With the same indifference with which a man permits a stray dog to follow him home. Glenn found the detail mildly humiliating, but it did not alter his pace.

NARRATION: He noticed that Paul carried a long bundle on his back, wrapped in a woolen cloth that seemed older than the path itself.

NARRATION: What truly disconcerted Glenn, however, was the logistics of the journey. How did a blind man make his way through the olive grove without a cane and without help? He moved with an improbable exactness. Like a body calibrated to the millimeter. Paul negotiated the old roots with the naturalness of someone who walks from memory, which was plausible enough; but he also avoided the new stones, the ones the recent storms had just dragged into place. That was no longer memory. That was real-time information.

NARRATION: The only source of updated information on that specific stretch of the olive grove was Glenn's eyes, walking behind. Glenn did not yet manage to formulate that conclusion in that moment. He was still missing pieces to complete the puzzle.

QUICK CUT — THE TREE

(A clearing. An immense holm oak, the trunk split by the weight of the decades. A canopy that covers three times the area of a common tree; in daylight, the shade would draw a perfect circle on the ground.)

(At the foot of the holm oak lies what was once a stone slab. Four thick roots now surround it, forming a crown of living wood that embraces it without smothering it. The lichen does not grow on the stone: it has fused with it. A few engraved letters survive only barely beneath the wear. The grave seems a tiny petrified organism, breathing at a scale that human time does not register.)

(Paul kneels before it.)

NARRATION: He did so without hesitation. With his free hand, he felt the stone. He did not try to clean it. It gave Glenn the impression that this man had executed that same gesture so many times that the slab no longer required maintenance, only company.

(Paul lays down the white gladioli. He arranges them by sliding his fingers along the stems a couple of times until he finds the exact angle, and stops, satisfied. He rests his open palm on the slab and keeps silent.)

NARRATION: Glenn understood, without anyone needing to interpret it for him, that this was a prayer. An ancient prayer, unrehearsed, that lasted exactly as long as it needed to last.

NARRATION: Glenn had walked through enough cemeteries in his life. He had seen broken men and women before headstones, paying homage to buried bodies that, in their time, had been everything to them.

NARRATION: What did not square for Glenn in this scene were the temporal calculations. He himself had cared for (loved, even) people who were already dead. But he had discovered (and this he accepted with displeasure toward the end of the nineteenth century) that he was incapable of keeping that affection intact. Time had thinned it. In his mental architecture, nothing was capable of surviving more than a century.

NARRATION: The stone that man was touching had been rooted at the foot of the holm oak for centuries. The proportion between the antiquity of the grave and the composure of the fair-haired man kneeling before it escaped Glenn's logic. It was inconceivable. He did not understand how a love could refuse to die for so long.

QUICK CUT — THE GUITAR

NARRATION: After a long while, Paul withdrew his hand. He did not rise. He undid the thick folds of wool: it was a guitar. A guitar with more centuries behind it than any other Glenn had seen in his entire existence.

(Paul sits against the trunk, resting his back on the bark. He settles the guitar in his lap.)

NARRATION: He tuned the strings by ear. Thumb and forefinger of the left hand on each pair; the right hand plucking to confirm. One peg. Another peg. A quarter turn.

NARRATION: Glenn remained exactly where he was, several meters from the tree. He did not sit down; he did not know whether doing so would be disrespectful. He tried to be discreet. He noticed, with some irritation, that his own legs were not holding him with their usual firmness.

(Paul begins to play. A simple modal progression, four chords. Then the voice enters. Low, intimate, singing almost to himself.)

PAUL *(singing)*: "Though the fig tree does not blossom, nor fruit be on the vines..."

NARRATION: Glenn did not understand the words. He knew enough Spanish to get by, but not enough to parse poetry. He could not tell whether it was a folk song or a religious chant. What immobilized him, beyond the text, was the instrument of transmission: the voice.

NARRATION: It was the first time in two centuries that Glenn had heard anyone sing with that level of detachment. Without asking for attention, without projecting toward an audience. It was an immaculate, monastic voice, addressed neither to him nor to anyone breathing in that olive grove. It sang to the slab, to what lay beneath it, and to the holm oak.

NARRATION: Glenn's shoulders loosened without asking his permission. He did not know what had provoked the act. He only understood, on feeling the descent, that he had spent an eternity living with his muscles contracted, and that they had just yielded enough to leave him exposed.

(Paul continues. A second verse. Glenn remains petrified in the half-light.)

NARRATION: The piece was brief. And when it ended, it did so without formalities or any grandiloquent close. The last note simply vibrated in the air and went out.

(Silence.)

NARRATION: The silence that followed was not the discomfort of a stalled conversation. It was something else. A silence Glenn could not catalogue at once. It felt like the air of a room just after someone has, at last, finished a task they had been postponing indefinitely.

(Paul rests the guitar against the trunk with extreme care, searching for a safe angle so that it will not slip. He stands up. He turns toward Glenn.)

NARRATION: It was then that Glenn took in the eyes.

NARRATION: He confirmed what he had suspected in the market. They were prosthetics. Excellent for the period: meticulously replicated iris, symmetry between the two, a matte finish designed not to give itself away at three meters' distance. The pupils were the same size and did not respond to changes in light. They were painted, not alive. No two human eyes are identical. These were.

NARRATION: Glenn asked no questions. In the kind of existence both of them shared there was an unwritten protocol: at a first encounter between immortals, no one inquires about the wounds of the past.

NARRATION: What remained unexplained was the logistics: how did Paul see? But at this precise instant, through a triangulation Glenn would take some time to puzzle out, Paul was looking at himself using the redhead's eyes.

NARRATION: What Glenn was definitely not prepared for was the absolute austerity of the words he was about to hear.

PAUL: Paul.

(Pause.)

PAUL: That's my name.

NARRATION: He said it that way, without further adornment. No "I'm Paul," no "my name is Paul, and yours?" Only the bare given name, no surname, drawing a fence around himself.

NARRATION: Once again, it was not the semantics that paralyzed Glenn. It was the voice. The same one that had just sung to the grave, but now directed at him.

NARRATION: Glenn had spent two centuries cataloguing voices. Voices that lied, voices that begged for mercy, voices that gave orders, voices that negotiated interest rates. Paul's voice executed none of those transactions. It was placid, deep, without ulterior motive. It was the kind of sound designed to make a body with contracted muscles lower its guard without noticing. It was a voice on which one could build a home.

GLENN: *(trying to recover his composure, his voice slightly more roughened than usual)* Glenn.

(A pause.)

GLENN: Glenn Sheridan.

PAUL: *(barely sketching a smile; the voice shortening the distance between the two of them without taking a step)* A pleasure.

NARRATION: He said it with the courtesy of a man who has memorized the formula and executes it correctly. Glenn recognized the mechanism. But beneath the hollow courtesy, the timbre remained intact: calm, magnetic, unbearably serene.

NARRATION: In that instant he did not know it. But later he would understand that he was going to follow that sound to its last consequences. And that not a trace of dignity would remain on him by the end of the road.

PAUL: Are you going to do something with those flowers?

(Glenn looks down. He is still holding the bouquet in his hand. He had forgotten about it entirely.)

NARRATION: And then he saw it. What had left the old woman's stall as a handful of white lilies now carried an irregular sash of wildflowers. Yellow and white chamomile. Red poppies. Small green leaves clumsily caught on the main stems.

NARRATION: Glenn did not recognize the bouquet. He only recognized the lilies. He did not know at what godforsaken moment of the pursuit through the olive grove he had been picking those wildflowers to add to the arrangement. He looked up at Paul.

GLENN: No.

(Pause.)

PAUL: You don't have to bring them next time.

NARRATION: The sentence dismantled Glenn on three simultaneous fronts that took several seconds to align in his head.

NARRATION: The first offense: that Paul should take for granted there would be a next time, when Glenn had emitted no signal of return. The second: that Paul should treat that "next time" as a guaranteed meteorological phenomenon, as predictable as the next day of rain.

NARRATION: And the third, the most humiliating of all: that Glenn did intend to return. He had made the decision without asking permission of his own mind, and Paul had known it before he did.

QUICK CUT — THE HOUSE

(Paul orients his face toward a point beyond the clearing.)

NARRATION: Following the direction of that blind face, Glenn made out, some hundred meters from the holm oak, a low house among the olive trees. Whitewashed. The lime had gone so many years without upkeep that it had transitioned from white to an ashen ochre. The roof still held its tiles, except in one corner where the structure had given way. He could not tell whether the door still closed.

PAUL: That was our house.

GLENN: Ours?

PAUL: Yes. It belonged to the two of us. To her and to me.

NARRATION: Glenn linked the phrase to the stone slab. It was not difficult. He did it in silence.

GLENN: How long has it been?

(Paul exhales. He lets a short pause fall.)

PAUL: A long time.

NARRATION: The word "long" in the mouth of an immortal dragged a very different weight than it would in an ordinary conversation. It carried a disproportionate weight. But Paul did not enter into detail, and Glenn (who was not in the habit of forcing anyone) did not demand that he elaborate.

NARRATION: Glenn looked again at the ruined house among the branches. And as he did, an unsolicited thought arrived: he thought they had been happy there. That it was a happy house. That the routine of genuine joy steeped into the walls and does not fade even when the bodies disappear.

NARRATION: And then he thought that he himself had never lived a happiness like that one. That his human life on the outskirts of Richmond had been a strident simulacrum. That that kind of peace was one more casualty in the catalogue of his own existence.

NARRATION: Paul did not suggest that they approach. Glenn did not propose it either.

QUICK CUT — THE IMAGES

(The distance between the two men is slight. Three paces. Four at most.)

PAUL: Let me show you something.

GLENN: What?

PAUL: Things that happened. Some, as I remember them. Others, as I believe they happened.

NARRATION: He made the distinction in passing, without emphasis. In that moment, Glenn did not understand where the difference lay. He would understand later.

NARRATION: The first image that assaulted Glenn's mind possessed the unquestionable texture of human memory.

(A monastery in a Nordic forest. The rough grain of wood on doors. The keen cold of a cell at dawn. An olfactory mixture of melting wax, damp, and the distant scent of a stew. The vibration of a bell. A fair-haired child going over Latin declensions at a desk that stood too tall for him, the soles of his feet freezing against the stone.)

NARRATION: It was an architecture of brutal sensations: temperature, taste, the stomach contracted in expectation of breakfast. Glenn assimilated them with the intrusive sharpness of a memory of his own.

NARRATION: Then the geography changed.

(A coastal plain. Limestone reverberating beneath a sun that fell straight down, with an almost physical weight. A group of prisoners bound in a courtyard. A Saracen approaching with a straight razor. The scrape of steel against skin. The beard falling onto the pale stone. And a disembodied voice, whispering in a language Glenn translated without knowing how: "Now you no longer look like a barbarian.")

(Immediately afterward, an upright figure standing before Paul, framed from the perspective of someone who still possessed his own eyes.)

NARRATION: Then the transmission cut. Dry, violent, like the slam of a safe door. Glenn did not see what happened next. There was no need. He understood that access to that portion was forbidden to him.

NARRATION: And when the images returned, the texture had changed entirely.

NARRATION: Glenn did not know how to catalogue what he was seeing. It was like going from a sharp photograph to a hyperrealist painting. The intensity did not diminish (sometimes it was even

greater) but it presented structural deficiencies: the visual periphery was missing. The white noise of the environment was missing. The textures had a finish too meticulous, polished, as though someone had composed the scene from secondhand descriptions rather than having lived it.

NARRATION: He saw a woman in a bed. Very old. Papery skin, eyes closed, hands at rest on the sheets. No rings. No object that would allow a date, a name, or a place to be fixed. The room was even, small, the curtains drawn. Glenn understood that this mutilated frame was all he would be permitted to know of her. The rest belonged to Paul.

NARRATION: Then he witnessed the most unsettling fragment of all. Paul's face shedding tears of blood, seen from an external angle.

NARRATION: An immediate discomfort assailed Glenn. That face in the memory bore no prostheses of bone: it had blue eyes, living. Human eyes. Glenn took a moment to process the discrepancy, until the gravity of the fact settled in: he was seeing Paul exactly as Paul believed he still existed. Whenever the German's mind needed to project his own image, it reached for the version of himself at twenty-seven. Despite the centuries, despite the amputation, that young human was the only tenant inhabiting the depths of his psyche.

NARRATION: He saw the tree. A shovel. A silhouette wrapped in what looked like a shroud, descending into the grave. And then, the centuries compressed into the span of seconds: the trunk of the holm oak widening, ring by ring; the roots dragging themselves toward the slab until they formed the crown; the lichen blooming and then being assimilated into the stone; the dirt path dissolving beneath the undergrowth and forming again.

NARRATION: Afterward, a succession of minor gestures, scattered across the map. A hand sliding an envelope under a door. Another checking the fever on a child's forehead. A signature traced on the back of a check with no recipient. An anonymous clerk filing a record. A row of beds in a hospital room. Blurred faces that did not remain long enough to be remembered.

NARRATION: He saw an immense desert, of a dry and blinding white, on another continent. He saw a man digging a hole in it. He saw the descent into a prolonged darkness, without dreams.

NARRATION: And at the end, without warning, the texture of the transmission shifted again. It did not return to the sensory sharpness of the first memories. It was an image anchored in the present, with absolute peripheral detail: the bustle of a market, the residual smell of frying, the dampness of cut flowers, but from an angle that struck Glenn as wrong.

NARRATION: It was the flower stall. But not from Paul's perspective.

NARRATION: The view came from behind the counter. The vendor's hand rested on the bouquet of gladioli in the foreground. And as the visual field turned, on the other side of the market, framed against a whitewashed wall, a man appeared dressed in too much clothing for the local climate. Red hair tied back. Hands in his pockets. Watching.

NARRATION: Glenn saw himself. And in that instant, the puzzle collapsed, two certainties slotting into place at once.

NARRATION: The first: the angle from which he was seeing himself was the angle of the old vendor, which at the time had seemed coincidental to him (it was not). The second: Paul, with an almost humiliating efficiency, had been using him as a human guide dog to navigate the topography of the olive grove.

(The transmission cuts dry. The clearing returns. The night air. The slab at the foot of the trunk. The guitar resting against the bark.)

NARRATION: Glenn had not moved a muscle.

PAUL: Now you know who I am.

(Pause.)

PAUL: They are memories. Or memories of memories. The division strikes me as somewhat blurred at times.

GLENN: Why have you shown me all of this?

(Pause.)

PAUL: I don't know.

NARRATION: Those three words were what disturbed Glenn most that afternoon. Not the images (which would take him weeks to process), but the sentence. He had before him a man who surpassed him by centuries, a being with all the time in the world to orchestrate grandiloquent speeches and rehearse perfect excuses, and he had chosen to deliver, without any kind of makeup, an "I don't know." He had said it with the sincerity of someone who, in fact, had no answer.

NARRATION: Something cracked in Glenn's chest. He did not know what mechanism had given way.

NARRATION: It was the preliminary warning. The first symptom of a miscalculation that was going to cost him exceedingly dear.

QUICK CUT — THE DEPARTURE

(Paul bends down and picks up the guitar. He wraps it again in the same old wool, with rhythmic movements, without thinking them through. He shoulders the bundle.)

NARRATION: Before leaving the clearing, he stopped. He did not bother to turn around.

PAUL: As I said earlier, there is no need to bring flowers next time. The ones I bring will be enough.

NARRATION: Glenn registered the sentence. And he stored it away as one of the two or three most generous things anyone had ever granted him in his entire existence.

NARRATION: Paul set off walking among the olive trees. Glenn closed his eyes for a second. When he opened them again, the path was already empty.

QUICK CUT — THE WAY BACK

(Glenn walks alone, returning to the town. The bouquet still hangs from his hand. He had forgotten entirely that he was carrying it.)

NARRATION: Before reaching the first houses, he stopped at the side of the road. He lowered his eyes to the flowers.

NARRATION: Without any forethought, he began to dismember the arrangement. The white lilies (the legitimate flowers, the purchased ones) he laid in the ditch by the road, anchoring them with a small stone so the night wind would not scatter them. The chamomile and the wild poppies stayed in his hand. He did not know why.

NARRATION: He thought, with that reluctant clarity proper to things one does not want to admit, of what would come next: that he was going to return. He did not know when or under what pretext, but he would fabricate some excuse, and that excuse would be obviously false. And Paul would know it from the first second.

NARRATION: He thought that in two hundred years of immortality no one had managed to pierce his defenses in that way. And a man of whom he knew almost nothing had just dismantled him in a single night. He intuited that the whole affair was a violation of some fundamental rule of his own being, but he could not name which one.

NARRATION: He thought, finally, that he had no choice but to learn to carry it. Bearing weight had always been the one skill in which he excelled naturally, without having wanted it and without having asked for it.

(Glenn's rented room. The light is meager.)

NARRATION: He carried the wildflowers to the room where he was lodging. He did not look for a vase with water. He did not throw them in the trash. He laid them on the wooden table and stood looking at them, in silence, for a length of time he did not bother to measure.

(FADE TO BLACK.)

FEEDBACK FORM

<https://forms.gle/3QTSjRcBZWmLhrjH9>